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An IDEV **Country Strategy Evaluation**

# Mauritania:

# Evaluation of the AfDB's Country Strategy and Program (2011-2020)

## Summary Report

AFRICAN DEVELOPMENT BANK GROUP

February 2023

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February 2023

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**Mauritania: Evaluation of the AfDB's Country Strategy and Program (2011-2020) - Summary Report**
IDEV Country Strategy Evaluation, February 2023




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The overarching objective of the African Development Bank Group is to spur sustainable economic development and social progress in its regional member countries (RMCs), thus contributing to poverty reduction. The Bank Group achieves this objective by mobilizing and allocating resources for investment in RMCs and providing policy advice and technical assistance to support development efforts.

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The mission of Independent Development Evaluation at the AfDB is to enhance the development effectiveness of the institution in its regional member countries through independent and instrumental evaluations and partnerships for sharing knowledge.


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# Acronyms and Abbreviations

| | |
|---|---|
| ADF | African Development Fund |
| ADFD | Abu Dhabi Fund for Development |
| AFD | French Development Agency |
| AfDB | African Development Bank Group |
| AFESD | Arab Fund for Economic and Social Development |
| BCI | Banque pour le Commerce et l'Industrie (Bank for Trade and Industry) |
| BPM | Banque populaire de la Mauritanie (People's Bank of Mauritania) |
| CLTS | Community-Led Total Sanitation |
| CMYP | Comprehensive Multiyear Plan |
| CNE | National Water Council |
| CODE | Committee on Development and Operations Effectiveness |
| CPCNE | Permanent Committee of the National Water Council |
| CRE | Regional Water Council |
| CSP | Country Strategy Paper |
| CSPE | Country Strategy and Programme Evaluation |
| DAD | Development Assistance Database |
| DWSS | Drinking Water Supply and sanitation |
| ECGF | Governance and Public Financial Management Coordination Office |
| EIG | Economic Interest Groups |
| ESAP | Environmental and Social Assessment Procedures |
| ESCON | Environmental and Social Compliance Note |
| ESMP | Environmental and Social Management Plan |
| ESW | Economic and Sector Work |
| EU | European Union |
| FIRM | Resource Mobilization and Partnerships Department |
| GCI-VII | 7th General Capital Increase |
| GDP | Gross Domestic Product |
| GIZ | German Agency for International Cooperation |
| GNI | Gross National Income |
| HDI | Human Development Index |
| IDEV | Independent Development Evaluation |
| IFAD | International Fund for Agricultural Development |
| IMF | International Monetary Fund |
| IOP | Indicative Operations Programme |
| IPR | Implementation and Results Report |
| IRENA | International Renewable Energy Agency |
| IsDB | Islamic Development Bank |
| IWRMP | Integrated Water Resources Management Project |
| LIMR | Liaison Office in Mauritania |
| LoC | Line of Credit |
| MAEPSP | Ministry of Economic Affairs and Productive Sector Promotion |
| MFI | Microfinance Institution |
| MRO | Mauritanian Ouguiya |
| MRU | New Mauritanian Ouguiya |
| MSE | Micro and Small Enterprise |
| MTEF | Medium-Term Expenditure Framework |
| MTR | Mid-Term Review |
| NSO | Non-Sovereign Operation |
| NTF | Nigeria Trust Fund |
| ODA | Official Development Assistance |
| OECD | Organisation for Economic Cooperation and Development |
| OMVS | Senegal River Basin Development Organization |
| ONAS | National Sanitation Authority |
| OPEC | Organisation of Petroleum Exporting Countries |

| | |
|---|---|
| **PAGIP** | Public Investment Management Support Project |
| **PAGOCI** | Governance Support Project for Inclusive Growth Promotion |
| **PAHABO** | Hydro-agricultural Development Project in West Brakna |
| **PAREDE** | Economic Reforms and Diversification Support Programme |
| **PATAM** | Mauritania - Agricultural Transformation Support Project |
| **PBO** | Programme-Based Operation |
| **PCR** | Project Completion Report |
| **PGRF** | Risk Management Function of the Bank Group |
| **PIU** | Project Implementation Unit |
| **PMF** | Women's Vegetable Production Gardening Areas |
| **PNDA** | National Agricultural Development Plan |
| **PNDE** | National Livestock Development Plan |
| **PNDEA** | National Livestock and Agricultural Development Plan |
| **PNISER** | National Integrated Rural Water Sector Project |
| **PPP** | Purchasing Power Parity |
| **PRECAMF** | Project to Build the Capacities of Microfinance Operators |
| **PRSP** | Poverty Reduction Strategy Paper |
| **PTSB** | Staff Benefits Plan Administration Unit Retirement & Medical Plans |
| **RBCSP** | Results-Based Country Strategy Paper |
| **RDGN** | North Africa Regional Department |
| **REVUWI** | Project for Improving Climate Resilience of Water Sector Investments through Appropriate Climate Adaptation Activities for Pastoral and Forestry Resources in Southern Mauritania |
| **RIPS** | Regional Integration Policy and Strategy |
| **RISP** | Regional Integration Strategy Paper |
| **RWSSI** | Rural Water Supply and Sanitation Initiative |
| **SAP PS** | SAP Project System |
| **SCAPP** | National Accelerated Growth and Shared Prosperity Strategy |
| **SEIA** | Summary Environmental Impact Assessments |
| **SME** | Small and Medium-Sized Enterprise |
| **SNADEA** | National Strategy for Sustainable Access to Water and Sanitation for 2030 |
| **SNDR** | Development Impact and Results Department |
| **SNIM** | National Industrial and Mining Company |
| **SNSC** | Environmental and Social Safeguards and Compliance Department |
| **SRF** | Special Relief Fund |
| **TFP** | Technical and Financial Partner |
| **TSF** | Transition Support Facility |
| **UA**[1] | Unit of Account |
| **UAM** | Million Units of Account |
| **UNDP** | United Nations Development Programme |
| **UNS** | United Nations System |
| **USD** | United States Dollar |
| **WB** | World Bank |
| **WFP** | World Food Programme |

1 1 Unit of Account (UA) = 1.40080 United States Dollars (USD) = 50.57 New Mauritanian Ouguiyas (MRU) as of 6 December 2021

# Executive Summary

## Introduction

Located in North-West Africa, Mauritania is the continent's 11th largest country with a low population density of 4 inhabitants/km². The country has a population of 4.6 million inhabitants, 56.9% of whom live in urban areas, with a life expectancy of 65.1 years in 2020, which is above the African average (63 years), but below the North Africa average (74 years).

This evaluation of the country strategy and programme of the African Development Bank Group (AfDB or 'the Bank') for Mauritania follows the previous evaluation covering the 1994-2004 period. It covers the 2011-2020 period, in particular the Results-Based Country Strategy Paper (RBCSP) 2011-2015 and the Country Strategy Paper (CSP) 2016-2020. The latter was updated and extended to December 2022 by the Bank in April 2021 in order "to align its next CSP for the country with the 2016-2030 Accelerated Growth and Shared Prosperity Strategy (SCAPP) action plan for the second period (2021-2025), whose implementation has been delayed due to the outbreak of the COVID-19 pandemic and to guarantee the relevance of the current CSP to efforts to address the health crisis." This extension period is not covered by this evaluation, whose data collection and analysis work had already been completed in August 2021.

## National Development Framework

In 2020, the Government prepared a Poverty Reduction Strategy Paper (PRSP) covering the 2001-2015 period that aims to lay the foundations of accelerated and sustained economic growth that would create jobs, reduce unemployment, and sustainably improve the population's quality of life. Its 2011-2015 Five-Year Action Plan, which had four strategic thrusts and one cross-cutting thrust, served as the basis for the Bank's RBCSP 2011-2015. In 2016, the Government adopted SCAPP 2016-2030 to address challenges that persisted following the completion of PRSP 2011-2015. Its aim is to strengthen economic resilience and promote inclusive (or shared) economic growth. For each of these three strategic levers, the Government defined priority areas on which CSP 2016-2020 was based.

## Bank's Assistance and Implementation Context

During RBCSP 2011-2015, the Bank's assistance was intended to "contribute to the achievement of Mauritania's priority objectives focused on strengthening the competitiveness of the economy and poverty reduction" through two strategic pillars, namely: i) infrastructure development; and ii) improved economic and financial governance. During CSP 2016-2020, Bank assistance focused on i) promoting agricultural transformation (Pillar I), and ii) increasing power supply (Pillar II), in order to achieve the key objective of "helping Mauritania to achieve inclusive and green growth" in order to improve the living conditions of the people (or to achieve shared prosperity). As at 31 December 2020, the Bank had financed 24 projects in Mauritania over the 2011-2020 period, worth UA 154.26 million (USD 215,96 million in December 2021), in 7 sectors of intervention: industry, mines and quarries, transport, agriculture, finance, the multisector, water and sanitation and the social sector. The volume of approvals quintupled from one CSP to the next. The average envelope per project has increased by 141%, from UA 2.5 million to UA 6 million. The African Development Fund (ADF) financed 54.5% of all operations. The Government's counterpart contribution was UA 12.1 million. Absent during the RBCSP 2011-2015, the private sector grew during

CSP 2016-2020 and represented 34.7% of approvals for the entire evaluation period (2011-2020). Co-financed projects amounted to UA 195.4 million, backed by a UA 19.7 million ADF contribution.

While the country benefited from a favourable economic context at the start of RBCSP 2011-2015, this was not the case for CSP 2016-2020, which was marked by a drop in the price of iron ore, the country's main export product. The external trade deficit widened during the evaluation period. The situation deteriorated in early 2020 following the outbreak of the COVID-19 pandemic, whose impact on the country exceeded the African average. Economic activity fell by 3.6%. The budget surplus of the previous year gave way to a budget deficit. Foreign direct investment inflows fell sharply by almost 63%. However, GDP per capita and gross national income per capita grew steadily over the evaluation period. The incidence of poverty declined while the Human Development Index score improved over the years, from 0.453 in 2011 to 0.546 in 2019. However, income distribution remained unequal with a Gini coefficient of 32.6 in 2014.

### Evaluation Purpose and Objectives

The purpose of this evaluation is to enable the Bank's management to: i) report to stakeholders on the outcomes achieved with the resources provided; and ii) improve its development effectiveness through lessons learned, particularly to guide the preparation and implementation of the next CSP 2023-2027 for Mauritania. The specific objective of this Country Strategy and Programme Evaluation (CSPE) is to assess the relevance of the Bank's assistance to Mauritania, including its selectivity, the effectiveness of its strategies and programmes in the country and their contribution to the achievement of national development goals, their sustainability, internal and internal coherence, efficiency, and mainstreaming of cross-cutting issues.

This summary report is supplemented by a second volume comprising technical annexes.

## Methodology and Limitations

The evaluation was guided by eight questions centred on the criteria of relevance, effectiveness, sustainability, internal and external coherence, efficiency, mainstreaming of cross-cutting issues and learning. Each evaluation criterion and sub-criterion is rated on a clearly defined four-point scale: highly satisfactory, satisfactory, partly unsatisfactory, and unsatisfactory. The evaluation team consulted stakeholders during the design stage of this evaluation to promote the use of its findings. Due to COVID-19 travel restrictions, evaluation data was collected through online interviews and the review of existing documentation (Bank's corporate and project documents) and the Bank's project database (SAP Project System). Project task managers at the Bank's headquarters and other colleagues at the Bank's North Africa Region involved in operation implementation provided electronic inputs in the form of implementation data, comments on evaluation findings and reviews of draft preliminary reports. Evaluation sub-questions concerning cost-benefit and cost-effectiveness analysis have remained unanswered due to lack of data. However, the quality of the CSPE is intact as data has been provided for the key indicators, resulting in well-documented evaluation findings.

This executive summary presents the evaluation findings based on criteria grouped under two broad concerns: What is the Bank's contribution to Mauritania's development outcomes, and how did the Bank design and manage its operations in the country? It then draws lessons from implementation of the assistance and makes recommendations for improvement to the Bank's Management.

## Bank Contribution to Development Outcomes

**The relevance of the Bank's strategies and programs was rated satisfactory.** The relevance of the CSPs to the country's priorities was highly satisfactory, as all the pillars of the CSPs are aligned. The programming of assistance for the 2011-2015 and 2016-2020 periods coincided with the introduction of a new national reference framework, respectively the PRSP 2011-2015 and SCAPP 2016-2030. Among the 24 projects approved over the period, 87.2% have their objectives aligned with one of the components of national strategies, which is satisfactory. All the pillars of the CSPs and related projects/programmes were aligned with the Bank's own strategic priorities, in particular the following: Industrialise Africa; Improve Quality of Life for the People of Africa; Feed Africa; and Integrate Africa, which is highly satisfactory. In contrast, the involvement of civil society, beneficiaries, the private sector and universities, which is necessary to take their concerns into account, has been found partly unsatisfactory. It was limited to the validation of strategic choices during policy dialogue as part of CSP preparation missions. The country has multinational projects, but few of them are directly and explicitly linked to the Bank's most recent regional strategy that covers the period 2020-2026. The Bank's selectivity was rated satisfactory. Taking into account the mid-term adjustment of the second CSP, it emerges that the Bank intervened with projects in the six areas of results for which it has a comparative advantage, out of the seven areas targeted in that CSP. However, no project to improve access to electricity in rural and urban areas was approved, despite this outcome being targeted in the two CSPs. Implementation of the Indicative Operational Programme (IOP) was rated satisfactory because seven of the eleven projects slated at CSP approval were approved (63.63%). The five emergency assistance operations approved over the period helped address floods (2012, 2014, and 2019) or COVID-19 response needs.[1] The Bank conducted 6 unplanned economic and sector works (ESWs) and 5 of the 8 planned ESWs.

**The effectiveness of the Bank's strategies and programmes was rated satisfactory.** At CSP national level, effectiveness was rated satisfactory with two of the four objectives achieved as follows. During the 2011-2015 period, the economy was less competitive than expected. The competitiveness index score declined from 3.14 to 3.0 between the beginning and end of the period under consideration. However, poverty was reduced as planned from a rate of 42% in 2008 to 31% in 2014. Extreme rural poverty declined from 40.8% to 25.1% over the same period. Over the 2016-2020 period, the country partly achieved the objective of a more inclusive and greener growth. The economy grew at a GDP growth rate, excluding extractive industries, that rose from 1.6% in 2016 to 5% in 2018. The percentage of wage earners rose from 42.8% in 2016 to 43.8% in 2019, which suggests inclusive growth. The percentage of vulnerable jobs declined from 54% to 52%. Regarding green growth, the proportion of renewable energy in the energy mix rose from 13.37% in 2015 to 41% in 2018. It was expected to reach 50% following new construction work, but that objective was not achieved as the Bank did not finance any operations in the sub-sector due to a lack of resources. In contrast, effectiveness at pillar level was rated partly unsatisfactory, with 42.8% of objectives achieved and 27.2% of expected outputs delivered or expected to be. Community access to drinking water increased, and the institutional capacities of government services were strengthened, but the business climate did not improve sufficiently to have the expected positive impact on the economy's competitiveness. In addition, failure to implement the project to increase power supply was a limiting factor that prevented the expected improvement of the economy's competitiveness. Overall, implementation of the IOPs was satisfactory (50-64%). Operational performance was rated satisfactory since almost 60% of expected outputs were achieved or deemed achievable.

The following factors contributed to these outcomes: (a) The Bank was unable to assist the country in removing obstacles that cause frequent delays and lengthen implementation periods, due among others, to irregular project supervision. Over half of the projects were extended at least once; (b) There is a strong synergy between Bank operations and those of other TFPs with more resources, especially in energy, agriculture, public governance, and financial sector development, which contributed to the achievement of poverty reduction and inclusive and green growth outcomes; (c) There are shortcomings in the CSP theory of change, especially regarding the linkage of outcomes at national, pillar and operation levels; (d) Effectiveness at pillar level over time improved with an output delivery rate that rose from 17.8% in 2011-2015 to 27.2% in 2016-2020, thanks to, inter alia, adjustments to the pillars or IOPs following mid-term reviews, the physical presence of a resident country programme officer starting in 2018, and the intensification of dialogue with the national authorities which made it possible to adapt to changes in context and remove obstacles to the implementation of operations.

**The sustainability of the Bank's programmes and strategies was rated satisfactory overall, but some aspects continue to require further attention.** The achievements of all completed or closed projects were sustained or deemed sustainable. All the projects for the period involved target communities, and their Project Implementation Units (PIU) were integrated into the services of the oversight Ministry, thus increasing the level of ownership by beneficiaries. However, only 33.3% of these projects had implemented a mechanism to ensure the sustainability of achievements and the mobilisation of revenue to finance recurrent costs, although this was planned in the design of 5 of the 6 projects completed or closed and in 10 of the 16 ongoing projects. As regards capacity-building, only 42.9% of projects had implemented one or more related activities. Concerning the implementation of environmental and social safeguards in category I & II projects, it should be noted that 20%, 28.6% and 33.3% of these projects respectively documented the implementation of the agreed measures, secured a budget to finance the monitoring of their implementation, and effectively appointed an officer to monitor their implementation located at the PIU. These weak links in the Bank's exit strategy require strengthening in order to provide the necessary guarantee that the outcomes of the Bank's assistance in the country will be sustained.

## How did the Bank design and manage its assistance?

**The coherence of the Bank's interventions was rated satisfactory.** Of the 19 Bank projects (excluding the five emergency assistance operations), 17 complemented each other (internal coherence). Furthermore, all Bank projects were complementary with the operations of at least two development partners active in Mauritania (external coherence). For example, the Rosso Bridge Construction Project, which connects the country with Senegal and has strong national and regional economic development potential, is jointly financed by the Bank, the European Investment Bank (EIB), the European Union (EU) and the States of Senegal and Mauritania. In the agricultural sector, the Bank has aligned its projects and emergency assistance operations with the operations of the World Bank focused on livestock through structuring projects (Regional Sahel Pastoralism Support Project - PRAPS, USD 45 million). Other institutions have done likewise, including the EU (RIMRAP, RIMDIR and RIMFIL projects), GIZ (Project for the Promotion of Employment and Professional Integration in Rural Areas (PELIMIR) and AFD (*CAP Insertion*).

**The efficiency of the Bank's strategies and programmes was rated satisfactory.** The number of operations rose from 11 to 21 between CSP 2011-2015 and CSP 2016-2020, and the volume of approvals quintupled from UA 27.5 million to UA 126.7 million. The average envelope per project rose from UA 2.5 million to 6.0 million. The country is therefore mobilising more and more resources, as it had planned to obtain UA 95.52 million during CSP 2016-2020 and raised UA 126.75 million, i.e. 1.32 times its performance-based allocation (PBA). For all completed or closed projects, the budgets allocated were adhered to (100%). However, only half the projects completed or closed adhered to the implementation deadlines. The disbursement rate for ongoing projects is 35.6% for an average age of 3.5 years, which is unsatisfactory. Two bottlenecks are affecting operational efficiency, namely pre-implementation delays and a low disbursement rate. Problems exist at both country and Bank levels. The Bank has been unable to eliminate these impediments to smooth implementation, partly due to irregular project supervision.

**Mainstreaming of cross-cutting issues was rated partly unsatisfactory.** Specific objectives were set for certain cross-cutting issues in some of the 24 projects approved during the 2011-2020 period. Youth employment and climate change adaptation and/or mitigation were an objective in three (12.5%) and five (20.8%) projects respectively. Although one specific gender promotion objective appeared in two projects (8.3%), 16 others (66.7%) implemented various gender equality and women's promotion activities (quota, targeted activities, inclusion of specific indicators in the results-based logical framework, etc.). Addressing fragility was a specific objective in four projects (16.7%), which is low, considering that the Bank carried out a preliminary study on the drivers of fragility and opportunities for resilience. Private sector development was the objective of four projects (16.7%), and the Bank has financed five non-sovereign operations in the country for a total of UA 53.5 million, i.e. 35% of the country's resource allocation.

## Lessons

**Lesson 1:** In countries with low PBAs, additional Bank resources are successfully leveraged when the regional and/or country team implements a pro-active strategy.

Between the RBCSP 2011-2015 and CSP 2016-2020, the volume of approvals quintupled and the average envelope per project increased by 141%. Considering the IOP at approval and the adjustment made at CSP 2016-2020 mid-term, Mauritania planned to obtain UA 95.52 million to finance operations over the period. It succeeded in raising UA 126.75 million, i.e. 1.32 times its PBA.

**Lesson 2:** The private sector is a key driver of the country's development.

While there was no private sector operation in Mauritania's RBCSP 2011-2015, it only required five operations during CSP 2016-2020 (one direct loan, two lines of credit and two guarantees) for the private sector to represent 34.7% of approvals for the entire evaluation period (2011-2020). For example, the direct loan for the National Industrial and Mining Company (SNIM) dredging project contributed to the objectives of developing the mining sector by increasing exports of iron ore, the country's main source of foreign exchange. SNIM has become one of the world's leading iron ore producers. In addition, lines of credit and guarantees to Banque Populaire de Mauritanie (BPM) and the Bank for Trade and Industry (BCI) have helped to increase financing for Mauritanian small and medium-sized enterprises (SMEs) in industry, mining, fisheries, trade, and transport.

**Lesson 3:** The careful selection of sectors of intervention and systematic alignment of Bank projects with the operations of the main development partners in the country (external coherence) contributes significantly to the effectiveness of a strategy aimed at mobilizing more financing and achieve national development objectives.

- Social and economic infrastructure as well as governance are the main sectors of intervention, as they absorbed about half of the Official Development Assistance envelope received by the country. By targeting these sectors, the Bank was able to leverage UA 175.7 million from co-financiers for projects worth a total of UA 195.4 million over the period, including UA 19.7 million from the ADF; i.e., a leverage effect of 1 to 8.9.

- As presented above under the heading 'effectiveness', one of the two national objectives set in CSP 2016-2020 and one of the two objectives of RBCSP 2011-2015 were achieved even though the Bank had not completely delivered the outputs expected at the pillar level during the period. In fact, the outcomes of operations are more closely aligned with national outcomes than pillar outcomes. The contribution of the other development partners (USD 3,697.5 million in 2019, of which the Bank provided 3.4%) was significant, and their strong complementarity with the Bank's operations expedited the direct translation of the Bank operations' outcomes into outcomes targeted at national level.

**Lesson 4:** Operations' effectiveness does not guarantee the achievement of the expected outcomes at the various higher levels.

Operations' achievements did not translate into achievement of the expected pillar outcomes. In other words, implementation of the operations did not sufficiently contribute to the attainment of pillar outcomes to fulfil the theory of change of Bank assistance. This situation reflects the weaknesses already noted in the theory of change of Bank assistance, in particular the reliability and feasibility of the causal chain between the outcomes defined at the three levels during programming (national outcomes, pillar outcomes, IOP and operations' outcomes).

## Recommendations

**Recommendation 1:** Improve the articulation between the targeted objectives at national and pillar levels and the expected results of the operations programmed in the country assistance strategy, taking into consideration:

a) the reliability and feasibility (in the actual country context) of the results chain (causal relationship) between the three levels of action: operations, pillar and national; b) the volatility resulting from frequent IOP changes; c) the lifespan of operations programmed in the IOP in selecting the planning horizon for the expected CSP results; and d) adequate sizing of the CSP's targeted results relative to the estimated resource allocation to finance operations in the country over the period.

**Recommendation 2:** Ensure that the rhythm of two supervisions per year is adhered to.

On these occasions, the timely provision of the necessary sector specialists and budget could help to remove the impediments to the smooth implementation of operations (insufficient familiarity with the Bank's applicable rules and procedures, poor quality of disbursement requests, delays in mobilising counterpart funds, lack of diligence in the procurement procedure; etc.). These more regular supervisions can also provide opportunities to guide and advise national stakeholders and possibly hold fiduciary clinics and in-situ training sessions.

**Recommendation 3:** Foresee mechanisms that ensure the sustainability of benefits right from the design of Bank operations and monitor their effective implementation.

Currently planned mechanisms, such as cost-recovery to finance the recurrent costs of community infrastructure and equipment as well as building local ownership and participation capacities (exit strategy), must be effectively implemented to ensure the sustainability of the Bank's impact on the country's development.

**Recommendation 4:** Improve the mainstreaming of cross-cutting issues in the CSPs and the Bank's operations.

In particular promotion of gender equality and women's empowerment, youth employment, fragility and resilience, climate change adaptation and mitigation, and private sector development. It is recommended to include specific objectives at the design stage, especially in results-based logical frameworks, modelled on the Bank's gender marker system, so that these cross-cutting issues are at the core of all stakeholders' activities during the implementation of operations. This integration mechanism could be complemented by other arrangements. ■


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# Management's Response

**Overall, Management welcomes the results of the evaluation conducted by the Independent Development Evaluation Department (IDEV) on the African Development Bank's strategies and programmes in Mauritania during the 2011-2020 period. Management agrees with the evaluation's lessons, conclusions, and four main recommendations, which are consistent with the findings of project monitoring and supervision missions and portfolio performance reviews. The evaluation recommendations will inform the design of the new country strategy for the 2023-2027 period and will guide the implementation of current operations and the design of future operations.**

## Introduction

The Independent Development Evaluation Department has finalized the evaluation of the African Development Bank's strategies and programmes in Mauritania over the 2011-2020 period. During this period, the Bank developed two country strategy papers: the Results-Based Country Strategy Paper (RBCSP) 2011-2015 and the updated Country Strategy Paper (CSP) 2016-2020 extended to December 2022. Under RBCSP 2011-2015, the Bank's assistance was aimed at "contributing to the achievement of Mauritania's priority objectives of strengthening the competitiveness of the economy and reducing poverty" through two strategic pillars, namely: i) infrastructure development; and ii) the improvement of economic and financial governance. As for CSP 2016-2020 for Mauritania, approved on 6 September 2016, its main objective was "to help Mauritania achieve more inclusive and green growth" in order to improve the living conditions of the population (or shared prosperity) and it focused on the following two pillars: i) promotion of agricultural transformation; and ii) expansion of electricity supply. It underwent a mid-term review approved in January 2019, with a partial reorientation of Pillar 2 to enhance the impact of and fallout from Pillar 1. Thus, pillars 1 and 2 for the 2019-2022 period were respectively: i) "promotion of agricultural sector transformation"; and ii) "strengthening of agricultural infrastructure."

The evaluation found that the overall relevance, effectiveness, coherence, and efficiency of the Bank's strategies and programmes during the period under review were satisfactory, although efforts are still needed to improve i) the alignment of results at the country, pillar, and operational levels (theory of change); and ii) the involvement of civil society, beneficiaries, the private sector, and academia.

The evaluation rated the sustainability of Bank operations during the period under review as satisfactory on the whole. However, certain aspects still require more attention. These include: i) consideration of the exit strategy in order to guarantee the continuity of Bank assistance in the country; and ii) project implementation deadlines that are not always met.

In contrast, the evaluation deemed the mainstreaming of cross-cutting issues to be partly unsatisfactory. These issues include gender promotion and women's empowerment; youth employment; fragility and resilience; climate change adaptation and mitigation; and private sector development.

Management agrees with these evaluation findings and recommendations. Indeed, issues of private sector development, investment efficiency, sustainability of operations, and mainstreaming of cross-cutting aspects were included in the completion report of CSP 2016-2020 extended to 2022.

Management appreciates the quality of the analyses conducted during the evaluation and will incorporate the recommendations into the design of CSP 2023-2027. The various findings and lessons identified will guide the dialogue with stakeholders at the country level and the implementation of Bank-financed projects and programmes in the country.

## Relevance

**The relevance of the Bank's strategies and programmes for the 2011-2020 period was deemed to be satisfactory.** The Bank's operations during the evaluation period coincided with the implementation of the national development strategy reference framework, respectively the Poverty Reduction Strategy Paper (PRSP) 2011-2015 and the Accelerated Growth and Shared Prosperity Strategy (SCAPP) 2016-2030. Hence, during the review period, the Bank aligned its interventions with these national strategies and thus created strong linkages and much synergy between these various operations.

For CSP 2023-2027, the Bank, in collaboration with the Mauritanian government, agreed that interventions and expected results in priority areas should be aligned with the second 2021-2025 action plan of the Accelerated Growth and Shared Prosperity Strategy (SCAPP). Thus, the strategic alignment between the CSP priority areas and the expected results of the programmed operations will be strengthened and will make it possible to consolidate the causal links between the results of the Bank's operations and the targeted objectives at national level. The CSP and IOP project preparation teams will ensure that the intermediate results selected as targets actually lead to the higher level results, to ensure that their linkages are reliable and feasible in the national context of operations.

Furthermore, the evaluation also deemed satisfactory the articulation of the CSP 2016-2020 with the Bank's regional integration policy. Indeed, the Bank is the lead development partner in co-financing (with the European Union and the European Investment Bank) the multinational project for the construction of the Rosso bridge, which aims to improve border crossing conditions between Senegal and Mauritania, and which is one of the sections of the Cairo-Dakar trans-African corridor. The Bank will continue to strengthen regional integration as part of its future strategies and strengthen the articulation between the CSP and the Regional Integration Strategy Paper (RISP) 2020-2026 for North Africa.

## Effectiveness

**The evaluation rated the effectiveness of the Bank's support to Mauritania during the 2011-2020 period as satisfactory.**

Indeed, the Bank has met the targets set at the national level. At the operations level, effectiveness is satisfactory as almost 60% of the expected outputs were delivered or deliverable and 83.3% of the projects achieved the expected development outputs. Nonetheless, the next CSP will focus more on the intermediate link between the outcomes of operations and those of the priority areas during definition of the theory of change. Indeed, thanks to the adjustments made during the mid-term reviews, an improvement in performance over time (between CSP 2011-2015 and CSP 2016-2020) has been observed. The physical presence of a resident programme officer as of 2018 and strengthening of the dialogue with national authorities have enabled the Bank to adapt to the changing context and remove obstacles to implementation of operations.

It should be recalled that the Bank introduced new output tools in the CSPs and at the operations level in 2019 and 2021 respectively, with a particular focus on strengthening the results chain and the theory of change:

- For the CSPs, the new output assessment tools include a strategic alignment matrix and a performance matrix. The strategic alignment matrix is designed to demonstrate close alignment of the intervention areas with the country development plan and Bank priorities and will also reflect the theory of change. The performance matrix presents the Bank's results by defining performance areas, indicators, baselines, targets and sources at the beginning of the CSP or Regional Integration Strategy Paper (RISP) cycle.

- On the operations side, improvements are being made to strengthen the quality and evaluation of operations and to strengthen the approach to planning and results monitoring. These improvements focus on reforms to the Bank's approach to planning and results measurement in operations initiated from 2021. These reforms are accompanied by a set of new tools: i) a theory of change; ii) a results framework; iii) a monitoring plan; and iv) a risk matrix.

## Sustainability

**The evaluation rated the sustainability of the Bank's operations in Mauritania over the 2011-2020 period to be satisfactory in general.**

When designing its operations, the Bank pays particular attention to the sustainability of its achievements and investments, especially in its dialogue with the authorities and when defining new operations. Indeed, this point highlights the importance of ownership of operations by the authorities, which is ensured by the Bank through the strategic alignment of these operations with national development plans. Such alignment ensures the sustainability of Bank-funded operations and of project impact. The basic principle governing the selection of projects defined in the selectivity framework approved in 2021, implies that the Bank's operations have a high potential for sustainable development impacts.

Indeed, the achievements of the projects completed or closed during the evaluation period were continued. All projects during the period involved the target communities and their project implementation units (PICs) were integrated into the services of the supervisory ministry, thus strengthening the level of ownership by beneficiaries. However, certain aspects still require more attention, particularly the building and mobilization of local staff capacity and the inclusion of mechanisms that ensure the sustainability of achievements, including the mobilization of revenue to finance recurrent costs, in project design and implementation. Monitoring of the implementation of environmental and social management measures was found to be partly unsatisfactory. In fact, the Bank has been monitoring environmental and social management measures more closely for several years, which has made it possible to improve the way they are taken into account (exit strategy) and thus provides the necessary guarantee for the continuity of Bank assistance in the country.

In addition, IDEV is currently evaluating the counterparty's rules and procedures, which will enhance the sustainability of the Bank's operations.

## Coherence

**The evaluation deemed the coherence of the Bank's portfolio of activities in Mauritania to be satisfactory between 2011 and 2020.**

The external coherence of the Bank's projects with the operations of other technical and financial partners (TFPs) was deemed to be highly satisfactory. All projects are complementary with the operations of at least two partners in the country. Even for emergency aid operations, the Bank systematically coordinated its operations with other TFPs.

In addition, the internal coherence of the Bank's operations was also deemed satisfactory, with strong synergies between the Bank's actions, which complement each other (for 17 out of 24). In addition, the application of the Bank's selectivity document: "Sharpening the Bank's Strategic Focus - A Proposal to Increase the Bank's Selectivity," approved by the Board in May 2021, will make it possible to target the Bank's areas of intervention in the country and reduce the volatility associated with changes in the Indicative Operations Program (IOP) while ensuring that both the internal and external coherence of the Bank's operations is enhanced. This selection will be based on an in-depth dialogue and an advanced level of preparation of the target operations.

Thus, the Bank's IOP for the period 2023-2024 is the result of a long process of dialogue and identification based on the needs expressed by the government. For example, in the livestock sector, the Bank was initially asked by the government to carry out studies on the value chains of meat (in 2020-2021) and milk (in 2021-2022). These studies served as a basis for the preparation of the Mauritania Compact presented at the Dakar II Summit in January 2023 and allowed the Bank to receive a request to finance the preparation of a project expected to be submitted for Board approval in 2024. This long process upstream of operations ensures strong ownership on the part of the authorities and a satisfactory quality at entry of operations leading to a reduction in the volatility of the IOP.

Furthermore, as highlighted in the evaluation report, no project was appraised to improve access to electricity during the period 2011-2020, even though this result was targeted in both CSPs. However, through in-depth dialogue and the financing of project preparation in recent years, two operations under the Desert to Power initiative are included in the Bank's work program in Mauritania for the period 2023-2024: i) the Program for the Strengthening of Productive and Energy Investments in Mauritania for the Sustainable Development of Rural Areas with financing from the Sustainable Energy Fund for Africa (SEFA) and ii) the Mauritania-Mali 225 kilovolt electricity interconnection project and the development of associated solar power plants. This latter project, financed by the regional resources of the African Development Fund, will contribute significantly to regional integration by being fully integrated into the Trans-Sahel backbone transmission line project.

## Efficiency

**Over the 2011-2020 period, the efficiency of the Bank's strategies and programmes was deemed to be satisfactory.**

While performance was highly satisfactory in terms of compliance with the allocated budget and satisfactory in terms of compliance with implementation deadlines, with half of the completed or closed projects in good standing, two bottlenecks nevertheless undermined the efficiency of operations, namely: pre-implementation delays and a low disbursement rate. The constraints appear both at the level of national actors and within the Bank. However, the IDEV report notes that improvements have been made at the level of these two bottlenecks as of 2018. Indeed, as noted in the 2020 Portfolio Review, "loan agreements in 2020 are signed within an average period of 1.8 months after approval compared with 3.4 months in 2015 and become effective after an average period of 3.7 months for public sector projects compared to 9 months in 2015."

In order to address these bottlenecks that cause delays, the Bank has, in recent years, included the number of implementation progress and results (IPR) reports required annually per project among the key performance indicators (KPIs). This recommendation features prominently in the recommendations of successive Portfolio Performance Improvement Plans (PPIPs).

## Cross-Cutting Issues

**The mainstreaming of cross-cutting issues was considered to be partly unsatisfactory during the evaluation period.**

Of the 24 projects approved during the period, explicit objectives were set in three of them for youth employment (12.5%) and five of them for climate change adaptation and/or mitigation (20.8%). Although a gender promotion objective was found in only two projects (8.3%), 16 others (66.7%) implemented various activities in favour of gender and women. Addressing fragility was an explicit objective in four projects (16.7%). Private sector development was an objective in four projects (16.7%). However, the Bank financed five non-sovereign operations in Mauritania for a total of UA 53.5 million, representing almost 35% of the Bank's financing in the country during the period.

There is also a trend towards improving the mainstreaming of these cross-cutting aspects into Bank-approved operations in Mauritania with the approval in 2021 of several youth employment support operations, including: i) the Vulnerable Youth Employability and Socio-Economic Integration Support Project; and ii) the Support Project for Resilience of Youth Enterprises in G5 Sahel Countries.

Regarding these new operations to support youth employment, the Bank is continuing its long-standing work that has enabled it to accumulate a wealth of experience and many achievements in this area in Mauritania. This includes the Youth Training and Employment Support Project (PAFEJ), which led to the development of the national employment strategy adopted by the Council of Ministers in February 2019, and the Support for the Promotion of Micro-, Small- and Medium-Sized Enterprises and Youth Employment Project (PAMPEJ). Beyond these specific operations, the issue of youth employment is the subject of particular attention and integration in a cross-cutting manner in many operations, particularly in the agricultural sector where the Bank has a strong presence.

In addition, as part of the Promotion of Gender-Sensitive Agricultural Value Chains Project in support of the Agricultural Transformation Support Project (PATAM), approved in September 2021, the Bank is strengthening the inclusion of women and the development of women's institutions in synergy with the AFAWA (Affirmative Finance Action for Women in Africa) programme. All of these operations were incorporated into the CSP 2016-2020 updated and extended to end-2022.

Lastly, it is important to recall that the Bank has taken concrete measures since 2021 to strengthen these aspects. These measures include the following examples: i) The Bank's selectivity framework approved in 2021 defines the contribution to these cross-cutting priorities as a criterion for identifying transformative operations; ii) In 2021, the Bank approved its new climate change strategic framework committing to align all new operations and sector strategies with the Paris Agreement by 2023, and all country and internal operations by 2025; iii) In 2022, the Bank approved its Strategy for Addressing Fragility and Building Resilience in Africa, which will guide its work in this area until 2026; iv) The Bank began producing country and regional gender profiles in 2021, to ensure that gender issues inform government policies and actions on economic inclusion, resilience, social cohesion, and peacebuilding.

## Conclusion

Overall, Management welcomes the findings and recommendations of the evaluation of the Bank's strategies and programmes in Mauritania for the 2011-2020 period. Management's responses to each of the four key recommendations are provided in the action plan table below. ■

<table>
<tr><th colspan="2">Measures Taken by Management</th></tr>
<tr><th>IDEV Recommendation</th><th>Management Response</th></tr>
<tr><td colspan="2">Recommendation 1: Improve the alignment between the objectives targeted at the national and pillar levels and the expected outputs of the operations programmed under the country assistance strategy</td></tr>
<tr><td>The following elements should be taken into account:<br>▌ Reliability and feasibility (in the country context) of the results chain (causal links) between the three levels of action: operational, pillar and national;<br>▌ Volatility resulting from frequent IOP changes;<br>▌ The life span of the operations programmed in the IOP when determining the planning horizon for expected CSP outputs; and<br>▌ Adequate sizing of the CSP's target results relative to the resources earmarked to fund operations during the period in the country.</td><td>AGREED<br>1. Reliability and feasibility of the results chain: RDCN, in collaboration with the sectoral departments, will ensure that the strategic alignment between the CSP priority areas and the expected outputs programmed operations is reinforced.<br>2. Volatility: RDCN will ensure that it implements the Bank's selectivity document, approved by the Board in May 2021. Thus, application of the selectivity principle (with an advanced level of preparation of target operations) will help target the Bank's sectors of intervention in the country and reduce the volatility resulting from IOP changes.<br>3. Life span of operations: The implementation period of projects approved under the CSP may exceed the time frame of the country strategy. To this end, RDCN will indicate the duration (in years of achievement) of the various planned outcomes, in particular for operations exceeding the CSP period.<br>4. Right-sizing: For several years, the Bank has been strengthening quality at project entry by reinforcing the theory of change. RDCN, in collaboration with the sectoral departments and SNDR, will ensure that the target results of the CSP are adequately sized, taking into account available and planned resources.<br>Under the 2023-2027 Country Strategy Paper for Mauritania, which is currently being developed, RDCN will take into account the four elements mentioned (results chain, IOP volatility, life span of operations, and sizing of outputs). [RDCN, Q3 2023]</td></tr>
<tr><td colspan="2">Recommendation 2: Ensure that the frequency of two supervisions per year is respected</td></tr>
<tr><td>In this regard, timely provision of the necessary sector specialists and budget can help to eliminate obstacles to the proper execution of operations (poor mastery of the Bank's applicable rules and procedures; poor quality of disbursement requests; late mobilization of counterpart funds; insufficient diligence in the procurement process; etc.).<br>These more regular supervisions can also be opportunities to provide advice and guidance to national stakeholders and possibly hold in-situ clinics and training sessions.</td><td>AGREED<br>The Bank recently implemented this recommendation.<br>By 2022, 100% of the projects in the active portfolio in the Northern Region had submitted at least one implementation progress and results report (IPR) and 98% of these same projects had submitted two IPRs. RDCN will continue to ensure that two IPRs are submitted annually.<br>In addition, since 2017, fiduciary clinics have been held on a regular basis (one 3-day fiduciary clinic per year) and the Bank will continue to conduct in situ training sessions almost systematically during supervision missions. Each fiduciary clinic includes training modules for the management teams of Bank-financed projects on the following topics: i) procurement rules and procedures; ii) financial management; iii) disbursements; iv) monitoring and evaluation; v) environmental and social safeguards; and vi) gender mainstreaming.</td></tr>
</table>

**Measures Taken by Management**

| IDEV Recommendation | Management Response |
|---|---|
| **Recommendation 3:** Make provision for mechanisms that ensure the sustainability of achievements right from the design of Bank operations and monitor their effective implementation | |
| The mechanisms currently planned, such as cost recovery for financing the recurrent costs of public infrastructure and facilities and the strengthening of local ownership and participation capacities (exit strategy), must be effectively implemented in order to ensure the sustainability of the Bank's impact on national development. | **AGREED**<br>1. Management takes note of this pertinent recommendation, which highlights one of the Bank's key development missions. The sustainability aspects of project benefits have been strengthened in the new templates of the concept note and appraisal report for projects approved in 2021. **The assessment of this dimension will be strengthened in the new version of the preparation status review, scheduled to be launched in 2023. [SNDR, Q4 2023]**<br>2. The Directorate will ensure that stakeholder capacity-building as well as the integration of training components in institutional support are systematically proposed within the framework of operations being appraised and programmed under IOP 2023-2024. With regard to the investment projects envisaged in 2023-2024, RDCN, in collaboration with the sectoral departments, will pay particular attention to project ownership by the beneficiaries and to environmental and social safeguards issues with a view to ensuring the sustainability of Bank-financed operations in Mauritania. **[RDCN, T4 2024]** |
| **Recommendation 4:** Ensure greater mainstreaming of cross-cutting aspects into the Bank's CSPs and operations | |
| This recommendation specifically addresses gender promotion and women's empowerment; youth employment; fragility and resilience; climate change adaptation and mitigation; and private sector development. It is recommended that explicit objectives be included at the design stage, particularly in results-based logical frameworks, along the lines of the Bank's gender marker, so that these cross-cutting issues are central to the work of all stakeholders during the implementation of operations. This integration mechanism could be complemented by other modalities. | **AGREED**<br>Management recognizes the importance of mainstreaming the multiple cross-cutting issues mentioned (gender, women's empowerment, youth employment, climate change adaptation and mitigation, private sector development, fragility) at both the CSP and operational levels. In recent years, the Bank has taken concrete steps by adopting major reforms to strengthen these aspects (see page 12).<br>The multiple cross-cutting aspects (gender, women's empowerment, youth employment, climate change adaptation and mitigation, private sector development, fragility) will be mainstreamed into the new CSP 2023-2027 and its results framework, and specifically into IOP 2023. **[RDCN, Q3 2023]** |

# Introduction

## Scope and Purpose of the Evaluation

This Bank Country Strategy and Programme Evaluation (CSPE) for Mauritania is part of the 2019-2021 work programme of the Independent Development Evaluation Department (IDEV, 2019a).

The most recent CSPE of the African Development Bank Group ('the Bank' or 'AfDB') covered the 1994-2004 period. This CSPE only covers the 2011-2020 period.[2] The CSP 2016-2020[3] extension period is not taken into consideration because of the additional resources that would have been required, since the data collection work had already been completed in August 2021. At this stage of the evaluation, it was not possible to include operations approved during the extension and collect additional data given the available resources and the new shorter timeline for preparing the next CSP for Mauritania. The purpose of this CSPE is to help the Bank to: i) report to stakeholders on the results achieved with the resources made available; and ii) improve its development effectiveness through lessons drawn from experience, in particular to guide the preparation and implementation of the next Country Strategy Paper (CSP) for Mauritania covering the 2023-2027 period. As recommended by IDEV (2019b:43), the specific objective is to assess the relevance of the assistance provided to the country, including selectivity, internal and external coherence of its strategies and programmes in the country, their efficiency, sustainability, the mainstreaming of cross-cutting issues in strategies and programs, the institutional performance of the Bank and Government as development partners, their effectiveness and contribution to the achievement of the country's development goals during the evaluation period.

## Evaluation Approach and Methods

Technical Annex 7 describes the methodology in more detail. This evaluation is based on eight questions that IDEV answers as part of its corporate CSPE commitments (IDEV, 2019b:47).

The evaluation team comprising one IDEV evaluation officer and two emerging evaluators consulted stakeholders at the design stage to agree on the evaluation questions as well as the terms and conditions of the exercise, and thus promote its use. The team then: i) reviewed the portfolio; ii) reviewed the performance of completed or closed projects; iii) undertook sector evaluations of Bank assistance in sectors with at least three approved operations with an "ongoing," "completed" or "closed" status; and iv) evaluated assistance at country and strategic pillar levels. Online interviews with the country team and the Directorate-General for North Africa through telephone calls, e-mail exchanges and/or comments on the evaluation findings and review of the drafts of various preliminary reports during virtual meetings and the review of existing documentation provided data for the evaluation. The analysis of documents obtained at the Bank and on the Internet was carried out using secondary data extraction models developed for each of the adopted indicators. Each evaluation criterion is rated on a four-point scale clearly defined as "highly satisfactory," "satisfactory," "partly unsatisfactory" and "unsatisfactory" (Annex 4). While factual data is presented to justify the rating of each sub-criterion, it should be noted that the score for a criterion is the average of the scores across the sub-criteria. The CSPE summary report was drafted based on this factual data collected from documents related to operations, the reports of background studies, and interview data. It was reviewed by two IDEV internal peer reviewers, an external peer reviewer, and members of the Evaluation Reference Group (ERG) for quality assurance.

This summary report presents the evaluation findings relating to evaluation criteria which focuses on two major questions, namely: What was the Bank's contribution to the development results achieved by the country; and how did the Bank design and manage its assistance to the country? It then identifies the lessons to be drawn from this experience and makes recommendations to guide the Bank's assistance, in particular the next CSP 2023-2027.

## Evaluation Limitations and Mitigation Measures

Due to COVID-19 travel restrictions, the evaluation team could not meet key informants in-person. The evaluation data was therefore collected remotely. Certain efficiency indicators, particularly cost-benefit analysis and cost-effectiveness analysis could not be reported on due to insufficient data. The existing monitoring/evaluation systems did not provide all the necessary data. However, the quality of the CSPE was not significantly affected since data on the main indicators was available, thus resulting in relevant and well-documented evaluation findings.

## Report Structure

After this introductory section, the next section of this report presents Mauritania's development context during the 2011-2020 period; followed by a section that presents the Bank assistance provided to the country, then another section related to the Bank's contribution to development outcomes. Furthermore, another section presents the design and management of Bank operations; followed by a section that summarizes the evaluation's conclusions. The two last sections present the lessons drawn from the evaluation, and recommendations, respectively. This summary report is accompanied by a separate document containing technical annexes* which present, in detail, the facts that inform the analysis and underpin the evaluations conclusions. ■

* Only available in French

# Development Context of Mauritania

This section presents the country's geographical, political, economic, and social context then the national development policies implemented by the Government between 2011 and 2020.

## Geographical, Political, Economic and Social Context

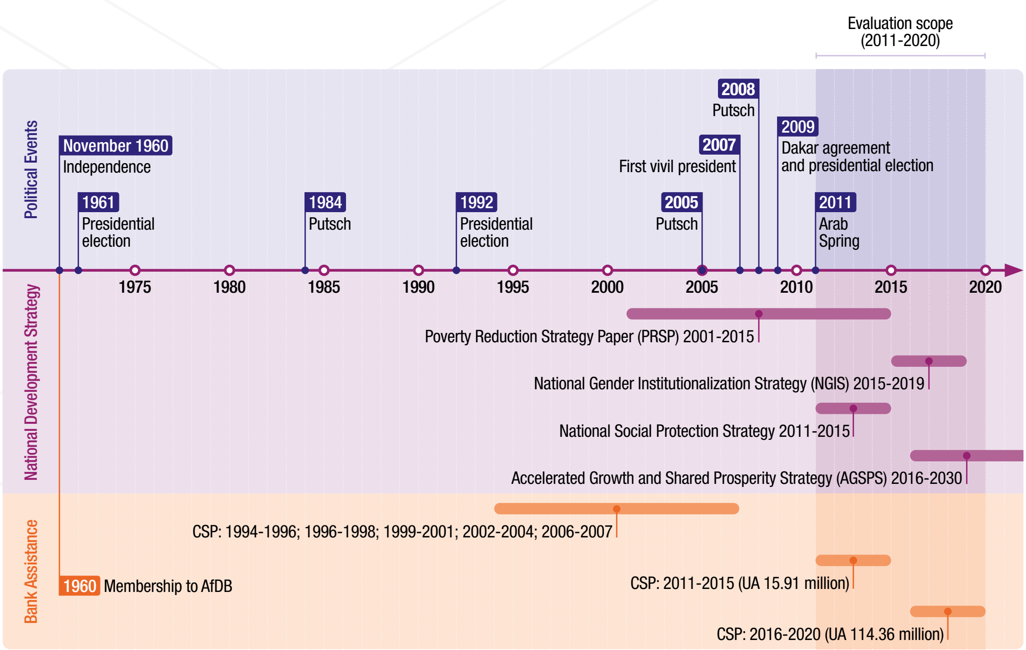
### Geographical Context

The country covers an area of 1 026 700 km², with a low population density of 4 inhabitants per km². The country is bordered to the North-West by Morocco, to the North-East by Algeria, to the South-East by Mali, to the South by Senegal, and to the West by the Atlantic Ocean with almost 754 km of coastline.

### Political Context

The Islamic Republic of Mauritania has been independent since 1960. After over two decades of military rule, the country entered a period of democratic transition culminating in 2007 in the organisation of senatorial, legislative, and presidential elections that were considered free and fair by the international community. The Results-Based Country Strategy Paper (RBCSP) 2011-2015 and the Country

**Figure 1:** Mauritania - Main Events and National Planning Documents (1960-2020)




Source: AfDB, 2010; AfDB/ADF, 2016: iv; AfDB, 2021: 3

Strategy Paper (CSP) 2016-2020 were implemented against a backdrop of political and institutional stability (AfDB, 2016: iv). Figure 1 below summarises the key events marking the country's modern history.

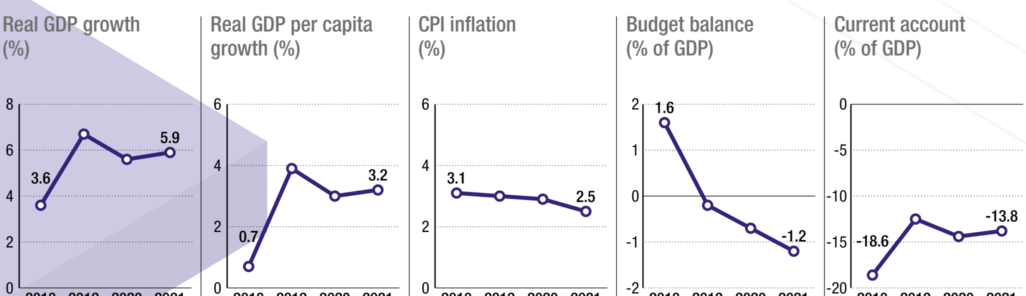
## Economic Context

The implementation of the RBCSP 2011-2015 began in a favourable economic context (AfDB/ADF, 2016: iv). The economy accelerated over the 2010-2013 period with real GDP growth peaking at of 6.1%, followed by a decline in 2014 and recovery in 2016. Gross national income per capita (calculated with the Atlas Method) rose from USD 1130 in 2011 to USD 1230 in 2015 (AfDB, 2022). The implementation of CSP 2016-2020 began in a difficult context marked by falling prices of iron ore, the country's main export product (AfDB/ADF, 2016: iv). In 2019, real GDP growth reached 6.7%, due to increased production of extractive industries and increased fishery exports. It also ended with a series of challenges since, from March 2020, the country had to confront the COVID-19 pandemic which affected it more than the average in Africa (Our World in Data, 2022). Real GDP contracted sharply in 2020 to 3.6%, following a growth of 5.9% in 2019 (AfDB, 2020a). The budget balance deficit was 4.1% of GDP in 2020 due to a significant drop in tax revenues caused by the economic downturn, declining export revenue, the lowering of taxes on certain staple commodities, and increased health spending to combat COVID-19. Foreign direct investment in Mauritania fell to USD 594 million in contrast to the original estimate of USD 937 million. The current account deficit rose to a record 17.6% of GDP due to a one-third drop in iron ore exports and a halt in fishery exports (Figure 2).

## Social Context

In 2018, the country had a population of 4.4 million inhabitants, 55% of whom lived in urban areas (AfDB, 2020d). Mauritania's human development index (HDI) score improved over the years from 0.453 (159th out of 187 countries) in 2011 (UNDP, 2011: 144, 147) to 0.513 (157th out of 188 countries) in 2015 (UNDP, 2016: 226). In 2019, the country was ranked 157th out of 189 countries with an HDI score of 0.546 (UNDP, 2020: 20; 27). The incidence of poverty fell from 42% in 2008 to 31% in 2014 (AfDB, 2016: iv). Income distribution remains unequal despite a decline in the Gini Index from 35.7 to 32.6 between 2008 and 2014. In 2019, 9.5% of the workforce was unemployed (World Bank, 2020). Life expectancy at birth rose from 62.5 years in 2010 to 64.7 in 2018, which is above the African average (63.2 years), but below the average for North Africa (73.8 years). Infant and maternal mortality rates have declined since 2010, reaching respectively 51.5 per 1000 (2018) and 602 per 100 000 (2016). However, the child mortality rate exceeds the crude mortality rate for the general population (7.2 per 1000). The school enrolment

**Figure 2:** Overview of Mauritania's Key Macro-Economic Indicators




Source: AfDB (2020c: 167)

rate is low with a gross ratio of 36.8% in secondary education and 79.5% in primary education in 2018, reflecting the low investment in education (2.6% of GDP in 2016).

## National Development Policies (2011-2020)

**Figure 1 mentions the development policy reference documents.**

Despite the reduction in the incidence of poverty and the HDI improvement, Mauritania's performance was unsatisfactory. In 2000[4], the government prepared a Poverty Reduction Strategy Paper (PRSP) for the 2001-2015 period to address these challenges and lay the foundations of accelerated and sustained economic growth that would create jobs, reduce unemployment, and sustainably improve the living conditions of the populations. PRSP implementation drew on successive five-year action plans: PRSP I (2001-2004), PRSP II (2006-2010) and PRSP III (2011-2015). PRSP III which served as the basis for RBCSP 2011-2015 focused on the following five strategic thrusts: 1) accelerating economic growth and stabilising the macroeconomic framework; 2) anchoring growth in the economic sphere of the poor; 3) developing human resources and expanding basic services; and 4) improving governance and building capacities. Thrust 5, a cross-cutting one relating to strengthening of management, monitoring, evaluation, and coordination, was introduced during the preparation of PRSP II 2006-2010 (Mauritania, 2011: 8).

In 2016, the country adopted the Accelerated Growth and Shared Prosperity Strategy (SCAPP) 2016-2030 based on the Government's General Policy Declaration for the 2015-2019 period and the Report on national consultations on the post-2015 Development Agenda to address the challenges that persisted after completion of PRSP 2011-2015, namely: a) Mauritania's economic growth has not been sufficiently inclusive; b) the PRSP has not really been used as a reference framework for the programming, monitoring and evaluation of public policies which explains why public spending does not reflect PRSP orientations; c) programs to support the most vulnerable segments of the population have shortcomings in terms of targeting; d) the country is heavily dependent on the rest of the world for official development assistance (ODA) and foreign trade (Mele, 2014); e) government services, local authorities and populations do not sufficiently participate in the PRSP tool; f) PRSP implementation has suffered from constraints linked to shortcomings in the areas of planning, targeting and operating modalities in a context of a decentralisation context that has few actual concrete actions, administrative malfunctions, inexperienced government services in terms of steering, strategic monitoring and a limited capacity to produce strategic information to meet real needs and facilitate economic and social development decision-making; and g) food insecurity has decreased but about 200 to 300 000 people are severely affected by food insecurity depending on the time of year (Islamic Republic of Mauritania and UNDP,[5] 2015: 185-187). SCAPP specifically aims to build economic resilience and promote inclusive growth, reduce the economy's vulnerability to external shocks, ensure more equitably shared growth as well as a promising medium and long-term outlook (Islamic Republic of Mauritania and UNDP 2015: 187). SCAPP implementation comprises 3 five-year action plans, the first of which covered the 2016-2020 period (Figure 1). This plan indicates the actions to be taken per priority area for each of the three strategic levers in order to achieve SCAPP objectives (Table 1).

Several sector strategies and plans were prepared during the period under review, namely: (a) the Strategy for Rural Sector Development by 2015 (SDSR-2015) approved in December 2001 and updated in February 2013 to SDSR-2025; (b) Mauritania's 2015-2019 Industrial Sector Development Strategy; (c) the 2015-2025 National Agricultural Development Plan (PNDA); (d) the National Livestock Development Plan (PNDE) 2025 approved in June 2017; (e) the 2016-2025 Strategic Multi-Sector Nutrition Plan; and (f) the 2016-2020

**Table 1:** Strategic Levers and Priority Areas of the SCAPP 2016-2020 Action Plan

| Levers | Priority areas |
|---|---|
| **1. Promote strong, sustainable, and inclusive growth** | Promote economic diversification and growth |
| | Develop growth support infrastructure |
| | Promote a competitive private sector |
| **2. Develop human capital and access to basic social services** | Improve the access, quality and performance of education and vocational training |
| | Improve conditions of access to quality health and nutrition services |
| | Ensure productive employment and decent work for all |
| | Promote youth, culture, and sports |
| | Significantly increase social inclusion by ensuring equitable access to quality basic services |
| **3. Strengthen all dimensions of governance** | Establish and preserve peace and security conditions that foster stable development |
| | Complete the actions already initiated to establish the rule of law based on the principles of equality, non-discrimination, and equity in particular by routinely recording all births in the civil status registry system. |
| | Initiate more effective policies in the areas of regional development and transparent and concerted management of State affairs |
| | Ensure transparent and effective economic and financial governance |
| | Establish the conditions for environmental governance based on the effective and responsible use of the various resources. |

Source: Mauritania, not dated: 32-159

Comprehensive Multi-Year Plan (PPAC) of the Expanded Immunisation Programme.

The finalisation of the action plan for the SCAPP 2021-2025 period that was to inform the next CSP was delayed by the COVID-19 crisis in 2020. The Government implemented preventive measures that are consistent with the policy recommendations of the Global Community of Practice (G-CoP) established by the Bank's African Development Institute (AfDB, 2020e[6]). To address the downturn in economic activity and job losses caused by these prevention measures, the government built the health system's operational capacities, established a mechanism to provide more effective financial management of response plans and strengthened the resilience of vulnerable communities by mitigating the pandemic's health, social and economic impacts, with the Bank's support (AfDB, 2022e; AfDB, 2022d; AfDB, 2020a). The Bank provided support through two operations, namely: the Multinational Support Project for G5 Sahel Member Countries to Combat the Coronavirus Pandemic whose objectives were to build the capacities of the G5 Sahel countries to contain the spread of the virus and end the COVID-19 pandemic and to support the resilience of the food and nutrition systems of vulnerable communities in G5 Sahel countries; and the COVID-19 Crisis Response Programme in the G5 Sahel Countries (PARC COVID-19 - G5 SAHEL) which enabled the Government to make financial transfers to about 200,000 households and remove taxes on staple commodities (AfDB, 2021). ■

# Bank Assistance to Mauritania (2011-2020)

Mauritania joined the Bank on 10 September 1964 (AfDB, 2022c) and operations began in 1972. The country is eligible for the ADF window for sovereign operations with conditional access to non-concessional AfDB resources for transformative non-sovereign operations (AfDB, 2022b).

This section presents: 1) the Bank's strategic priorities in the country over the period; and 2) the Bank portfolio implemented to achieve the CSP's strategic results.

## AfDB Strategic Priorities in the Country

RBCSP 2011-2015 and CSP 2016-2020 were informed by the reference frameworks of the national development strategies, respectively PRSP III (2001-2015) and the 2016-2020 action plan of SCAPP 2016-2030 (SCAPP I).

Table 2 below provides a quantified overview of the Bank's assistance to Mauritania in each of these periods. Annex 2a presents the list of operations approved and not cancelled between 2011 and 2020. Annex 2b presents the list of projects corresponding to these financing operations. The sequence of development results (theory of change) as planned in the CSP is presented below and summarised in the figure in Technical Annex 5.

**Under RBCSP 2011-2015**, Bank assistance sought to "contribute to the achievement of Mauritania's priority objectives based on strengthening economic competitiveness and reducing poverty" (AfDB/ADF, 2010: 16). Drawing on the lessons learned from implementation of the previous CSP, the 2009 portfolio review and strategic directions of the Bank's medium-term strategy, the government, with the participation of the central administration and civil society selected **2 pillars**, namely: i) **strengthening infrastructure**; and ii) **improving economic and financial governance**. In line with thrusts 1 and 3 of the PRSP and objective 4 of its action plan (2011-2015), **Pillar I** targeted two outcomes, viz: 1) improving community access to drinking water; and 2) improving access to electricity, especially in rural areas. **Pillar II** targeted two outcomes, viz: 3) improving the business climate by: a) supporting the development of infrastructure critical to the performance of economic activity; and b) implementing reforms intended to consolidate macro-economic stability, improve the business legal and regulatory framework and promote private investment in close cooperation with the European Union and World Bank; and 4) improving public finance management and strengthening the administration's capacities to manage economic and sector policies in order "to improve the effectiveness of public resources management and modernize the institutional and organizational framework of the administration, with a view to improving its effectiveness in implementing and monitoring economic and social policies." (AfDB/ADF, 2010: 18-19). At the mid-term review, it was agreed that the initially planned pillars and expected outcomes be maintained.

**Under CSP 2016-2020**, the Bank's main objective was to "assist Mauritania in achieving more inclusive and greener growth" (AfDB/ADF, 2016: 16). Following a broad-based participatory process involving governmental authorities and other Mauritanian stakeholders including the private sector, universities, civil society, the beneficiaries of Bank projects and programs and TFPs and with CODE's approval, the assistance was focused on the following two pillars: i) **promoting agricultural transformation** (Pillar I),

**Table 2:** Overview in Figures of AfDB Assistance to Mauritania (2011-2020)

| | DSPAR 2011-2015 | DSP 2016-2020 | |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Approval date** | January 2011 | July 2016 (for the 2016-2017 period) | January 2019 (for the 2018-2020 period) |
| **Pillars** | Pillar I: Infrastructure development | Pillar I: Promotion of agricultural transformation | Pillar I: Promotion of agricultural sector transformation |
| | Pillar II: Improvement of economic and financial governance | Pillar II: Increased power supply (AfDB, 2019) | Pillar II: Strengthening of economic infrastructure* |
| **Number of operations planned** | 10 | 8 | 9 |
| **Number of operations approved (at completion)** | 11 | 13 | 8 |
| **Sector distribution (number of operations approved and proportion of total CSP commitments)** | 4 sectors | 6 sectors | 4 sectors |
| | Agriculture (3 op. - 46.6%), Water and Sanitation (5 op. - 36.1%), Multisector (2 op. -10%), Social (1 op. - 7.3%) | Industry & mines (1 op. - 34.6%), Transport (1 op. - 24.9%), Finance (5 op. -22.3%), Multisector (3 op. - 10.7%), Water and sanitation (1 op. - 4.4%), Social (2 op. - 3.1%), | Agriculture (4 op. - 57.4%), Multisector (1 op. -28.5%), Social (2 op. - 12.6%), Finance (1 op. -1.5%) |
| **Amount planned (UA million)** | NA** | 66.02 | 29.5 |
| **Amount committed (UA million)** | 27.52 | 100.39 | 26.36 |
| **Number of non-lending operations planned (ESW)** | 6 | 2 | 0 |
| **Number of ESW carried out** | 5 | 1 | 5 |
| **Status of operations as at 31 December 2020** | Closed (4), Completed (1), | Approuvé (2), En cours (6) | Clôturé (5), En cours (8) |
| **Ongoing (6), Approved (0)** | Approved (2), Ongoing (6), | Closed (5), Ongoing (8) | |

* During the CSP 2016-2020 mid-term review, a partial readjustment was agreed with a new Pillar II for the 2018-2020 period: Strengthening of Economic Infrastructure.
** Data not available

Sources: AfDB, 2021a: 12; AfDB D, 2010: 16-17, Annex 5; AfDB, 2013c: 6-9, Annexes VII et VIII; AfDB, 2015a: 7-8; AfDB, 2016c: 17-21, Annex IV; AfDB, 2019b: 11, 19, Annexes III and IV

and ii) **increasing power supply** (Pillar II). **Under Pillar I**, there were two areas of intervention, namely: a) promotion of agricultural value chains with the targeted outcome of increasing agricultural sector value-added; and b) development of agricultural production support infrastructure with the targeted outcome of improving agricultural productivity with the ultimate goal of "facilitating the transition from purely traditional agriculture to more modern and productive agriculture that is competitive on national, regional and international markets." These thrusts of Pillar 1 are aligned with strategic thrust 2 of the Government's General Policy Declaration covering the 2015-2019 period, namely the emergence of a competitive economy that generates shared growth. **The targeted outcome of Pillar II was to improve access to electricity in rural and peri-urban areas**, in order to facilitate the population's widespread access to electricity and ensure secure power supply at low cost to foster the country's economic development, in line with strategic thrust 2 of the Government's General Policy Declaration over the 2015-2019 period and main objectives 1 and 2 of SCAPP 2016-2020, respectively: i) promote diversified, inclusive, green and sustainable economic growth that reduces inequalities and is a pro-poor, creates jobs and addresses unemployment, to enhance resilience and shared prosperity; and ii) reduce poverty and fight against the exclusion of vulnerable groups. Financing of the hybridization of mini-networks in rural Mauritania and strengthening of this sector's governance, especially of the renewable energies sub-sector, are central to this pillar (AfDB/ADF, 2016: 17-18). The Bank sought to capitalise on its previous and ongoing operations in this sector while seeking their complementarity with the operations of other TFPs in the sector: the United Nations Development Programme (UNDP), Global Environment Facility (GEF), the International Renewable Energy Agency (IRENA), the Abu Dhabi Fund for Development (ABFD), the French Development Agency (AFD) and the Senegal River Basin Development Agency (OMVS). In 2018, during the CSP 2016-2020 mid-term review, the Bank and Government agreed to reformulate Pillar II given that in the first two years (2016-2017), no operations could be sponsored under this pillar due to the low ADF allocation to Mauritania and that applications related to economic transformation were submitted(AfDB, 2018: 18[7]). **The new Pillar II "Strengthening Economic Infrastructure"** includes "improved access to power supply and the development of transmission infrastructure" in order to heighten the impact of Pillar I "Promotion of Agricultural Sector Transformation."

## Strategy Implementation: Bank Portfolio

This section draws on data from the Bank's SAP Project System internal application. It presents: a) trend of approvals, excluding cancellations; b) priority areas (High 5s); c) sectors of intervention; d) financing instruments mobilised; e) financing sources (windows); and f) the status of operations. Additional statistics are presented in Technical Annex 6.

**Trend of Net approvals:** The number of operations almost doubled from 11 under CSP 2011-2015 to 21 under CSP 2016-2020. In terms of volume, they increased almost fivefold thereby reflecting the Bank's efforts to meet the ever-growing financing demand of the country's authorities. The average envelope was UA 4.8 million per project over the entire period (Technical Annex 6). It rose from UA 2.5 million per project between 2011-2015 to UA 6 million between 2016-2020, i.e. a 141% increase.

**Priority areas (High 5s):** Four of the Bank's High 5s were covered by operations during the period[8] as follows: Industrialise Africa (30%), Improve Quality of Life for the People of Africa (29%), Feed Africa (25%) and Integrate Africa (16%). No operation was financed under the 'Light Up and Power Africa' priority area because of a lack of resources. However, the original Pillar II of CSP 2016-2020 aimed to 'Increase power supply'.

**Sectors of intervention:** Industries/mines/quarries (23%), agriculture (18%), transport (16%), finance (15%), multi-sector (14%), water and sanitation (9%) and the social sector (5%).

**Financing instruments (of the public and private sectors):** The 27 **public sector operations** (65%) are programme-based operations (PBOs), **institutional support operations** and **investment operations** including 2 regional operations: the Programme to Build Resilience to Food and Nutrition Security in the Sahel (UA 11.5 million) and the Rosso Bridge Construction Project (UA 25 million). There are 2 regional emergency assistance operations to combat the coronavirus pandemic. **The private sector** which was absent from the operations during the 2011-2015 period gained momentum in 2016-2020 and represents 34.7% of the Bank's financing in Mauritania throughout the period under evaluation. This comprises a **direct loan** of UA 34.7 million to SNIM which represents 64.9% of the envelope for non-sovereign operations in the country, two **lines of credit** and two **guarantees** for fairly modest amounts to the Bank for Trade and Industry (BCI) and *Banque Populaire de Mauritanie* (BPM). Loans and grants respectively represent 70.9% and

29.1% of the Bank's assistance to Mauritania over the period. The National Integrated Rural Water Sector Project (PNISER) is financed by an ADF loan (UA 3.05 million), an ADF grant (UA 2.45 million) and a RWSSI grant (UA 3.5 million).

**Financing sources:** The Government of Mauritania contributed UA 12 116 580 in **counterpart funds** for 10 operations with the Bank, i.e. almost 7.9% of the assistance received. In keeping with the country's credit category, the ADF window is the main source (54.5%), followed by the **AfDB** window (30.8%). The contribution of the Bank's **trust funds** (14.7%) was in the form of **grants** (GEF, RWSSI, SRF, and TSF) or **loans** (EPSA, NTF). In 2019, Mauritania received USD 3697.7 million of official development assistance (ODA) from technical and financial partners (TFP) . In decreasing order of importance are the contributions of the Arab Fund for Economic and Social Development (AFESD), Germany, the Organisation of Petroleum Exporting Countries (OPEC), the World Bank, Kuwait, China, and the European Union ( AfDB 2021a: 9). Social and economic infrastructure as well as governance are their main sectors of intervention, which absorbed about half of the assistance envelope. AfDB is in 7th position with almost 48% of the total amount of its operations in the rural development sector. The Bank has co-financed three projects.[9]

**Status of Operations:** As at 31 December 2020, 20 of the 32 operations approved since 2011 were ongoing which represented 78% of total approvals. Half of the operations approved under RBCSP 2011-2015 are still in execution, indicating implementation performance issues. Two emergency humanitarian assistance operations[10] were approved in June and July as part of the COVID-19 response. ■

# Contribution to Development Outcomes

This section presents evaluation findings regarding 1) the relevance, including selectivity, 2) effectiveness; and 3) sustainability of Bank assistance.

## Relevance

This section answers the evaluation question: to what extent did the CSP design meet the country's needs and strategic development framework and was it in alignment with the Bank's strategies? The evaluation also considered sub-questions linked to selectivity: Were there aspects or dimensions of the CSP that were not covered by all the operations? Were operations not included in the CSP? If so, which ones and why? The evaluation data is presented in Technical Annexes 8, 9a, 9b, 9c, 9d and 9e.

*The relevance of the Bank's strategies and programs was rated satisfactory. The anchoring of the CSPs on national priorities and alignment of the pillars and projects of the Bank with its own strategic priorities were highly satisfactory. However, the involvement of civil society, beneficiaries, the private sector, and universities was unsatisfactory. Although these actors participated in the validation of strategic choices, they were not included at the operations level. The country's multinational projects were not deliberately or specifically aligned enough with the regional strategy.*

### Alignment of assistance with national development strategies

**The relevance of the CSP design (pillars) in relation to the country's strategic priorities was rated highly satisfactory.** All the pillars (100%) are aligned with PRSP III (2011-2015) and SCAPP I (2016-2020) presented above in part 2.2. Pillar I of the RBCSP 2011-2015 on strengthening infrastructure (water and power) was aligned with the objectives of Thrusts 1 and 2 of PRSP III, respectively "Accelerating economic growth and maintaining macroeconomic stability" and "Anchoring growth within the economic sphere of the poor." Pillar II on "Improving economic and financial governance" was anchored on Focus Area 4 of PRSP III on "Improving Governance and Building Capacity" (AfDB/ADF, 2010a: 16-18; Mauritania, 2011: 19, 31 and 44). Pillar I of CSP 2016-2020 on the promotion of agricultural transformation was anchored on strategic lever 1, "Promoting strong, sustainable and inclusive growth" of SCAPP I, particularly its priority area 1 on promoting more diversified growth in promising sectors such as agriculture (AfDB/ADF, 2016c: 17, 19-20; Mauritania, not dated:68-69[11]). Pillar II on strengthening economic infrastructure was defined to achieve the objectives of this same strategic lever in the priority area on "Strengthening growth support infrastructure," in particular increasing the availability of affordable energy services to economic units (Mauritania, not dated: 90-94; AfDB/ADF, 2010c: 18-,20; AfDB/ADF, 2019b: 19, Annex 5). This alignment of the CSPs with national strategic priorities was fostered by the involvement of the relevant actors (i.e the government, private sector, universities, civil society, and the beneficiaries of the Bank's programmes/projects) in the design and validation process of CSP priorities (AfDB, 2010: 16; AfDB/ADF, 2016 c: 16).

**Alignment of the objectives of Bank's projects with the focus areas, levers and priority areas of the national development strategies was rated satisfactory.** Some 34 of the 39 objectives of the

24 projects approved over the 2011-2020 period (87.2%)[12] are specifically aligned with at least one of the components of PRSP III or SCAPP I, except for emergency assistance projects which are not included in a particular reference framework, but which addressed flood and COVID-19 needs (Technical Annex 8). In the **economic and financial governance sector**, 8 of the 10 objectives (80%) of the four projects approved over the 2011-2020 period are specifically aligned with the government's priorities (AfDB, 2017a: 4; AfDB, 2016a: VI-VII; ADF, 2013a: V-VI; Mauritania, 2011a: 22, 23, 44, 49, 50; Mauritania, not dated: 68, 84, 140, 145). Five of the seven objectives of the water and sanitation sector were consistent with the focus areas of the National Strategy for Sustainable Access to Water and Sanitation by 2030 (SNADEA),[13] thus contributed to improving access to drinking water including in rural areas, as well as to increased knowledge and development of water resources in accordance with the priorities defined in the country's development documents (Mauritania, 2011a: 40; AfDB, 2013d: iii; 2012b: v). As regards **financial sector** projects, 8 of the 10 objectives were specifically aligned with national priorities and contributed to the development of the financial sector by modernising the country's payment system, to improving money market management and financial inclusion, and lastly strengthening banking sector supervision and access to financing (AfDB, 2017b: v, 15; AfDB, 2016b: 9). All the objectives (100%) of projects in the **agricultural, transport, social, industrial, mines and quarries sectors** are specifically aligned with national development documents. The PATAM and PAHABO II agricultural sector projects are aligned with the 2013-2025 National Livestock and Agriculture Development Plan (PNDEA) and the 2015-2025 National Agricultural Development Plan (PNDA).[14] These projects contribute to the objectives of promoting economic diversification and transformation, the development of growth support infrastructure, promotion of a competitive private sector, promotion of food security and the economic development of natural capital, as defined in national development documents (Mauritania, 2011a: 31, 34; Mauritania, not dated: 34-42; AfDB, 2014a: 5; AfDB, 2018b: vii). In the **social sector**, Bank approvals are linked to training, support to youth employment and MSE promotion. The single **transport project** for the construction of the Rosso bridge contributes to the achievement of these SCAPP 2016-2030 objectives relating to the development of relations with other countries to promote sub-regional and regional trade and objectives as well as the improvement of access to basic services and quality of life for the population (Mauritania, not dated: 92, 120-122; AfDB, 2016a: 4). In the **industries/mines/quarries sector**, implementation of the SNIM project contributes to the achievement of the objective of developing the mining sector (Mauritania, not dated: 78; AfDB, 2017c: Annex 1).

### Alignment with population's needs

**The CSP designs satisfactorily took into consideration the population's needs.** The Bank achieved this by relying on several mechanisms: i) reformulation of Pillar II of CSP 2016-2020 to address the energy sector challenges (AfDB, 2021a: 11, Annex II); ii) dialogue with Mauritanian stakeholders (government, private sector, universities, civil society, and Bank programme/project beneficiaries) prior to the preparation of CSP 2016-2020 (AfDB/ADF, 2016c: 16) as well as dialogue from 7 to 11 November 2010 with the central administration and civil society during validation of CSP 2011-2015 (AfDB/ADF, 2010a: 16); iii) the different field missions by the North Africa Regional Directorate and analytical studies aimed at enhancing the Bank's advisory role. Under RBCSP 2011-2015, there was Pillar I on infrastructure improvement to meet the population's needs, in particular "limited access to drinking water and sanitation services in urban and rural communities which fuels the spread of water borne diseases". This was to be done by pursuing 3 ongoing projects and approving another which will establish drinking water supply and sanitation (DWSS) facilities, 400 DWSS management units, the legal framework of the Water Code, regional water and sanitation directorates, the medium-term expenditure framework (MTEF) for the sector and the Regionalized Water Information System in Mauritania (SIREM) and its activation' (AfDB /ADF, 2010a: Annex 7). CSP 2016-2020 was designed "to improve the population's living conditions (or shared prosperity)" by ending the exclusion of communities especially those living in rural and peri-urban areas, due to a lack of basic infrastructure (water supply, energy and sanitation) which results in limited access to basic goods and services (AfDB/ADF, 2016c: iv, 1, 9, 15). The 2 pillars of this strategy directly meet these needs of the population (AfDB/ADF, 2016c: 17-21, Annex I). However, the involvement of civil society, beneficiaries, the private sector, and universities was unsatisfactory (AfDB/ADF, 2010a: 16: AfDB/ADF, 2016c: 16) because it was limited to validation of the CSP pillars. Broadening their participation would have helped to improve targeting and potentially increase the impact on the population's living conditions. At the operations level, the projects of the **water and sanitation sector** were aligned with the needs of rural communities in the Brakna, Gorgol and Tagant regions by providing water for different uses (drinking water, small-scale irrigation, livestock watering and sanitation). In the **finance sector**, the Bank provided support to the Bank for Trade and Industry (BCI) to develop small and medium-sized enterprises (SME) to meet its customers' needs, especially in the fisheries and agro-industrial sectors which are crucial to the country's economy. AfDB support has also enabled the BCI to expand its assistance to other key sectors in the country (building and public works, services, energy, and mines). Alongside the planned operations, the Bank responded rapidly to the population's pressing needs during crises in the country by approving 6 emergency assistance projects (Annexes 2a and 2b).

## Alignment with Bank priorities

**The relevance of the CSP pillars in relation to the Bank's strategic priorities was rated highly satisfactory.** All the CSP pillars (100%) presented in Table 2 are specifically aligned with the Bank's strategic priorities: Light up and power Africa; Feed Africa; Industrialise Africa; Integrate Africa and Improve quality of life for the people of Africa.

**The alignment of the projects with the Bank's strategic priorities was rated highly satisfactory.** All the 24 projects approved over the 2011-2020 period (100%) are aligned with one or more of the Bank's strategic priorities.

## Alignment between CSP and RISP

**The alignment of CSP 2016-2020 with the Bank's Regional Integration Policy was rated satisfactory.** The North Africa Region did not have a Regional Integration Strategy Paper (RISP) when the RBCSP 2011-2015 and CSP 2016-2020 were prepared and approved. The most recent RISP covers the 2020-2026 period. However, the Bank had a regional integration policy and strategy (RIPS) covering the 2014-2023 period. The evaluation therefore considered the alignment of CSP 2016-2020 with the RIPS 2014-2023, excluding RBCSP 2011-2015. It showed that the CSP 2016-2020 did not have any specific objective in terms of regional integration. Nevertheless, it had programmed the Rosso Multinational Road Construction Programme aimed at improving border crossing conditions between Senegal and Mauritania. This road is a section of the Cairo-Dakar Trans African Highway 1 (AfDB, 2016a: 4). It also included the Programme to Build Resilience to Food and Nutrition Insecurity in the Sahel (P2RS) (AfDB, 2014c: 5) and support to finance the Power Interconnection Project (to the OMVS grid) which are contributing to regional integration in alignment with: i) Pillar I, particularly the priority area relating to the "development of hard and soft regional infrastructure"; or ii) Pillar II, particularly the priority areas pertaining to "Industrialisation, export diversification and market development" and "Trade Policy and Facilitation" (AfDB, 2016c: 17, Annex 4; 2019b: Annex 5). However, the energy sector project was not financed.

## Bank selectivity

The following three aspects of selectivity were evaluated: a) the effective coverage of CSP priorities by project approvals; b) the IOP implementation rate at CSP approval and following the mid-term review, and c) the specific consideration given to the Bank's comparative advantages in selecting its operations. The related evaluation data are presented in Technical Annexes 9a, 9b, 9c, 9d and 9e.

**Table 3:** Positioning of Operations by Strategic Pillar (excluding emergency assistance operations)

| CSP | Pillars | Outcome Areas | Projects (number) | Envelope (in UA million)* |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **2011-2015** | Pillar I: Strengthening of Infrastructure | O1: Improvement of population's access to drinking water | 4 | 21.52 |
| | | O2: Improvement of access to electricity especially in rural areas | 0 | 0 |
| | Pillar II: Improvement of economic and financial governance | O3: Improvement of business climate | 2 | 4 |
| | | O4: Improvement of public finance management and building the administration's capacity to carry out economic and sector work | 1 | 0.74 |
| **2016-2017** | Pillar I: Promotion of agricultural transformation | O1: Agricultural sector value-added increased | 6 | 40.67 |
| | | O2: Agricultural productivity improved | 6 | 40.67 |
| | Pillar II: Improving power supply | O3: Improved access to electricity in rural and peri-urban areas | 0 | 0 |
| **2018-2020** | Pillar I: Promotion of agricultural transformation | O1: Agricultural sector value-added increased | 3 | 14.9 |
| | | O2: Agricultural productivity improved | 3 | 14.9 |
| | Pillar II: Strengthening of economic infrastructure | O4: Improved access to production factors: energy, transport | 1 | 25 |

* In this table, the envelope for each project was totally broken down into each of its directly targeted outcomes (O). If the information had been complete, the breakdown would have presented only the envelope for the component concerned by the targeted outcome. The total exceeds the amounts approved (UA 154.26 million) because the project amount is doubly allocated to each outcome and not pro-rated to the budget of the project component concerned.

Source: AfDB, 2010a: 17-19; AfDB, 2013c: iii, XII-XIII; AfDB, 2016c: 19-20; SAP PS data adapted by the team (see Technical Annex 8)

**The coverage of priorities agreed upon in the CSPs was rated satisfactory.** The Bank approved projects that covered 5 of the 7 outcomes (71.4%) of pillars agreed upon at CSP approval (Technical Annex 8). Taking into account the strategic readjustment of CSP 2016-2020 at mid-term, the Bank covered 6 of the 7 pillar outcomes, i.e. 85.7% (Table 3; Technical Annex 8). During RBCSP 2011-2015, the Bank covered 3 of the 4 expected pillar outcomes (75%). Due to a lack of resources, the two projects prepared under the "Light up Africa" High 5 were not presented to the Bank's Board of Directors. Appraisal of the rural electrification project planned under Pillar I: "Improve access to electricity particularly in rural areas" during RBCSP 2011-2015 approval was abandoned (AfDB/ADF 2010a: 17-18). The inter-urban transport and power distribution programme decided upon at the Mid-term Review to connect five of the country's urban centres to the interconnected grid of the Senegal River Basin Organisation (OVMS) was not presented to the Board of Directors (AfDB, 2013c: Annex 7) since the preparation team had counted on Mauritania's access to non-concessional resources of the AfDB public sector window to finance the operation. However, Mauritania's eligibility for this window has been deferred because of the country's debt distress risk (AfDB, 2015a: 10).

**Implementation of the Indicative Operational Programme (IOP) was rated satisfactory.** Seven of the eleven projects planned at CSP approval (63.63%) were approved (Technical Annexes 9a and 9b). Considering the adjustments made at the CSP mid-term reviews, 13 of the 26 planned projects were approved, i.e., an implementation rate of 50%. Approvals for the 2011-2020 include two private sector projects (lines of credit) whose promotion was one of the Bank's targeted objectives over the 2011-2020 period (AfDB/ADF, 2010a: Annex 7; AfDB, 2016c: 19). Over the RBCSP 2011-2015 period, 5 of the 10 projects planned under the IOP (50%) were approved (Technical Annexes 9a and 9c). During CSP 2016-2020, the implementation rate remained at 50%; i.e., 8 out of sixteen programmes approved (Technical Annexes 9b and 9d).

**Regarding compliance with the IOP, performance was rated satisfactory.** Some 10 of the 19 projects approved over the 2011-2020 were programmed excluding the 5 emergency assistance operations (Technical Annexes 9a, 9b, 9c and 9d). These represented 52.6% of projects in the portfolio and 65.3% of the resources allocated to the country. In other words, unplanned projects represented over half the number of approved projects and a little over one third of the envelope (Table 4).

**The implementation rate of economic and sector work (ESW) was rated satisfactory.** The Bank had planned 4 ESW at approval and 2 were completed (50%). Considering the adjustments made during the mid-term review, 5 of the 8 ESW planned (62.5%) were completed. The 2 ESW planned over the CSP period were not conducted. However, the Bank carried out 6 unplanned ESW over the CSP 2016-2020 period representing 54.5% of the 11 ESWs carried out over the 2011-2020 period (Technical Annex 9e). In addition to the ESW the Bank provided the Government with two institutional support operations, namely: i) assistance in implementing the new reform of the Public Procurement Code which became effective in February 2012; and ii) assistance in finalising the Public Finance Reform Master Plan (AfDB, 2015a: 7).

**Consideration of the Bank's comparative advantages in selecting interventions was rated satisfactory.** Given its long experience in infrastructure financing in Mauritania, the Bank identified agricultural infrastructure and energy infrastructure as its priority sectors during the 2016-2020 CSP. It has intervened in rural development where it played a lead and catalytic role. In this sector, the Bank has approved operations totalling USD 21.67 million, i.e. 20.1% of all TFP approvals in the sector and has mobilised USD 52.25 million in co-financing with other partners (AfDB, 2021a: Annex 9). However, the Bank did not approve any operations in the energy sector where it has an established comparative advantage, which led to the reformulation of its second pillar at the CSP 2016-2020 mid-term review (AfDB), 2019b: 18). This choice is fully in keeping with the commitment of the Bank's Management under the 7th General Capital Increase (GCI-VII), in particular, to increase selectivity by focusing operations on 30 strategic priorities selected on the basis of the following criteria that define its comparative advantage: its previous operations, its institutional guidance and capacities, requests from regional member countries, its mandate and position in Africa's regional architecture (AfDB, 2020h: 2). The Bank did not confine itself to those areas in which it is effectively leading or was the lead donor but undertook to identify the development priorities in which its investments could achieve the best outcomes given its past performances, its organisational capacity, and its mandate (AfDB, 2020h: 2). The evaluation excluded RBCSP 2011-2015 whose implementation preceded the GCI-VII commitments.

**Table 4:** Status of Planned and Approved Projects over the 2011-2020 Period

| | Planned projects | | Approved projects | | Gap | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| | Number | Amount (UA) | Number | Amount (UA) | Number | Amount (UA) |
| **CSP 2011-2015** | 10 | Not determined in CSP | 9 | 27 518 747.58 | 1 | 27 518 747.58 |
| *including: emergency assistance operations* | | | 2 | 1 263 651.95 | 2 | 1 263 651.95 |
| **CSP 2016-2020** | 16 | 100 741 423.44* | 15 | 126 746 027.49 | 1 | 26 004 604.05 |
| *including: emergency assistance operations* | | | 3 | 11 459 502.45 | 3 | 11 459 502.45 |
| **Total** | 26 | 100 741 423.44 | 24 | 154 264 775.07 | 2 | 53 523 351.63 |

* This amount concerns 10 projects. Information is not available for 6 projects.

Source: SAP PS data adapted by the team

An IDEV **Country Strategy Evaluation**

## Effectiveness of Bank Assistance

This section answers the following evaluation question: Did the CSP effectively achieve the development outcomes? In particular, the following three aspects of effectiveness were evaluated: a) the achievement of CSP results expected at the national level; b) the achievement of CSP results expected at pillar levels; and c) the achievement of the expected results of the operations approved during the evaluation period and completed or closed. The results of operations approved before the evaluation period, but completed or closed during the evaluation period, are presented for information.

*The effectiveness of the Bank's strategies and programmes was rated satisfactory overall. At the national level, two of the 4 objectives were achieved, which is satisfactory. Effectiveness was partly unsatisfactory at pillar level with only 27.2% of expected outputs delivered during the evaluation period. At the operational level, effectiveness is satisfactory for almost 60% of the expected outputs were delivered or deliverable and 83.3% of projects achieved the expected development outcomes. Performance improved over time (between CSP 2011-2015 and CSP 2016-2020), due to adjustments made at the mid-term reviews, the physical presence of a resident programme officer from 2018 and the strengthening of dialogue with the national authorities which made it possible to adapt to the change in context and eliminate constraints to the implementation of operations. This mixed performance is due to: the poor alignment of targeted outcomes at pillar level and those defined at the national and operational levels; frequent changes to the IOP; the gap between the lifespan of approved operations and the planning horizon for expected CSP outcomes; inadequate sizing of the expected outcomes at the CSP pillar and national levels given the estimated amount of resources for financing operations; and a highly constraining national context for the implementation of operations.*

The objectives and expected outcomes of each CSP at the pillar and national levels which serve as evaluation benchmarks are presented in detail in the above sub-section. The Bank has had a liaison office in Mauritania since 2013 (AfDB, 2019b: 8), with the senior programme officer as the only regular resident staff member coordinating operations in the country. He is assisted by local temporary staff. The Deputy Director-General for the North Region based outside the country assumes the role of country manager. The development and delivery of the Bank's services in Mauritania is carried out from units outside the country spread among the countries of the North Region and the Headquarters in Abidjan.

### Effectiveness at national level

**Effectiveness of the Bank's assistance at national level was rated satisfactory.** Two of the four objectives were achieved. One of the two objectives of RBCSP 2011-2015 was achieved. **The national poverty reduction objective** (AfDB, 2010: 16) was achieved and the national poverty rate fell from 42% in 2008 to 31% in 2014 while the rural extreme poverty rate dropped sharply from 40.8% in 2008 to 25.1% in 2014 (Mauritania, 2015). On the other hand, **the national objective of strengthening the competitiveness of the Mauritanian economy** was not achieved. The competitiveness index score fell from 3.14 (AfDB, 2015a: Annex 2) over the 2010-2011 period (compared to 4.65 for Tunisia) to 3.0 in 2014-2015 compared to an average of 3.9 for North Africa (AfDB/WEF/WB/OECD, 2015). One of the two targeted national outcomes of CSP 2016-2020 was achieved. **The first national objective of promoting inclusive (or shared) growth** was achieved. In this respect the GDP growth rate excluding extractive industries rose from 1.6% in 2016 to 5% in 2018. Between 2015 and 2018, 13618 businesses were established, including 1522 by women. Inclusion was strengthened by a drop in the percentage of vulnerable jobs from 54% in 2016 to 52% in 2019 (World Bank, 2022d). The percentage of salaried workers rose slightly from 42.8% in 2016 to 43.8% in 2019 (World Bank, 2022c). Although gross national income (GNI) per capita fell from

USD 3527 (2011 PPP dollars) in 2015 (UNDP, 2016: 226) to USD 1660 in 2019 (AfDB, 2021a: xxvi), the HDI score rose from 0.513 in 2015 to 0.520 in 2016 (AfDB, 2019b: 4-5) and reached 0.546 in 2019 (UNDP, 2020: 20, 27). Drinking water and sanitation access rates increased significantly from 2015 to 2018, but disparities persist between urban and rural areas. In 2018, the drinking water access rate was 80% nationally and 60% in rural areas. 46% of the population had access to improved sanitation services, 27% in rural areas and 84% in urban areas (AfDB, 2021a: 6). The rate of access to improved sanitation facilities was 40% in 2015, with 13% in rural areas and 57% in urban areas (AfDB, 2022f). Some 57% of the country's population had access to drinking water, with 58% in urban areas and 57% in rural areas. **The second national objective of promoting green growth** (AfDB, 2016:15) was not achieved in the targeted priority sectors. The Bank deferred its investments in the renewable energy sub-sector because of a lack of resources. Installed power generating capacity was 500 MW in 2018 with a renewable energy (hydro, solar and wind) share of 41% compared to 13.37% in 2015 (World Bank, 2022a). By factoring in 100MW of wind power under construction with support from other financial partners, renewable energy should soon account for an estimated 50% of the energy mix (AfDB, 2021a: 8).

## Effectiveness at pillar level

**The Bank's effectiveness at pillar level was rated partly unsatisfactory.** Eight (17.8%) of the 45 outputs expected at approval were either delivered or expected to be delivered by 31 December 2020. Five had been completely delivered. Considering the adjustments made at the mid-term review, the situation improved with 22 (27.2%) of the 81 expected outputs delivered or deliverable by 31 December 2020. 20 of them had been completely delivered. Analysis of the data shows an improvement in performance between approval and the mid-term review. The overall delivery rate rose from 8 outputs delivered out of the 45 expected (17.8%) to 22 outputs delivered out of the 81 expected (27.2%), thanks to the adjustment measures adopted at mid-term.[15] However, these adjustments were effective at the CSP 2011-2015 review which allowed the Bank to deliver relatively more outputs, up from 50% to 62.1%. But not in the case of CSP 2016-2020 for which the total delivery rate of revised outputs fell to 7.7% compared to 10.8% of outputs expected at approval. 42.9% of the strategic objectives/outcomes (pillars) for the two CSPs were achieved. The strengthening of policy dialogue with the country's authorities through the organisation of a seminar on Business Opportunities with the Bank (BOS) and more frequent missions by the Management of the North Africa Regional Directorate also played a positive role in the adaption to a change in context and the elimination of constraints to the implementation of operations.[16]

## Effectiveness at the level of completed or closed projects

At the end of the evaluation period, 8 of the 24 projects approved between 2011 and 2020 had been completed or closed and 16 were ongoing.

**The effectiveness of Bank projects completed or closed was satisfactory.** As of 31 December 2020, the Bank had delivered, or was likely to deliver, 31 of the 52 outputs expected at approval (59.6%); of this number, 28 were fully delivered. The team was unable to find information on 21 outputs (40.4%). Consideration of only those outputs whose status is known reveals that 23 of 27 expected outputs (85.2%) were delivered or deliverable by 31 December 2020; of this number 20 were fully delivered. However, the Bank has been more successful in delivering the expected outputs at project level than those expected at the strategic level of country development assistance. 83.3% of the project development outcomes were achieved. Assumption of duty by the Resident Programme Officer in Nouakchott in June 2018[17] (year of the Mid-term Review of CSP 2016-2008) helped to improve the monitoring of operations. However, weak government capacities already identified as a risk (AfDB/ADF, 2010a: 20; AfDB/ADF, 2016c: 21) impeded the smooth implementation of operations, especially because of delays and lack of skills (Box 1).

The document review and discussions at the Evaluation Reference Group Meeting on 22 February 2023 showed that four factors account for this satisfactory effectiveness at the operational and national levels and the partly unsatisfactory performance at pillar level: a) weaknesses in the theory of change with respect to Bank assistance especially the reliability of the causal relationship between the outcomes at the three levels of assistance programming (IOP, outcomes of operations, pillar outcomes and national outcomes). In other words, projects are aligned on a pillar, but their implementation does not contribute significantly to the expected pillar outputs because of improbable causal relationships (unreliable). b) IOP volatility with frequent changes of operations to be financed and expected pillar outcomes. c) The life span of approved operations does not correspond to the time horizon for the expected CSP outcomes - dual speed phenomenon. At CSP completion, some major operations had not yet delivered all their outputs, a

**Box 1:** Factors Related to Effectiveness at Project Level (2011-2020)

The implementation progress and results (IPR) reports and project completion reports (PCR) identified the factors presented below that enhanced or impeded the effectiveness of operation:

- **Public Investment Management Support Project (PAGIP):** The Borrower was sufficiently involved in the project, and Steering Committee meetings were held regularly. The Borrower maintained close cooperation with the project stakeholders including the Bank and was able to select additional activities that ensured the complete utilisation of all resources and consequently strengthened project outcomes. However, the project had to address some challenges linked to: 1) mobilization of the government's counterpart funds and implementation of activities related to this counterpart contribution; 2) the frequency of project reporting and the annual external audit; and 3) submission of the Borrower's completion report (AfDB, 2019c: 9).
- **Economic Reform and Diversification Support Programme (PAREDE 1 & 2):** Mauritanian authorities were consistent in complying with the commitments agreed upon with the Bank. They made all the necessary efforts throughout the project's two phases, thereby guaranteeing the smooth implementation of planned measures and reforms. The Borrower fulfilled the conditions precedent and disbursement formalities for the tranches paid (loans and grant) within the time limits. The Mauritanian Government involved all the project stakeholders to lay the foundations for the programme's sustainability. A monitoring and evaluation system was established by the Ministry of Economy and Finance which forwarded all the necessary information for the Reforms Monitoring Matrix (AfDB, 2019a: 12).
- **Agricultural Transformation Support Project (PATAM):** The project had to address the following challenges: weak intersectoral coordination capacity at the national and local levels; climate hazards and frequent droughts; limited institutional capacity of stakeholders and insufficient human and physical resources at SONADER to monitor and implement the projects; problem of financial inclusion and access to financing and credit; poor upkeep and maintenance of hydro-agricultural facilities; bottlenecks in procurement, issuance of bidding documents and disbursements (AfDB, 2020i: 3-4).
- **Project for Improving Climate Resilience of Water Sector Investments (REVUWI):** The project addressed the following challenges: delays in the procurement process; non-compliance with the Bank's environmental and social regulations; slippage on the preparation of certain activities (such as the preparation of technical guidelines on adaptation best practices or an inventory of good climate change practices); poor correlation between some project indicators and activities; not easily measurable indicators as well as poor budget planning and project financial management shortcomings (AfDB, 2020j: 2-3).
- **Financial Infrastructure Modernisation Support Project (PAMIF):** The poor performance of the project team resulted in a project performance that fell short of the targets of standard indicators (AfDB, 2020k: 2-3)
- **ROSSO Bridge Construction Project:** The factors impeding implementation are: i) delays in paying compensation for expropriation; ii) non-existence of transport facilitation and transit measures resulting in little or no reduction in transit times; iii) lack of bridge maintenance because of insufficient resources; iv) increase in construction costs; and v) environmental risks (AfDB, 2020l: 4).

**Table 5:** Results of Bank Projects in Mauritania (2011-2020)

| High 5 | Results |
|---|---|
| **#2: Feed Africa** | Vegetable production gardening output rose from 0 to 50t/ha in the the wilayas of Gorgol, the Braknas and Tagant with a total rural population of 736 000 inhabitants (AfDB, 2020m: 4). |
| | Some 366 ha of agricultrual land was restored and protected against water erosion (AfDB, 2020n: 4) |
| | 205 sheep and 212 goats were delivered on-site to beneficiaries (AfDB, 2020n: 5). |
| **#3: Industrialise Africa** | Mauritania reduced the export time by 10 hours within 5 years; from 72 hours in 2015 to 62 hours in 2019 (ADF, 2020: 5). |
| | Mauritania reduced the import time by 57 hours; from 126 hours in 2015 to 69 hours in 2019. |
| **#5: Improve the quality of life for the people of Africa** | The human development index (HDI) rose from 0.513 in 2015 to 0.520 in 2017 (AfDB, 2019a: 6). |
| | The Gender Inequality Index (GII) improved from 0.643 in 2012 to 0.617 in 2017 (AfDB, 2019c: 5). |
| | The GDP growth rate, excluding extractive industries, which was 1.6% in 2016 surged to 5% in 2018 (AfDB, 2019a:6 ). |
| | Creation of 8100 new jobs (AfDB, 2020f: 4). |
| | 13,618 businesses created from 1/1/2015 to 31/12/2018, including 1522 by women. No statistics available for young people (AfDB, 2020o: 5). |
| | Creation of 2750 operational MSEs (AfDB, 2020f: 4). |
| | The average rate of return for MSEs rose from 15% to 25% and average annual revenue for MSEs rose from 450 000 to 600 000 MRO/yr. (AfDB, 2020f: 4). |
| | In 2018, 10,129 young people, 48% of whom were women benefited from professional support and integration services (AfDB 2020g: 3). |
| | 140 people (including 50 women) trained in project design, monitoring and evaluation (AfDB, 2019c: 4).<br>40 male members of smallholder organisations trained in the areas of gender, leadership and value chains;<br>170 producers trained; 50 fishermen trained in fishing techniques; 250 young people trained in agriculture and rural entrepreneurship including 150 young women (AfDB, 2020n: 5). 100 users trained in customs procedures; 25 people from the one-stop-shop trained (AfDB, 2020o: 6-7). |
| | 500 SME trained in entrepreneurship; 250 SMEs trained and given access to bank financing (AfDB, 2020o: 6). |
| | The microfinance institutions' coverage of project financing needs increased from 30% in 2014 to 60%. |
| | PNISER installed 24 new solar drinking water facilities and 15 water towers (AfDB, 2020m: 4). 140 localities became ODF, 3726 household built latrines and 1000 latrines built from partial subsidies to families. 10 drinking water networks were rehabilitated. 47 boreholes and 2 water retention ponds constructed (AfDB, 2020m: 6) |
| | The average drinking water access rate rose from 53% (baseline at the beginning of the REVUWI project) to 81% in the south of Mauritania (AfDB, 2020j: 4) |
| | The volume of water available per head of cattle rose from 0 to 10l following the construction of 8 new pastoral stations under PNISER |

Sources: AfDB, 2020o: 5-7; AfDB, 2020m: 4, 6; AfDB, 2020n: 4-5; AfDB, 2020j: 4; AfDB, 2020g: 3; AfDB, 2020f: 4; AfDB, 2019c: 4-5; AfDB, 2019a: 6; ADF, 2020: 5

**Table 6:** Summary of Performance Scores for Effectiveness

| Indicators | Score |
|---|---|
| **50% of CSP national objectives/outcomes achieved** | 3 |
| **42.9% of CSP strategic objectives/outcomes (pillars) achieved** | 2 |
| **27.2 % of expected pillar outputs delivered or likely to be delivered** | 2 |
| **40% of projects completed or closed during the period delivered all the expected outputs** | 2 |
| **59.6% of expected project outputs were delivered or likely to be delivered** | 3 |
| **83.3% of projects achieved the planned development outcomes** | 3 |
| **Average score** | 2.5 |

phenomenon heightened by accumulated slippage on implementation. d) The expected outcome targets at CSP pillar and national levels do not correspond to the planned level of resources for financing operations.

### Contribution to development results of projects approved before 2011 and completed or closed during this period

The list of these operations with their characteristics is presented in Annex 3. This section informs stakeholders of the results achieved by the Bank in the context of operations that would not otherwise have been noticed for they did not fall within the scope of this evaluation. This concerns seven projects in the water and sanitation, finance, agriculture and rural development and social sector as well as the multi-sector.

Phase I of the **Integrated Water Resources Management Project (IWRM)** was approved in 2007 and closed in 2015 (P-MR-EAZ-004). The IWRM project: i) established the Permanent Committee of the National Water Council (CPCNE) and the Brakna Regional Water Council (CRE) and helped the National Water Council (CNE) to meet in Brakna; ii) built knowledge and capacity at local level; iii) involved all the local actors; iv) digitized and edited regional maps and prepared a database on hydraulic equipment and infrastructure, encouraging the design of digital tools and monitoring/evaluation mapping of water resource governance policies (AfDB, 2015b: 5-6).

Implementation of the **Rural Drinking Water Supply and Sanitation Project in the Southern Region (PAEPA)** approved in 2006 and closed in 2015 (P-MR-EA0-005) resulted in the construction of: i) 52 boreholes and 54 drinking water supply (DWS) systems in communities with over 500 inhabitants; ii) 72 institutional latrine blocks in public places; and iii) 13 100 family constructed home latrines following the establishment of pilot community-led total sanitation (CLTS) facilities in 440 villages.

The **Line of Credit (LoC) to Mauritania-leasing** (P-MR-HAB-004) approved in 2008 and closed in 2013 financed 13 sub-projects for a total amount of almost UA 3.5 million. Financing of their activities provided consumers with a wider range of products. These sub-projects concern the following sectors: industry (23%), public and civil works (38%), transport and tourism (18%) and trade (21%) (AfDB, 2013b: 4)

The **LoC to BCI** (P-MR-HAB-003) was approved in 2008 and closed in 2013. This LoC, exceeding UA 5.6 million, was used to finance 30 businesses (new and expansion of existing ones), thereby increasing the amount of credit granted to the private sector in 5 sub-projects that were financed (25% of the 20 targeted projects): 3 in infrastructure; 1 in general services and 1 in telecom (AfDB, 2013a: 6).

The **Capacity Building Project for Microfinance Actors (PRECAMF)** approved in 2007 and closed in 2014 (P-MR-IE0-004) in the finance sector provided institutional support to relay structures of microfinance institutions (MFI) in rural areas as well as additional support to establish credit funds and build the economic capacities of promoters of income generating activities (IGA) and micro-and small enterprises (MSE). The project did result in an increase in IGAs and MSEs that maintain accounting records by training 20 000 IGA promoters and 1800 MSE promoters; the establishment of 21 credit funds in rural areas and 48 autonomous funds. All the beneficiary MFIs have a geographic information system (GIS) and transmit their data (AfDB, 2018a: 18). These results increased the MFI loan portfolio to MRO 1.85 billion, which exceeds the targeted objective of MRO 1.6 billion (AfDB, 2018a: 17). PRECAMF also contributed to the development of national expertise in microfinance, as materialized by the establishment of a Microfinance Directorate (AfDB, 2018a: 7). The project also successfully diversified and increased demand for financial services by improving the access to information on financial products related to IGA and MSE (AfDB, 2018a: 18).

The **Hydro-agricultural Development Project in West Brakna (PAHABO)** was approved in 2004 and closed in 2015 (P-MR-AAC-007). West Brakna is one of the country's poorest areas. The poverty rate is 71% compared to 55% nationally. The project affected 15,454 beneficiaries, which is more than the 10 500 targeted, and especially women who represent 57% of the rural poor. PAHABO established production support infrastructure that led in particular to the development of about 950 ha for rice-farming, 5600 ha of flood-recession farmland and 106 ha of women's vegetable production gardening areas (WVPGA), thereby helping to reduce poverty and improve the beneficiaries' food security. It also opened up access to the area by constructing 68km of dyke road between Boghé and Mboyo and two 19.3 km access roads linking it to the asphalted Rosso-Boghé road (including 64 new crossing facilities and the rehabilitation of 3 existing ones). The project improved the population's living conditions by expanding access to drinking water for 11 000 inhabitants of 20 localities. The Diou water supply system was restored by cleansing 2.6 km of the Kondo tributary, constructing 15.9 km of wastewater outfalls around the Diou loop and building 3 control facilities. Similarly, the Ndiorol system was recalibrated over more than 24 km, the transit capacity of the Siske facility was tripled, 12 drainpipes and 4 marshland crossing points comprising one submersible paved ford and three scuppers were constructed. The project laid the foundations of a process for the creation of smallholder organisations by supporting the establishment of 43 rice farming cooperatives, 95 women's vegetable production gardening cooperatives, 7 flood-recession farming cooperatives, 2 economic interest groups (EIGs) and 3 zonal user associations (AfDB, 2015c: 6-7). These cooperatives require further capacity-building which was planned in the second phase. Additional assistance was provided to women by constructing a vegetable storage/packaging centre with a capacity of 80 tonnes as well as offering various training courses and technical support.

## Sustainability

This section answers the following evaluation question: Were the CSP achievements continued and/or likely to continue after the assistance provided had ended? The evaluation team first assessed the extent to which the outcomes of completed or closed operations continued and/or were likely to continue after the assistance provided had ended. It then assessed the extent to which the operations had considered key aspects of sustainable development (CMED, 1987), which is central to the Bank's Ten-Year Strategy. Theoretically, the sustainability of the Bank's achievements after project completion is determined by: a) the level of project ownership by beneficiaries; b) the capacity of beneficiaries to ensure continuity of project services (through the mobilization or building of local capacity by the Bank); and c) the implementation of the Bank's environmental and social safeguards standards in Category I and II projects (Table 7). These are the three pillars of sustainable development (CMED, 1987).

*The sustainability of the Bank's strategies and programs was rated satisfactory overall but some aspects require closer attention, in particular the strengthening or mobilization of local capacities in Bank projects and the inclusion in project design of mechanisms to ensure the sustainability of the achievements including revenue collection to finance recurrent costs and their effective implementation. Monitoring of the implementation of environmental and social management measures was rated partly unsatisfactory. Improving the mainstreaming of these aspects (exit strategy) is necessary to guarantee sustainability of the achievements of the Bank's assistance to the country.*

**The Bank's performance in terms of sustainability of achievements was rated highly satisfactory.** All completed or closed projects[18] (100%) had outcomes which continued and/or were likely to continue after the end of the assistance. Emergency Humanitarian Assistance to Drought Victims and Malian Refugees (P-MR-AAZ-003) and Emergency Humanitarian Assistance Nouakchott (P-MR-EBO-005) were not considered in the assessment of this aspect of sustainability.

**Table 7:** Summary of Performance Scores for Sustainability

| Indicator | Score | Average |
|---|---|---|
| 100% of completed or closed operations had outcomes which continued and/or were likely to continue after the end of the assistance provided. | 4 | 4 |
| **Beneficiaries' level of ownership of Bank projects** | | **3** |
| 100% of projects approved between 2011 and 2020 which were completed or closed during the period involved the target communities | 4 | |
| 33.3% of projects approved between 2011 and 2020 which were completed or closed during the period implemented a mechanism to ensure the sustainability of achievements | 2 | |
| 33.3% of projects approved between 2011 and 2020 which were completed or closed during the period implemented a revenue collection mechanism to finance recurrent costs | 2 | |
| 100% of projects approved between 2011 and 2020 which were completed or closed during the period incorporated the Project Implementation Unit (PIU) into the services of the oversight ministry | 4 | |
| **Local capacity-building or mobilisation in Bank interventions** | | **2** |
| 42.9% of projects approved between 2011 and 2020 which were completed or closed during the period implemented one or more activities to strengthen the country's technical or institutional capacity | 2 | |
| **Compliance with the Bank's environmental and social safeguard standards** | | **2** |
| 20% of cat. I & II projects approved between 2011 and 2020 documented the implementation of environmental and social impact mitigation measures, including those linked to related conditions precedent. | 2 | |
| 33.3% of cat I & II projects approved between 2011 and 2020 effectively designated/ appointed an Officer within the PIU, to monitor and report on ESMP implementation and/or resettlement/ compensation of the affected population | 2 | |
| 28.6% of Cat I & II projects approved between 2011 and 2020 had a budget for monitoring and reporting on ESMP implementation, which is actually made available according to Bank or borrower supervision reports | 2 | |
| **Sustainability, average score** | | **3** |

Beneficiaries' level of ownership of Bank projects

Theoretically, guaranteeing the sustainability (or persistence) of project's achievements is contingent on the beneficiaries' level of ownership which itself hinges on 4 key factors: i) involving beneficiaries in the design and implementation; ii) establishing a mechanism for the sustainability of achievements after completion; iii) establishing a mechanism for the mobilisation of own revenues to finance recurrent costs; and iv) integrating the project implementation Unit (PIU) into the oversight public administration's services, at the national and regional levels. This theoretical assumption underpinned the assessment of the project's ownership level and chances of sustainability of its achievements after completion.

**Regarding the involvement of the target beneficiaries in completed or closed projects, the Bank's performance was rated highly satisfactory.** The Bank involved beneficiaries in all projects approved during the period, except for humanitarian aid projects for which information is not available.

**Regarding the inclusion of outcome sustainability mechanisms in project design and implementation, the Bank's performance was rated partly unsatisfactory.** The Bank implemented such mechanism in 2 out of 6 projects[19] (33.3%). The Project Preparation Facility (PPF) financed the technical studies of the Hydro-Agricultural Development Project in West Brakna, Phase II (PAHABO II), which eventually led to implementation under the name Africa Agricultural Transformation Support Project (PATAM) (AfDB, 2018b: 9). In addition, provision was made for the proposal of a consistent and realistic concept for the establishment of a maintenance and service fund (MSF) managed jointly by the administration and user representatives (AfDB, 2014a: 26-27). However, it was provided for within the design of 5 of the 6 completed or closed projects, or 83.3%. This raises concerns that the facility will not be implemented in 10 of the 16 ongoing projects (62.5%) which had provided for it. It is not enough to include this feature in the project design, it is necessary to monitor its effective implementation.

**Regarding the inclusion of a revenue collection mechanism in project design and implementation to finance recurrent project costs after completion, the Bank's performance was rated partly unsatisfactory.** Two of the 6 projects which were completed or closed (33.3%) implemented the mechanism. These were the Public Investment Management Support Project (PIMSP) (AfDB, 2019c: 8) and the line of credit provided to the Bank for Trade and Industry for trade financing (AfDB, 2013a: 15). This mechanism was scheduled to be implemented in 3 projects. The team did not get information on the mechanism's implementation status in 4 completed or closed projects, and therefore concluded that it was not implemented, as this would have been mentioned in the reports if it was the case. It is noteworthy that 13 of the 18 ongoing projects (72.2%) planned to implement the mechanism.

**As concerns establishing public sector Project Implementation Units (PIUs) in supervisory ministries or specialised Government agencies, the Bank's performance was rated highly satisfactory.** PIUs for all Bank projects were thus set up (100%), both for completed or closed projects and for those ongoing. This enabled the public services concerned to capitalise on the know-how and to appropriate material and equipment acquired during the projects' implementation, thus strengthening their organisational capacity. In accordance with the applicable Bank's operational guidelines, the implementation and monitoring of relief operations financed from its resources were carried out by i) a United Nations agency - in this case, the World Food Programme (WFP) - regarding the operation "Emergency Humanitarian Assistance to Drought Victims and Malian Refugees" in 2012; and ii) specialised government agencies: a) the National Sanitation Authority (ONAS) for operation "Emergency Humanitarian Aid Nouakchott" in 2014; and b) the Food Security Commission (CSA) for operation "Emergency Humanitarian Aid to Flood Victims in the Guidimakha Wilaya" in 2019. The same was true in 2020 for the social sector operation "Support project for G5 Sahel Member Countries to Combat the Coronavirus Pandemic" which was implemented by the Executive Secretariat of the G5 Sahel which includes 5 countries of the sub-region.

Non-sovereign operations were conducted within beneficiary companies. These included two lines of credit granted respectively to the Bank for Trade and Industry (BCI) and the *Banque Populaire de Mauritanie* (BPM), and the dredging project[20] financed by a corporate loan to the Société Nationale Industrielle et Minière (National Industrial and Mining Company - SNIM), an enterprise in the industries, mines, and quarries sector.

**Strengthening or mobilising local technical capacity in Bank interventions was rated partly unsatisfactory.** Three of the seven completed or closed projects (42.9%) whose information is available carried out capacity-building activities. The Bank's assistance in the financial sector built BCI's capacity by improving its internal procedures for recording and updating client data. In the governance sector, henceforth, it is possible to accurately track public investments and their implementation rates. All ministries and structures involved in public investments are connected to the electronic Development Assistance Database (DAD) which has increased the capacity to design, monitor and evaluate public investment projects. In the agricultural sector, the technical capacities of rice and vegetable cooperatives were built, by increasing their project management capacity, accelerating agricultural transformation, and enhancing value chains.

Compliance with and implementation of the Bank's environmental and social safeguards standards

In accordance with the Bank's integrated safeguard system, this aspect concerns only the 2 category I and 5 category II projects in the evaluation portfolio (Table 8).

**Documentation on the implementation of environmental and social safeguards of category I & II projects, including those related to conditions precedent, was rated partly unsatisfactory.** Only one (1) of the five (5) category I & II projects for which information is available (20%) documented the implementation of environmental and social management measures. Indeed, P2RS recruited a consultant to support the Nature Protection Directorate (DPN) within the framework of the strategic environmental assessment and developed an environmental monitoring guide (AfDB, 2020n: 12). It should be noted that data is not available for the 2 category I projects which are however "likely to induce significant irreversible adverse environmental and/or social impact, or likely to significantly affect environmental or social components considered sensitive by the AfDB or the borrowing country" (AfDB, not dated:6). Moreover, the portfolio is impaired by the non-rigorous implementation of environmental and social management plans (ESMPs) to minimise the risks and negative impacts of investment projects. Indeed, there are no local environmentalists and the few available have limited knowledge of applicable safeguard instruments and of the requirements for periodic monitoring of key environmental and social (E&S) performance indicators. However, the Bank had planned to build the required capacities in projects it finances (AfDB, 2021a: 15). With the threat of suspension of disbursements in case of failure to submit periodic environmental and social monitoring reports and an environmental and social compliance note (ESCON) validated by the Bank's Sector Director and Director of the Department of Safeguards and Compliance (SNSC) for Category I & II projects, and the reform of the project concept note and project appraisal report templates (effective September 2022), ESMP implementation reports are submitted more regularly.

**Compliance with the deadline for the publication of the ESIA & ESMP summaries of cat. I & II projects was rated partly unsatisfactory.** Only the non-sovereign category I project with SNIM published summaries 77 days before the Bank's Board review, i.e. within the required timeframe of at least 60 days for non-sovereign operations. The other 6 category I & II projects did not provide any information, revealing a gap in monitoring and evaluation during the assessment period. However, this shortcoming was corrected through internal measures taken by the Bank since September 2022 as mentioned above.

**The monitoring of ESMP implementation by an officer appointed within the PIU was rated partly unsatisfactory.** An environmental and social monitoring officer was appointed in the P2RS, the only one among the 6 Cat. I & II projects (33.3%) for which information is available, as evidenced by the existence of periodic reports on the implementation of the ESMP and/or the resettlement/compensation of the affected population (ADB, 2020n: 2). Meanwhile, provision is made for this position within the implementation units of all 6 Cat. I & II projects.[21]

**Regarding the provision of a budget for monitoring and periodic reporting on ESMP implementation, the Bank's performance was**

**Table 8:** Environmental Categories of Projects (2011-2020)

| | Cat. 1 & 2 | Cat. 3 | Cat. 4 | Cat. 9 | Not concerned |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Projects concerned, number | 7 | 11 | 2 | 1 | 3 |
| Projects concerned, UA million | 98.00 | 34.91 | 18.81 | 0.63 | 1.89 |

Source: Annex 10

**rated partly unsatisfactory.** This budget was made available in 2 of the 6 category I & II projects for which information is available (28.6%). These are PATAM (AfDB, 2020i: 9) and P2RS (AfDB, 2020n: 6). It was envisaged in the design of 4 of the 6 projects (66.7%). This lack of budget mobilization is likely to compromise the effective monitoring of compliance with the Bank's environmental and social management commitments. A distinction must be made between: i) the existence of a budget allocation in the ESMP to finance its implementation and monitoring; and ii) the actual provision and execution of this budget. If a budget is provided for in the ESMP and is not included in the project costing table at the design stage, the implementation team will not be able to use project funds to finance the activity. Where the expenditure is included in the project costs, these funds must effectively be mobilized and made available to the officer in charge of ESMP implementation. ■


SENDO

# Design and Management of Bank Operations in the Country

Internal and external coherence, efficiency, and mainstreaming of cross-cutting issues reflect the way the Bank designed its operations in the country and managed them through supervision.

## Internal and External Coherence

This section focuses on the following evaluation question: To what extent are the Bank's operations in the country consistent with each other, and have they established synergies with the initiatives of other development partners?

According to the OECD (2019: 9), internal coherence is the extent to which the Bank's operations in the country complement each other. It defines external coherence as the synergy between the Bank's operations and those of other development partners in the country. These two aspects were assessed based on: a) the proportion of Bank portfolio operations deemed complementary; and b) the proportion of Bank portfolio operations which have explicit complementary links with the operations of other partners in the country.

*The coherence of Bank operations was rated satisfactory. Of the Bank's 19 projects (excluding emergency aid projects), 17 complement each other (internal coherence). Better still, all Bank projects complement the operations of at least two development partners active in Mauritania (external coherence).*

**The internal coherence of Bank projects was rated satisfactory.** Indeed, 17 of the 24 projects (70.83%) are complementary. Excluding the five emergency aid projects raises this rate to 89.5%. The Bank did not link its emergency aid operations with its ongoing projects in the country, thus missing an opportunity to strengthen the resilience of aid beneficiaries and ensure the sustainability of achievements.

**The external coherence of Bank projects with the operations of other TFPs was rated highly satisfactory.** All 22 projects for which information is available (100%) had complementary links with the operations of at least two partners in the country. Even for emergency aid operations, the Bank systematically coordinated its operations with the other TFPs. In 2019, Mauritania received USD 3697.75 million in official development assistance (ODA) from several TFPs, led by the Arab Fund for Economic and Social Development (AFESD), Germany, the Organisation of Petroleum Exporting Countries (OPEC), the World Bank (WB) and China. The AfDB with USD 124.4 million is in the 8th position with more than 50% of its commitments in the rural development sector. Aid is coordinated by the General Directorate of Investment Projects and Programmes of the Ministry of Economic Affairs and Development. There is a consultation platform between the government and the TFPs[22] (ADF, 2013a:5), within which there are already operational groups: the governance group (GS-Governance), the private sector development group, the food security group, the water and sanitation and agriculture group[23] (AfDB, 2012a: 2). These bodies meet regularly at the technical level under the chairmanship of previously designated leaders. From early 2014, they have been contributing to the quarterly State-TFP consultation meetings. The Bank also participates in the proceedings of the 5 TFP sector coordination groups and co-chairs the private sector group with the WB. The Bank has forged a strategic partnership with the WB through joint initiatives to support national authorities in the promotion of public-private partnerships (PPPs). The Bank is also part of the technical committee set up by the national authorities, to advise and guide the government on strategic issues and the preparation of State-Donor meetings, alongside the WB, EU, and UNDP (AfDB, 2017b: 7).

## Efficiency

The Bank doubled the number of operations from 11 under CSP 2011-2015 to 21 under CSP 2016-2020, despite the lessons from the implementation of the 2006-2007 Interim CSP: "to avoid too much dispersion of Bank operations and (...) to maintain a selective approach given Mauritania's relatively modest allocation" (AfDB/ADF, 2010: 16). However, the average budget of operations increased by 141% between 2011-2015 and 2016-2020, due to two large operations. These are the dredging project with the National Industrial and Mining Company (SNIM), the only project in the industry/mining/quarrying sector (UA 34.7 million); and the Rosso bridge construction project which is the only transport operation (UA 25 million), as opposed to the multitude of operations in the other sectors, which have an average budget of UA 1.6 to 3.9 million.

Considering the IOP at approval and the mid-term adjustment of the CSP 2016-2020, Mauritania planned to obtain UA 95.52 million to finance the operations of the period. It managed to mobilize UA 126.75 million (Table 2), a success rate of 132%. This corresponds to 1.32 times its PBA, indicating that: a) efforts have been made to mobilize more resources for Mauritania's development, and b) there is residual scope for mobilizing additional funds.

This section contributes to answering the following assessment question: Has the CSP converted its inputs into benefits efficiently? The efficiency assessment focuses on: a) timeliness of operations at various stages of the project cycle;[24] b) adherence to the allocated budget; and c) use of allocated resources, especially the disbursement rate according to the project's age.[25] On this last point, data on cost-benefit and cost-effectiveness analysis (administrative costs per million UA disbursed) in Mauritania could not be obtained. Box 1 presents the internal and external factors which helped or hindered the efficiency of the Bank's operations.

**Table 9:** Some Sovereign Operations Standards

| Design of operations | |
|---|---|
| Time between negotiation conclusion date and approval date | Max. 4 months |
| Creation of project implementation entities | No later than the date of approval of the financing |
| Preparation and validation of project procurement plans | Prior to funding approval |
| **Implementation of operations** | |
| First disbursement from the date of funding approval | Max. 6 months |
| **Cancellation of loans or grants** | |
| The loan, grant or guarantee is approved but unsigned | More than 90 days and a cumulative period of 180 days from the date of approval |
| No disbursements have been made for a continuous period | 180 days |

Source: Presidential Directive PD 2/2015

*The efficiency of the Bank's strategies and programs was rated satisfactory. While performance was highly satisfactory in terms of adherence to the allocated budget and satisfactory in terms of adherence to implementation deadlines with half of the projects completed or closed in good time. Nevertheless, two bottlenecks reduced the efficiency of operations: delays prior to implementation and a low disbursement rate. The bottlenecks are apparent both at the level of national stakeholders and within the Bank.*

Presidential Directive PD 2/2015 concerning the Design, Implementation, and Cancellation of Bank Group Sovereign Operations was used as a reference for the efficiency assessment. Table 9 above presents some related standards.

**Compliance with deadlines prior to the implementation of operations was rated partly unsatisfactory.** Table 10 below shows delays in the appraisal of operations, prior to the start of implementation. The time lapse for operations' effectiveness worsened from 3.6 months between 2011-2015 to 4.7 months between 2016-2020, although it remained well below the critical threshold of 6 months. The average time from approval to first disbursement improved from 8.9 months in 2011-2015 to 7.3 months in 2016-2020. However, more efforts are needed to meet the standard of 6 months maximum. This delay is more marked in the industry/mining/quarrying sector (24.5 months), transport (13.7 months), water and sanitation (9 months) and agriculture (8 months). Financial, social, and multi-sector operations made their first disbursement within less than 6 months.

It is worth noting that the preparation period for projects financed by non-sovereign loans is longer, due to the required due diligence.

**Compliance with implementation deadlines for completed/closed projects was rated**

**Table 10:** Average Time Lapse between Project Cycle Stages

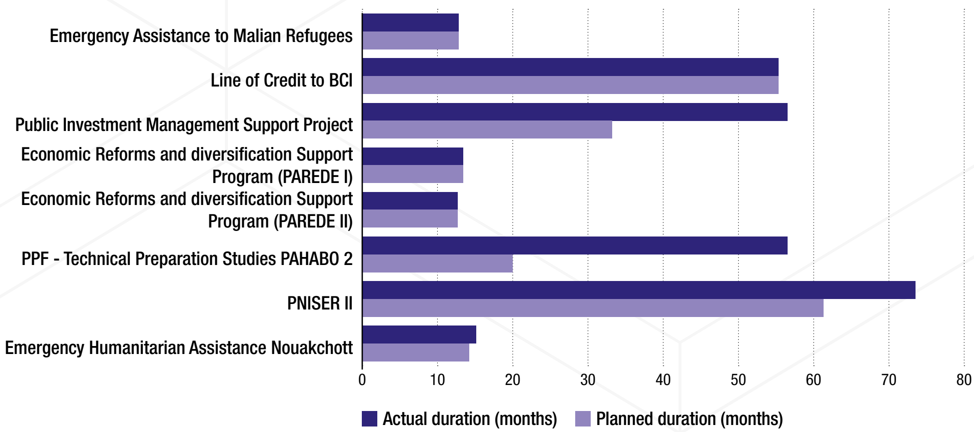
| | Approval - Signature | Signature - Effectiveness | Mise en vigueur - 1st disbursement | Approval - 1st disbursement |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| | in number of months | | | |
| **Public sector operations** | **1.7** | **2.4** | **3.1** | **7.3** |
| Project preparation study | 0.5 | 0.0 | 10.2 | 10.8 |
| Programmatic support programme | 0.8 | 4.4 | 0.4 | 5.6 |
| Institutional support | 1.8 | 1.1 | 3.8 | 6.3 |
| Emergency operation | 2.1 | 0.3 | 0.5 | 2.0 |
| Public investment | 2.2 | 3.8 | 3.8 | 9.8 |
| **Private sector operations** | **7.1** | **0.0** | **5.8** | **12.1** |
| Direct loan | 7.3 | 0.0 | 17.2 | 24.5 |
| Line of credit | 5.8 | 0.0 | 0.1 | 5.9 |
| Guarantee | 8.4 | - | - | - |
| **Combined** | **2.6** | **2.2** | **3.4** | **7.8** |

Source: Annex 2a

**satisfactory.** Indeed, four of the eight projects completed/closed between 2011 and 2020 (50%) were on schedule (Figure 3). With the inclusion of ongoing projects, 12 of the 24 projects implemented during that period were extended at least once, and even five times in some cases. The average number of extensions is 2.25 (Technical Annex 11). The average implementation period of the six projects for which information is available was 36.98 months, which is 1.33 times longer than the average planned duration (27.88 months). Except for transport, all sectors were affected by these delays and extensions, but to varying degrees (Table 11).

Implementation delays stemmed from a number of factors including: i) the interruption of activities during the COVID-19 lock-downs; ii) the late and partial mobilization of the national counterpart contribution which lengthen the timeframe for first disbursement; iii) procurement setbacks at the start of implementation, due to the late recruitment of the procurement expert; iv) delays in the execution of some signed contracts; and v) bottlenecks and poor mastery of applicable Bank rules and procedures (AfDB, 2020g: 2; AfDB, 2020f: 3). The Bank was unable to address these obstacles which hampered proper implementation, partly due to irregular project supervision over the 2011-2020 period. Indeed, no

**Figure 3:** Planned Duration and Effective Duration of Closed/Completed Projects (in months)




Source: Calculation by the authors based on SAP extraction

**Table 11:** Project Extensions in the Bank's Sectors of Intervention

| Sectors | Number of projects | Number of extensions |
|---|---|---|
| Multi-sector (governance) | 5 | 3.5 |
| Social | 3 | 3 |
| Agriculture | 6 | 2.5 |
| Water and sanitation | 4 | 1.75 |
| Finance | 4 | 1 |
| Industry/mining/quarries | 1 | 1 |
| Transport | 1 | 0 |
| | **24** | |

Source: SAP PS internal data

project met the standard of at least 2 supervisions per year (AfDB, 2014 b: 239), except for the following projects for which 2 supervision missions were carried out in some years: PNISER, PAFEJ, PAGOCI, and PAGIP.

**Compliance with the allocated budgets was rated highly satisfactory.** All 8 completed/closed projects for which information is available made use of their initial budgets without any overruns. PAGIP saved about USD 521 000 (AfDB, 2019c: 6; ADF, not dated a: 8) and reinvested it by adding a public investment management module to the DAD software.

**The disbursement rate was rated unsatisfactory.** The projects' average disbursement rate during the period (excluding completed/closed projects) was 35.6% with an average age of 3.5 years (Tables 12 and 13), down from 61.4% in 2013 and 41% in the 2012 portfolio review (AfDB, 2013a: 12). Four projects were of particular concern: i) the Rosso Bridge Construction Project approved in January 2016, with a rate of 1.3%; ii) the Project for Improving Climate Resilience of Water Sector Investments (REVUWI), approved in July 2016, with a disbursement rate of 4.6%; iii) the Agricultural Transformation Support Project approved in December 2018, with a disbursement rate of 9.5%; and iv) the Financial Infrastructure Modernisation Support Project (PAMIF) approved in December 2017, with a disbursement rate of 12.2%. The disbursement rate for completed or closed projects was 99.5%. Indeed, all completed or closed projects

**Table 12:** Disbursement Profile by Sector and by Project Age Group*

| Age | Agriculture | Govern-ance/Multi-sector | Finance | Social | Transport | Water & Sanitation | Industry/ mining/ quarry | Combined |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| | Disbursement rate | | | | | | | |
| ]0-2 years] | 0.0% | 100.0% | 0.0% | 88.8% | | | | 78.2% |
| ]2-4 years] | 9.5% | | 12.2% | | | | 20.0% | 16.8% |
| ]4-6 years] | | | 100.0% | 57.1% | 1.3% | 4.6% | | 19.2% |
| ]6-8 years] | 68.1% | 84.5% | | 84.3% | | | | 72.3% |
| ]8-10 years] | | | | | | 88.1% | | 88.1% |
| **Average** | **34.1%** | **96.7%** | **59.8%** | **76.0%** | **1.3%** | **59.5%** | **20.0%** | **35.6%** |

* These are projects with an ongoing or approved status. Completed or closed projects are not included.
Sources: Annexes 2a and 2b; Team calculations based on SAP PS data

**Table 13:** Disbursement Profile by Project Type* (%)

| | Disbursement rate | Average project age (years) |
|---|---|---|
| **Public sector projects** | **38.3%** | **3.41** |
| Institutional support | 40.2% | 3.26 |
| Emergency operation | 25.8% | 0.73 |
| Public investment | 28.8% | 4.86 |
| **Private sector projects** | **29.8%** | **3.86** |
| Direct loan | 20% | 3.11 |
| Line of credit | 100% | 4.62 |
| **Average** | **35.6%** | **3.46** |

* These are projects with an ongoing or approved status. Completed or closed projects are not included.
Sources: Annexes 2a and 2b; Evaluation team calculations based on SAP PS data

fully disbursed allocated funds, except for the Technical Study Preparation of PAHABO Phase II, an operation financed by the project preparation fund, with a disbursement rate of 83% (Annex 2b).

Table 13 presents the disbursement profile by project type. It shows that disbursements are lower in private sector projects (excluding guarantees) with 29.8% for an average age of 3.86 years, compared to public sector projects (38.3% with an average age of 3.41 years).

Disbursement constraints include: i) new approvals which lower the rate; ii) commencement delays; iii) delays and poor mastery of applicable Bank rules and procedures; iv) low quality at entry; and v) poor quality of disbursement requests and of supporting documents for advance payments. The parliamentary procedure required for ratification of loan and grant agreements also causes delays. For example, the PAMIF supplementary loan approved in April 2020 and signed in July 2020 has not been ratified by parliament to date (AfDB, 2021a: 15-16, Annex 1 and Annex 7). A few key actions are already under way to remedy this: i) the Bank regularly transmits the status of confirmed disbursements for all projects to the Ministry of Economic Affairs and Promotion of Productive Sectors (MAEPSP); and ii) coordination meetings which bring together the Bank, the MAEPSP and project coordinators have been strengthened. The poor mastery of Bank rules and procedures remains to be resolved.

## Mainstreaming Cross-cutting Issues

This section answers the following question: How has the Bank mainstreamed cross-cutting issues into project design and implementation? This was assessed based on whether or not there were explicit objectives for the following cross-cutting issues in the CSPs and projects: gender equality promotion and women's empowerment; youth employment; fragility and resilience; climate change adaptation and mitigation; and private sector development. Alternative modalities for mainstreaming cross-cutting issues were also identified and documented. The evaluation data is presented in Technical Annex 11.

*The mainstreaming of cross-cutting issues was rated partly unsatisfactory. Of the 24 projects approved during the period, explicit objectives were set in three projects for youth employment (12.5%) and five projects for climate change adaptation and/or mitigation (20.8%). Although only two projects included a gender equality promotion objective (8.3%), 16 others (66.7%) implemented various gender equality and women's activities. Addressing fragility was an explicit objective in four projects (16.7%). Private sector development was an objective in four projects (16.7%). However, the Bank financed five non-sovereign operations in the country for a total of UA 53.5 million, representing almost 35% of Bank financing in the country during the period.*

**Gender mainstreaming in the Bank's CSPs and projects was rated partly unsatisfactory.** Two of the 24 projects approved during the 2011-2020 period (8.3%) had an explicit gender equality promotion objective. These were the Project to Support the Promotion of Micro-, Small- and Medium-sized Enterprises and Youth Employment (PAMPEJ) and the Governance Support Project for Inclusive Growth Promotion (PAGOCI) (Technical Annex 11). Despite reference to the efforts made by the Mauritanian Government to promote gender equality and women, only PAGOCI had an explicit gender equality promotion objective among the nine approved (11.1%) under RBCSP 2011-2015. CSP 2016-2020 adopted gender equality promotion as a guiding principle and undertook to systematically mainstream gender into all its operations (AfDB, 2016: 9, 16-17), in accordance with SCAPP 2016-2030 whose major objectives include "promoting gender-based development" and based on a well-detailed gender analysis (AfDB, 2016: Annex 13). Yet, among the 15 projects approved during the period, only PAMPEJ had an explicit gender equality promotion objective (6.7%) (Technical Annex 11). However, 16 of the 24 projects (66.7%) planned to carry out women-focused activities (organisational support and training for women's associations or cooperatives) including a study on gender disparities in the labour market. The other modalities for mainstreaming gender into their operations (Technical Annex 11) included setting a quota of women among their beneficiaries and including gender indicators in monitoring and evaluation mechanisms.

**Mainstreaming youth employment into the Bank's CSPs and projects was rated partly unsatisfactory.** Three of the 24 projects approved during the period (12.5%) had an explicit youth employment objective. These were the Youth Training and Employment Support Project (PAFEJ), PAGOCI and PAMPEJ (Technical Annex 11). In RBCSP 2011-2015, the Bank did not set a specific objective to create jobs, especially for youths, despite its commitment to help Mauritania address the crucial job creation challenge. However, two of the nine projects approved (22.2%) during the period had an explicit objective of creating jobs for youths, especially PAFEJ and PAGOCI (Technical Annex 11). In CSP 2016-2020, the situation was less favourable with only PAMPEJ having an explicit objective among the 15 projects (6.7%) (Technical Annex 11). In addition, 4 other projects among the 24 provided for a quota or training activities for the youth among their beneficiaries (Technical Annex 11).

**Mainstreaming fragility and resilience into the Bank's CSPs and projects were rated partly unsatisfactory.** Four of the 24 approved projects (16.7%) had an explicit objective to address fragility and build resilience (Technical Annex 11). RBCSP 2011-2015 had identified that fragility resulting from external economic shocks, especially the soaring food and import prices (AfDB, 2010: 3) and from political instability (AfDB, 2010: 13) were handicapping. During the 2011-2015 period, only one of the nine projects had an explicit objective to address these, compared to three out of 15 (20%) during the CSP 2016-2020 (Technical Annex 11), which conducted a specific analysis of vulnerability factors and resilience opportunities (AfDB, 2016c: Annex 14).

Mainstreaming climate change (through adaptation and mitigation measures) into the Bank's CSPs and projects was rated partly unsatisfactory. Strategies defined in the CSPs do not propose specific climate change measures. CSP 2016-2020 identifies it as a risk but delays its mainstreaming until the design of programmed operations, especially in agriculture (AfDB, 2016c: 17-22). However, five of the 24 projects approved for the 2011-2020 period (20.8%) had an explicit objective related to climate change adaptation and mitigation (or climate change resilience) (Technical Annex 11). Of these projects, 2 were approved for the 2011-2015 period and 3 for 2016-2020.

**Mainstreaming private sector development into the Bank's CSPs and projects was rated partly unsatisfactory.** Private sector development is not a strategic priority in the CSPs. However, CSP 2016-2020 envisaged public-private partnerships (PPPs) in the agricultural sector (AfDB, 2016c: 17). Four of the 24 projects approved in the period (16.7%) had an explicit private sector development objective (Technical Annex 11). Of these, the line of credit to the *Banque Populaire de Mauritanie* (BPM) financed 72 projects in industry, mining, fisheries, trade, and transport sectors, while the line of credit to the Bank for Trade and Industry (BCI) covered the trade finance operations of Mauritanian SMEs. The Project to Support the Promotion of Micro-, Small- and Medium-sized Enterprises and Youth Employment (PAMPEJ) aims to, inter alia, "promote sustainable profitable SMEs and youth and women's entrepreneurship." The Governance Support Project for Inclusive Growth Promotion (PAGOCI) had the following operational objectives: i) development of a new PRSP which takes into consideration employment and gender; ii) reduction of administrative barriers to business; iii) strengthening entrepreneurship, especially for women and the youth; and iv) strengthening the private sector promotion mechanism. ■

# Evaluation Conclusions

Over the 2011-2020 period, the Bank financed 24 projects in Mauritania for a total of UA 154.26 million in 7 intervention sectors: industry/mining/quarrying, agriculture, transport, finance, multi-sector, water and sanitation, and social. Under RBCSP 2011-2015, the Bank's objective was to "contribute to the achievement of Mauritania's priority objectives of enhancing the economy's competitiveness and reducing poverty," based on two strategic pillars: i) strengthening infrastructure; and ii) improving economic and financial governance. Under CSP 2016-2020, the Bank opted for: i) the promotion of agricultural transformation (Pillar I), and ii) the strengthening of electricity supply (Pillar II), to achieve the major objective of "helping Mauritania achieve more inclusive and greener growth" with a view to improving the living conditions of the population (or shared prosperity).

**Relevance:** The design and implementation of the CSPs and operations were relevant to the needs of the people and to national development priorities. They were also consistent with the Bank's High 5 priorities, except for "Light up and Power Africa," whose sole prepared multi-country project was not financed due to lack of resources. Furthermore, the indicative operations programmes were implemented satisfactorily as operations approved corresponded to those planned in the IOPs. This made it possible for the Bank to cover 6 of the 7 expected outcomes at the pillar level, mainly through agricultural infrastructure projects where the Bank has institutional capacity and has already achieved good performance.

**Effectiveness:** The Bank achieved the objectives set at the country level. However, effectiveness was partly unsatisfactory at the pillar level. Indeed, the Bank delivered or was likely to deliver only 22 out of 81 outputs, taking into consideration the adjustments adopted at mid-term. This under-performance reflects a gap in the theory of change with respect to Bank assistance, as individual projects performed satisfactorily by delivering almost 60% of the 51 expected outputs but missed their targets at the pillar level.

**Contribution of projects approved before the evaluation period:** Six projects approved before the evaluation period contributed to the results found during the evaluation, notably in water resource management, irrigation development and creation of farmer organizations for poverty alleviation, and water supply and sanitation. Two lines of credit boosted the economic expansion of private enterprises. The Project to Build the Capacities of Microfinance Operators (PRECAMF) increased the portfolio of micro-finance institutions to MRO 1.85 billion, almost 16% above the target. Table 14 below summarises the rating of the evaluation criteria and sub-criteria.

**Sustainability of the achievements of operations.** Overall, sustainability was rated satisfactory because of the projects' ability to deliver outcomes that can be continued after external funding ceases (exit strategy) and to a satisfactory level of ownership by the beneficiaries. However, the lack of actions to build local technical capacity as well as gaps in the implementation of ESMP measures in Cat. 1 & 2 projects do not make it possible to conclude that the projects' long-term sustainability is ensured.

**Coherence:** Some 70.8% of the Bank's projects complement each other and all of them complement the operations of other development partners in Mauritania, which indicates a satisfactory level of coherence.

**Efficiency:** The mismatch between pillar and project results achievements was also caused by efficiency bottlenecks both at the country level and within the Bank, including delays before and during implementation as well as a low disbursement rate.

**Table 14:** Summary of Evaluation Criteria and Sub-criteria

| Evaluation criteria | Evaluation sub-criteria | Rating* |
|---|---|---|
| **Relevance** | **Relevance** | |
| | CSP relative to national strategies (100%) | 4 |
| | Projects relative to national strategies (87.2%) | 3 |
| | CSP relative to the population's needs (100%) | 4 |
| | CSP relative to Bank priorities (100%) | 4 |
| | Projects relative to Bank priorities (100%) | 4 |
| | CSP relative to the RISP (50%) | 3 |
| | **Selectivity** | |
| | Actual coverage of CSP priorities (71.4%) | 3 |
| | IOPs implementation rate (63.6%) | 3 |
| | Explicit consideration of comparative advantages | 3 |
| **Effectiveness** | Achievement of the expected results of RBCSP 2011-2015 (50%) | 3 |
| | Achievement of the expected results of CSP 2016-2020 (100%) | 4 |
| | Achievement of the expected results of the pillars (27.2%) | 2 |
| | Achievement of the expected results of operations (59.6%) | 3 |
| **Sustainability** | 100% of completed or closed operations have achievements which have continued and/or are likely to continue after the assistance provided ends. | 4 |
| | **Beneficiaries' ownership of Bank projects** | |
| | 100% of projects completed or closed during the period involved target communities | 4 |
| | 33.3% of projects completed or closed during the period implemented a mechanism to ensure the sustainability of achievements | 2 |
| | 33.3% of the projects completed or closed during the period implemented a revenue collection mechanism to finance recurrent costs | 2 |
| | 100% of projects completed or closed during the period integrated PIUs into the supervisory ministry's services | 4 |
| | **Local capacity building or mobilization in Bank operations** | |
| | 42.9% of projects completed or closed during the period implemented one or more activities to build the country's technical or institutional capacity | 2 |
| | **Compliance with the Bank's environmental and social safeguards standards** | |
| | 20% of Category I & II projects documented the implementation of environmental and social mitigation measures, including those linked to related conditions precedent. | 2 |
| | 33.3% of Category I & II projects have appointed/already have a focal point within the PIU to monitor and report on ESMP implementation and/or resettlement/compensation of the affected population. | 2 |
| | 28.6% of category I & II projects have an ESMP, and it was actually made available | 2 |
| **Coherence** | Internal coherence (70.8%) | 3 |
| | External coherence (100%) | 4 |
| **Efficiency** | Compliance with deadlines prior to implementation | 2 |
| | Compliance with implementation deadlines (50%) | 3 |
| | Compliance with allocated budgets (100%) | 4 |
| | Disbursement rate (35.6%) | 1 |
| **Mainstreaming cross-cutting issues** | The project had explicit fragility and resilience objectives (16.7%) | 2 |
| | The project had explicit gender promotion objectives (8.3%) | 2 |
| | The project had explicit youth employment creation objectives (12.5%) | 2 |
| | The project had explicit climate change objectives (20.8%) | 2 |
| | The project had explicit objectives on private sector development (16.7%) | 2 |

* 4= Highly satisfactory; 3=Satisfactory; 2=Partly unsatisfactory; 1=Unsatisfactory

**Mainstreaming cross-cutting issues** into the operations was partly unsatisfactory, although various modalities for the promotion of gender equality were identified. The **monitoring/evaluation mechanism** was unable to provide information on almost 40% of the expected project outputs, compelling the team to conclude that the related targeted outputs were not achieved, otherwise the information would have been available. ■

# Lessons Drawn from the Evaluation

**Lesson 1:** In countries with low PBAs, additional Bank resources are successfully leveraged when the regional and/or country team implements a proactive strategy.

Between the RBCSP 2011-2015 and CSP 2016-2020, the volume of approvals quintupled and the average envelope per project increased by 141%. Considering the IOP at approval and the adjustment made at CSP 2016-2020 mid-term, Mauritania planned to obtain UA 95.52 million to finance operations over the period. It succeeded in raising UA 126.75 million, i.e. 1.32 times its PBA.

**Lesson 2:** The private sector is an important lever for the country's development.

While there were no private sector operations in Mauritania's RBCSP 2011-2015, it took only five operations under CSP 2016-2020 (one direct loan, two lines of credit and two guarantees) for the private sector to account for 34.7% of approvals over the entire evaluation period (2011-2020). Indeed, the direct loan for the SNIM dredging project contributed to the achievement of the objective of enhancing the mining sector by increasing iron exports, which is the country's main foreign currency earner. SNIM has become one of the world's leading iron producers. In addition, lines of credit and guarantees to BPM and BCI increased financing for Mauritanian SMEs in the industry, mining, fisheries, trade, and transport sectors.

**Lesson 3:** Judicious selection of intervention sectors and a systematic articulation of Bank projects including operations of the country's main development partners (external coherence) are crucial to developing an effective strategy to raise more financing and achieve national development goals.

- Social and economic infrastructure as well as governance are the main sectors of intervention, as they absorbed about half of the Official Development Assistance envelope received by the country. By targeting these sectors, the Bank was able to leverage UA 175.7 million from co-financiers for projects worth a total of UA 195.4 million over the period, including UA 19.7 million from the ADF, i.e., a leverage effect of 1 to 8.9.

- As presented above under the heading 'effectiveness', one of the two national objectives set in CSP 2016-2020 and one of the two objectives of RBCSP 2011-2015 were achieved even though the Bank had not completely delivered the outputs expected at the pillar level during the period. In fact, the outcomes of operations are more closely aligned with national outcomes than pillar outcomes. The contribution of the other development partners (USD 3697.5 million in 2019, of which the Bank provided 3.4%) was significant, and their strong complementarity with the Bank's operations expedited the direct translation of the Bank operations' outcomes into outcomes targeted at national level.

**Lesson 4:** Operations' effectiveness does not guarantee the achievement of the expected outcomes at the various higher levels.

Operations' achievements did not translate into achievement of the expected pillar outcomes. In other words, implementation of the operations did not sufficiently contribute to the attainment of pillar outcomes to fulfil the theory of change of Bank assistance. This situation reflects the weaknesses already noted in the theory of change of Bank assistance, in particular the reliability and feasibility of the causal chain between the outcomes defined at the three levels during programming (national outcomes, pillar outcomes, IOP and operations' outcomes). ■

# Recommendations

**Recommendation 1:** Improve the articulation between the targeted objectives at national and pillar levels and the expected results of the operations programmed in the country assistance strategy, taking into consideration:

a) the reliability and feasibility (in the actual country context) of the results chain (causal relationship) between the three levels of action: operations, pillar and national; b) the volatility resulting from frequent IOP changes; c) the lifespan of operations programmed in the IOP in selecting the planning horizon for the expected CSP results; and d) adequate sizing of the CSP's targeted results relative to the estimated resource allocation to finance operations in the country over the period.

**Recommendation 2:** Ensure that the rhythm of two supervisions per year is adhered to.

On these occasions, the timely provision of the necessary sector specialists and budget could help to remove the impediments to the smooth implementation of operations (insufficient familiarity with the Bank's applicable rules and procedures, poor quality of disbursement requests, delays in mobilising counterpart funds, lack of diligence in the procurement procedure; etc.). These more regular supervisions can also provide opportunities to guide and advise national stakeholders and possibly hold fiduciary clinics and in-situ training sessions.

**Recommendation 3:** Foresee mechanisms that ensure the sustainability of benefits right from the design of Bank operations and monitor their effective implementation.

Currently planned mechanisms, such as cost-recovery to finance the recurrent costs of community infrastructure and equipment as well as building local ownership and participation capacities (exit strategy), must be effectively implemented to ensure the sustainability of the Bank's impact on the country's development.

**Recommendation 4:** Improve the mainstreaming of cross-cutting issues in the CSPs and the Bank's operations.

In particular promotion of gender equality and women's empowerment, youth employment, fragility and resilience, climate change adaptation and mitigation, and private sector development. It is recommended to include specific objectives at the design stage, especially in results-based logical frameworks, modelled on the Bank's gender marker system, so that these cross-cutting issues are at the core of all stakeholders' activities during the implementation of operations. This integration mechanism could be complemented by other arrangements. ■

# Annexes



* Only available in French

# Annex 1: Macroeconomic and Social Indicators of Mauritania

| | 2010 | 2012 | 2014 | 2016 | 2018 | 2020 | North Africa (2018 indicators) | Africa (2018 indicators) |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Basic indicators | | | | | | | | |
| Area (Km²) | 1 030 700 | 1 030 700 | 1 030 700 | 1 030 700 | 1 030 700 | 1 030 700 | 6 769 090 | |
| Total population | 3 494 195 | 3 706 555 | 3 930 896 | 4 163 533 | 4 403 313 | 4 649 658 | 199 328 172 | 1 274 205 478 |
| Urban population (% of Total) | 48.12 | 50.01 | 51.9 | 53.67 | 55.33 | 56.92 | 55.79 | 42.86 |
| Population density (per Km²) | 3.39 | 3.59 | 3.81 | 4.03 | 4.27 | 4.51 | 29.44 | 43.15 |
| GNI per capita (USD) | 980 | 1110 | | | | | | 1786.18 |
| Labour force participation* - Total (%) | 46.5 | 45.8 | 46 | 46.2 | 46.3 | 46.2 | | 37.99 |
| Human development index (rank among 188 countries) | 159 | 159 | 156 | 159 | | | | |
| Gini Index | | | 32.6 | | | | | |
| Prevalence of undernourishment (%) | 8.2 | 7.2 | 7.4 | 9.6 | | | 5.18 (2011) | |
| Demographic indicators | | | | | | | | |
| Population growth rate - Total (%) | 2.97 | 2.99 | 2.97 | 2.89 | 2.81 | 2.73 | 1.85 | 2.55 |
| Population growth rate - Urban (%) | 4.97 | 4.99 | 4.85 | 4.59 | 4.36 | 4.17 | 2.01 | 3.32 |
| Population < 15 years (%) | 41.24 | 40.98 | 40.68 | 40.4 | 40.08 | 39.68 | 29.38 | 40.23 |
| Population ≥ 65 years (%) | 3.15 | 3.13 | 3.12 | 3.12 | 3.14 | 3.17 | 5.88 | 3.58 |
| Dependency ratio (%) | 74.149 | 73.104 | 72.469 | | | | | |
| Sex ratio (per 100 female) | 99.98 | 100.16 | 100.34 | 100.52 | 100.71 | 100.87 | 100.46 | 100.23 |
| Female population 15-49 years (% of Total) | 24.25 | 24.3 | 24.34 | 24.37 | 24.41 | 24.47 | 26.03 | |
| Life expectancy at birth - Total (years) | 62.52 | 63.07 | 63.65 | 64.2 | 64.7 | 65.12 | 73.83 | 63.23 |
| Life expectancy at birth - Female (years) | 64.29 | 64.8 | 65.32 | 65.82 | 66.29 | 66.73 | 75.73 | 65.01 |
| Crude birth rate (per 1000) | 36.5 | 36.03 | 35.38 | 34.56 | 33.69 | 32.84 | 23.98 | 33.46 |
| Crude death rate (per 1000) | 8.33 | 8.04 | 7.75 | 7.46 | 7.22 | 7.02 | 5.47 | 8.11 |
| Infant mortality rate (per 1000) | 61.94 | 59.4 | 56.74 | 54.06 | 51.54 | | 19.34 | 48.69 |
| Fertility rate (per woman) | 4.837 | 4.728 | 4.67 | | | | | 4.41 |
| Maternal mortality rate (per 100 000) | 723 | 682 | 629 | 602 | | | | |
| Women using contraception (%) | 12.1 | 13.7 | 15.8 | 17.9 | 19.8 | 21.8 | 62.18 | 37.69 |
| Access to basic services | | | | | | | | |
| Access to electricity - Total (%) | 34.39 | 36.89 | 38.8 | 41.35 | 42.91 | | | |
| Access to electricity in rural areas (%) | 0 | 0 | 0.38 | 0 | | | | |
| Access to drinking water sources - Total (%) | 54.3 | 56.7 | 57.9 | 57.9 | | | 92.25 (2015) | 71.61 (2015) |
| Access to drinking water sources in rural areas (%) | 52.9 | 55.7 | 57.1 | | | | 89.93 (2015) | 60.37 (2015) |
| Access to sanitation facilities - Total (%) | 35.7 | 38.2 | 39.7 | | | | 88.59 (2015) | 39.67 (2015) |
| Access to sanitation facilities in rural areas (%) | 12.7 | 13.5 | 13.8 | | | | 84.83 (2015 | 31.27 (2015) |
| Public health spending (% of GDP) | 1.52 | 1.37 | 1.87 | | | | 3.88 (2010) | 5.86 (2010) |
| Environment and Agriculture | | | | | | | | |
| Agricultural land (as % of land area) | 38.52 | 38.47 | 38.47 | 38.47 | | | 0.20 (2016) | 42 (2016) |
| Women in agriculture (% of employed women) | 29.32 | 29.49 | 29.76 | 29.98 | 30.04 | 29.93 | | |
| Per capita $CO_2$ emissions (Metric tonne) | 0.61 | 0.69 | 0.66 | | | | | |

| | 2010 | 2012 | 2014 | 2016 | 2018 | 2020 | North Africa (2018 indicators) | Africa (2018 indicators) |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Education** | | | | | | | | |
| Gross enrolment rate (%) | | | | | | | | |
| Primary school - Total | 72.37 | 71.15 | 76.29 | 73.11 | 79.57 | | 95.78 (2010) | 98.96 (2016) |
| Primary school - Girls | 73.81 | 73.69 | 78.07 | 74.95 | 80.85 | | 96.19 (2012) | 97.29 (2016) |
| Secondary school - Total | 20.75 | 27.26 | 30.71 | 32.67 | 36.83 | | 84.16) | 46.47 (2015) |
| Secondary school - Girls | 19.07 | 24.96 | 29.33 | 32.19 | 37.14 | | 82.8 | 43.16 (2015) |
| Percentage of GDP spent on education (%) | 3.6 | 2.77 | | 2.63 | | | | 5.27 (2010) |
| **Macroeconomic indicators** | | | | | | | | |
| Real GDP growth (%) | 4.77 | 5.79 | 5.59 | 1.91 | 3.55 | 5.68 | 3.89 | 3.36 |
| Inflation (%) | 6.26 | 5.68 | 3.49 | 1.49 | 3.1 | 2.91 | 12.91 | 11.23 |
| Per capita growth rate (%) | 1.75 | 2.71 | 2.55 | -0.95 | 0.71 | 2.86 | 2.01 | 0.79 |
| Import of goods and services (% of GDP) | 60.97 | 80.26 | 65.75 | 53.47 | 62.43 | 56.61 | 37.13 | 29.47 |
| Export of goods and services (% of GDP) | 50.8 | 53.38 | 39.01 | 35.65 | 40.87 | 35.22 | 26.67 | 25.09 |
| Current account balance (% of GDP) | -7.19 | -23.44 | -27.34 | -15.05 | -18.57 | -14.49 | -5.36 | -3.38 |

Source: https://dataportal.opendataforafrica.org/nbyenxf/afdb-socio-economic-database-1960-2020

# Annex 2a: Operations Approved and Not Cancelled (2011-2020)

| SAP code | Project name | Sector | High 5 |
|---|---|---|---|
| P-MR-AAC-009 | PPF- PAHABO 2 TECHNIC. STUDY PREPARATION | Agriculture and rural development | Feed Africa |
| P-MR-AAC-011 | AGRIC. TRANSFORM. SUPPORT (ATA) IN MAURITANIA | Agriculture and rural development | Feed Africa |
| P-MR-AAC-011 | AGRIC. TRANSFORM. SUPPORT (ATA) IN MAURITANIA | Agriculture and rural development | Feed Africa |
| P-MR-AAZ-003 | EMERGENCY HUMANITARIAN AID | Agriculture and rural development | Improve the quality of life for the people of Africa |
| P-MR-AAZ-006 | MAURITANIA FLOODS EMERGENCY AID | Agriculture and rural development | Improve the quality of life for the people of Africa |
| P-MR-BAA-006 | SNIM DREDGING PROJECT | Industry/mines/quarry | Industrialise Africa |
| P-MR-EAZ-007 | NATIONAL INTEGRATED RURAL WATER PROJECT | Water & sanitation | Improve the quality of life for the people of Africa |
| P-MR-EAZ-007 | NATIONAL INTEGRATED RURAL WATER PROJECT | Water & sanitation | Improve the quality of life for the people of Africa |
| P-MR-EAZ-007 | NATIONAL INTEGRATED RURAL WATER PROJECT | Water & sanitation | Improve the quality of life for the people of Africa |
| P-MR-EAZ-009 | PNISER II | Water & sanitation | Improve the quality of life for the people of Africa |
| P-MR-EAZ-010 | REVUWI | Water & sanitation | Improve the quality of life for the people of Africa |
| P-MR-EB0-005 | NOUAKCHOTT EMERGENCY HUMANITARIAN AID | Water & sanitation | Improve the quality of life for the people of Africa |
| P-MR-HA0-001 | LOC BPM | Finance | Industrialise Africa |
| P-MR-HA0-001 | LOC BPM | Finance | Industrialise Africa |
| P-MR-HAB-007 | BCI LOC TRADE FINANCE - TF | Finance | Feed Africa |
| P-MR-HAB-007 | BCI LOC TRADE FINANCE - TF | Finance | Feed Africa |
| P-MR-HZ0-004 | SUPPORT FOR THE PAYMENT SYSTEM | Finance | Industrialise Africa |
| P-MR-HZ0-005 | SUPPLEMENTARY LOAN - SUPPORT FOR THE PAYMENT SYSTEM | Finance | Industrialise Africa |
| P-MR-I00-001 | PAMPEJ | Social | Improve the quality of life for the people of Africa |

| Status* | Approval date | Signature date | Effective date | 1st disbursement date | Scheduled closing date | Approved amount UA | Disbursement rate |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| CLSD | 11/05/2015 | 27/05/2015 | 27/05/2015 | 29/03/2016 | 31/12/2016 | 638 640.00 | 83,0 % |
| OnGo | 12/12/2018 | 25/01/2019 | 11/06/2019 | 13/12/2019 | 31/12/2024 | 6 000 000.00 | 0,0 % |
| OnGo | 12/12/2018 | 25/01/2019 | 11/06/2019 | 13/12/2019 | 31/12/2024 | 7 000 000.00 | 17,7 % |
| CLSD | 10/09/2012 | 19/12/2012 | | | 30/06/2013 | 694 314.26 | 100,0 % |
| OnGo | 28/10/2019 | 22/01/2020 | 22/01/2020 | 22/01/2020 | 20/06/2021 | 634 950.39 | 0,0 % |
| OnGo | 22/11/2017 | 28/06/2018 | 28/06/2018 | 27/11/2019 | | 34 715 713.03 | 20,0 % |
| OnGo | 07/12/2012 | 12/02/2013 | 12/02/2013 | 20/08/2013 | 31/12/2021 | 2 448 000.00 | 89,6 % |
| OnGo | 07/12/2012 | 12/02/2013 | 13/09/2013 | 08/11/2013 | 31/12/2021 | 3 052 000.00 | 84,5 % |
| OnGo | 07/12/2012 | 12/02/2013 | 12/02/2013 | 31/05/2013 | 31/12/2021 | 2 956 455.63 | 90,7 % |
| COMP | 18/12/2013 | 10/04/2014 | 23/01/2015 | 23/01/2015 | 31/12/2018 | 920 000.00 | 100,0 % |
| OnGo | 08/07/2016 | 11/10/2016 | 11/10/2016 | 06/01/2017 | 31/12/2021 | 4 408 895.55 | 4,6 % |
| CLSD | 04/04/2014 | 22/05/2014 | 01/07/2014 | | 31/12/2014 | 569 337.69 | 100,0 % |
| OnGo | 20/05/2016 | 10/11/2016 | 10/11/2016 | 14/11/2016 | 10/11/2021 | 4 860 199.82 | 100,0 % |
| OnGo | 08/06/2016 | 20/03/2017 | | | 10/11/2021 | 2 430 099.91 | 68,8 % |
| CLSD | 15/06/2016 | 07/12/2016 | 07/12/2016 | 09/12/2016 | | 6 943 142.61 | 100,0 % |
| CLSD | 11/10/2017 | 16/05/2018 | | | | 4 582 474.12 | 24,4 % |
| OnGo | 15/12/2017 | 11/02/2018 | 11/02/2018 | 11/02/2018 | 31/12/2022 | 3 600 000.00 | 12,2 % |
| APVD | 01/04/2020 | 02/07/2020 | 13/01/2021 | 13/01/2021 | 31/12/2023 | 400 000.00 | 0,0 % |
| OnGo | 21/09/2016 | 04/11/2016 | 18/04/2017 | 21/06/2017 | 30/06/2022 | 2 624 000.00 | 48,5 % |

| SAP code | Project name | Sector | High 5 | |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **P-MR-I00-001** | PAMPEJ | Social | Improve the quality of life for the people of Africa | |
| **P-MR-IAZ-002** | TRAINING & YOUTH EMPLOYMENT SUPPORT PROJECT | Social | Improve the quality of life for the people of Africa | |
| **P-MR-K00-014** | GOVERNANCE SUPPORT PROJECT FOR INCLUSIVE GROWTH PROMOTION | Multi-sector | Improve the quality of life for the people of Africa | |
| **P-MR-K00-016** | ECONOMIC REFORM SUPPORT PROG. (PAREDE) | Multi-sector | Improve the quality of life for the people of Africa | |
| **P-MR-K00-016** | ECONOMIC REFORM SUPPORT PROG. (PAREDE) | Multi-sector | Improve the quality of life for the people of Africa | |
| **P-MR-K00-017** | ECONOMIC REFORM SUPPORT PROG (PAREDE II) | Multi-sector | Improve the quality of life for the people of Africa | |
| **P-MR-K00-018** | CRISIS RESPONSE SUPPORT PROGRAMME | Multi-sector | Improve the quality of life for the people of Africa | |
| **P-MR-KF0-001** | PUBLIC INVESTMENT MANAGEMENT SUPPORT PROJECT | Multi-sector | Improve the quality of life for the people of Africa | |
| **P-Z1-D00-037** | ROSSO BRIDGE CONSTRUCTION PROJECT | Transport | Integrate Africa | |
| **P-Z1-AAZ-021** | MAURITANIA - PROJECT TO BUILD RESIL. TO FOOD & NUTRIT. INSEC. IN THE SAHEL | Agriculture and rural development | Feed Africa | |
| **P-Z1-IBE-021** | EXCEPTIONAL EMERGENCY PROJECT FOR | Social | Improve the quality of life for the people of Africa | |
| **P-Z1-IBE-021** | EXCEPTIONAL EMERGENCY PROJECT FOR | Social | Improve the quality of life for the people of Africa | |
| **P-MR-A00-003** | MAURITANIA ADRIFI | Agriculture and rural development | Feed Africa | |

* The team updated the statuses of some operations because their completion reports or completion report reviews were available. Normally, such operations should have the status "Closed" instead of "Completed" indicated in SAP PS.

** The cost of this multinational project is UA 16 000 000, allocated to several countries (Mauritania, Mali, Burkina Faso, Niger, Chad) The share of the Mauritania component is UA 3 324 552.06 (2 896 390 + 428 162 06) according to discussions held with Mauritania's resident Country Program Officer (CPO) in the Bank.

Source: AfDB SAP PS internal data

| Status* | Approval date | Signature date | Effective date | 1st disbursement date | Scheduled closing date | Approved amount UA | Disbursement rate |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| OnGo | 21/09/2016 | 04/11/2016 | 04/11/2016 | 21/06/2017 | 30/06/2022 | 521 360.00 | 100,0 % |
| OnGo | 28/11/2014 | 11/12/2014 | 11/12/2014 | 24/07/2015 | 30/06/2021 | 2 000 000.00 | 84,3 % |
| OnGo | 17/11/2014 | 11/12/2014 | 11/12/2014 | 02/04/2015 | 31/08/2021 | 2 000 000.00 | 84,5 % |
| CLSD | 23/11/2016 | 30/11/2016 | 30/11/2016 | 09/01/2017 | 31/12/2017 | 3 427 640.00 | 100,0 % |
| CLSD | 23/11/2016 | 30/11/2016 | 08/05/2017 | 08/05/2017 | 31/12/2017 | 3 273 000.00 | 100,0 % |
| CLSD | 15/12/2017 | 11/02/2018 | 02/10/2018 | 02/10/2018 | 31/12/2018 | 4 000 000.00 | 100,0 % |
| APVD | 22/07/2020 | 27/07/2020 | 27/07/2020 | 28/09/2020 | 30/06/2022 | 7 500 000.00 | 100,0 % |
| CLSD | 07/10/2013 | 01/12/2013 | 01/12/2013 | 29/08/2014 | 30/06/2016 | 740 000.00 | 100,0 % |
| OnGo | 09/12/2016 | 13/03/2017 | 23/01/2018 | 23/01/2018 | 30/06/2023 | 25 000 000.00 | 1,3 % |
| OnGo | 15/10/2014 | 11/12/2014 | 11/12/2014 | 15/05/2015 | 30/12/2021 | 11 500 000.00 | 68,1 % |
| OnGo | 09/06/2020 | 22/07/2020 | 22/07/2020 | 22/07/2020 | 30/04/2023 | 2 896 390.00** | 87,2 % |
| OnGo | 06/06/2020 | 20/07/2020 | 22/07/2020 | 22/07/2020 | 30/04/2023 | 428 162.06** | 100,0 % |
| OnGo | 16/09/2020 | 05/10/2020 | 05/10/2020 | 17/12/2020 | 31/12/2022 | 1 500 000.00 | 0,0 % |

# Annex 2b: List of Projects Approved and Not Cancelled (2011-2020)

| SAP code | Project name | Sector | High 5 | |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| P-MR-AAC-009 | PPF- PAHABO 2 TECHNIC. STUDY PREPARATION | Agriculture and rural development | Feed Africa | |
| P-MR-AAC-011 | AGRIC. TRANSFORM. SUPPORT (ATA) IN MAURITANIA | Agriculture and rural development | Feed Africa | |
| P-MR-AAZ-003 | EMERGENCY HUMANITARIAN AID | Agriculture and rural development | Improve the quality of life for the people of Africa | |
| P-MR-AAZ-006 | MAURITANIA FLOODS EMERGENCY AID | Agriculture and rural development | Improve the quality of life for the people of Africa | |
| P-MR-BAA-006 | SNIM DREDGING PROJECT | Ind/min/quarr | Industrialise Africa | |
| P-MR-EAZ-007 | NATIONAL INTEGRATED RURAL WATER PROJECT | Water & sanitation | Improve the quality of life for the people of Africa | |
| P-MR-EAZ-009 | PNISER II | Water & sanitation | Improve the quality of life for the people of Africa | |
| P-MR-EAZ-010 | REVUWI | Water & sanitation | Improve the quality of life for the people of Africa | |
| P-MR-EB0-005 | NOUAKCHOTT EMERGENCY HUMANITARIAN AID | Water & sanitation | Improve the quality of life for the people of Africa | |
| P-MR-HA0-001 | LOC BPM | Finance | Industrialise Africa | |
| P-MR-HAB-007 | BCI LOC TRADE FINANCE - TF | Finance | Feed Africa | |
| P-MR-HZ0-004 | SUPPORT FOR THE PAYMENT SYSTEM | Finance | Industrialise Africa | |
| P-MR-HZ0-005 | SUPPLEMENTARY LOAN - SUPPORT FOR THE PAYMENT SYSTEM | Finance | Industrialise Africa | |
| P-MR-I00-001 | PAMPEJ | Social | Improve the quality of life for the people of Africa | |
| P-MR-IAZ-002 | TRAINING & YOUTH EMPLOYMENT SUPPORT PROJECT | Social | Improve the quality of life for the people of Africa | |
| P-MR-K00-014 | GOVERNANCE SUPPORT PROJECT FOR INCLUSIVE GROWTH PROMOTION | Multi-sector | Improve the quality of life for the people of Africa | |
| P-MR-K00-016 | ECONOMIC REFORM SUPPORT PROG. (PAREDE) | Multi-sector | Improve the quality of life for the people of Africa | |
| P-MR-K00-017 | ECONOMIC REFORM SUPPORT PROG. (PAREDE II) | Multi-sector | Improve the quality of life for the people of Africa | |
| P-MR-K00-018 | CRISIS RESPONSE SUPPORT PROGRAMME | Multi-sector | Improve the quality of life for the people of Africa | |
| P-MR-KF0-001 | PUBLIC INVESTMENT MANAGEMENT SUPPORT PROJECT | Multi-sector | Improve the quality of life for the people of Africa | |
| P-Z1-D00-037 | ROSSO BRIDGE CONSTRUCTION PROJECT | Transport | Integrate Africa | |
| P-Z1-AAZ-021 | MAURITANIA - PROJECT TO BUILD RESIL. TO FOOD & NUTRIT. INSEC. IN THE SAHEL | Agriculture and rural development | Feed Africa | |
| P-Z1-IBE-021 | EXCEPTIONAL EMERGENCY PROJECT FOR | Social | Improve the quality of life for the people of Africa | |
| P-MR-A00-003 | MAURITANIA ADRIFI | Agriculture and rural development | Feed Africa | |

* The team updated the statuses of some operations because their completion reports or completion report reviews were available. Normally, such operations should have the status "Closed" instead of "Completed" indicated in SAP PS.

Source: AfDB SAP PS internal data

| Status* | Approval date | Signature date | Effective date | 1st disbursement date | Scheduled closing date | Approved amount UA | Disbursement rate |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| CLSD | 11/05/2015 | 27/05/2015 | 27/05/2015 | 29/03/2016 | 31/12/2016 | 638 640.0 | 83.0% |
| OnGo | 12/12/2018 | 25/01/2019 | 11/06/2019 | 13/12/2019 | 31/12/2024 | 13 000 000.0 | 9.5% |
| CLSD | 10/09/2012 | 19/12/2012 | 00/01/1900 | 00/01/1900 | 30/09/2013 | 694 314.3 | 100.00% |
| OnGo | 28/10/2019 | 22/01/2020 | 22/01/2020 | 22/01/2020 | 20/06/2021 | 634 950.4 | 0.0% |
| OnGo | 22/11/2017 | 28/06/2018 | 28/06/2018 | 27/11/2019 | 00/01/1900 | 34 715 713.0 | 20.0% |
| OnGo | 07/12/2012 | 12/02/2013 | 12/02/2013 | 31/05/2013 | 31/12/2021 | 8 456 455.6 | 88.1% |
| COMP | 18/12/2013 | 10/04/2014 | 23/01/2015 | 23/01/2015 | 31/12/2018 | 920 000.0 | 100.0% |
| OnGo | 08/07/2016 | 11/10/2016 | 11/10/2016 | 06/01/2017 | 31/12/2021 | 4 408 895.6 | 4.6% |
| CLSD | 04/04/2014 | 22/05/2014 | 01/07/2014 | 00/01/1900 | 04/06/2015 | 569 337.7 | 100.0% |
| OnGo | 20/05/2016 | 10/11/2016 | 00/01/1900 | 14/11/2016 | 10/11/2021 | 7 290 299.7 | 89.6% |
| CLSD | 15/06/2016 | 07/12/2016 | 00/01/1900 | 09/12/2016 | | 11 525 616.7 | 69.9% |
| OnGo | 15/12/2017 | 11/02/2018 | 11/02/2018 | 11/02/2018 | 30/06/2022 | 3 600 000.0 | 12.2% |
| APVD | 01/04/2020 | 02/07/2020 | 13/01/2021 | 13/01/2021 | 31/12/2023 | 400 000.0 | 0.0% |
| OnGo | 21/09/2016 | 04/11/2016 | 04/11/2016 | 21/06/2017 | 30/06/2022 | 3 145 360.0 | 57.1% |
| OnGo | 28/11/2014 | 11/12/2014 | 11/12/2014 | 24/07/2015 | 30/06/2021 | 2 000 000.0 | 84.3% |
| OnGo | 17/11/2014 | 11/12/2014 | 11/12/2014 | 02/04/2015 | 31/08/2021 | 2 000 000.0 | 84.5% |
| CLSD | 23/11/2016 | 30/11/2016 | 30/11/2016 | 09/01/2017 | 31/12/2017 | 6 700 640.0 | 100.0% |
| CLSD | 15/12/2017 | 11/02/2018 | 02/10/2018 | 02/10/2018 | 31/12/2018 | 4 000 000.0 | 100.0% |
| APVD | 22/07/2020 | 27/07/2020 | 27/07/2020 | 28/09/2020 | 30/06/2022 | 7 500 000.0 | 100.0% |
| CLSD | 07/10/2013 | 01/12/2013 | 01/12/2013 | 29/08/2014 | 30/06/2016 | 740 000.0 | 100.0% |
| OnGo | 09/12/2016 | 13/03/2017 | 23/01/2018 | 23/01/2018 | 30/06/2023 | 25 000 000.0 | 1.3% |
| OnGo | 15/10/2014 | 11/12/2014 | 11/12/2014 | 15/05/2015 | 30/12/2021 | 11 500 000.0 | 68.1% |
| OnGo | 06/06/2020 | 20/07/2020 | 22/07/2020 | 22/07/2020 | 30/04/2023 | 3 324 552.1 | 88.8% |
| OnGo | 16/09/2020 | 05/10/2020 | 05/10/2020 | 17/12/2020 | 31/12/2022 | 1 500 000.0 | 0.0% |

# Annex 3: Operations Approved before 2011 and Completed/Closed during the Evaluation Period (2011-2020)

| SAP Code | Project name | Sector | |
|---|---|---|---|
| P-MR-EAZ-004 | WATER DEVELOPMENT & MANAGEMENT | Water and sanitation | |
| P-MR-HAB-003 | LINE OF CREDIT TO BCI | Finance | |
| P-MR-HAB-004 | LINE OF CREDIT TO MAUR-LEASING | Finance | |
| P-MR-AAC-007 | BRAKNA-OUEST IRRIGATION SCHEME | Agriculture | |
| P-MR-AAC-007 | BRAKNA-OUEST IRRIGATION SCHEME | Agriculture and rural development | |
| P-MR-EA0-005 | MÉRID AREA RURAL DWSS PROJECT | Water and sanitation | |
| P-MR-IE0-004 | MICROFINANCE STAKEHOLDER CAPACITY BUILDING | Social | |
| P-MR-K00-008 | PROJECT TO SUPPORT THE STRENGTHENING OF PRO | Multi-sector | |

| | Approval date | Signature date | Effective date | 1st disbursement date | Scheduled closing date | Approved amount UA | Disbursement rate |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| | 07/11/2007 | 08/05/2008 | 15/01/2009 | 15/01/2009 | 31/12/2012 | 418 452.06 | 100 % |
| | 17/07/2008 | 16/04/2009 | 02/07/2009 | 02/07/2009 | 31/12/2014 | 5 644 734.52 | 100 % |
| | 17/07/2008 | 16/04/2009 | 02/07/2009 | 02/07/2009 | 31/12/2014 | 3 527 959.08 | 100 % |
| | 17/11/2004 | 03/06/2005 | 27/07/2005 | 10/08/2005 | 31/12/2014 | 2 670 000.00 | 100 % |
| | 17/11/2004 | 03/06/2005 | 27/07/2005 | 10/08/2005 | 31/12/2014 | 4 300 000.00 | 100 % |
| | 15/11/2006 | 12/01/2007 | 19/06/2007 | 03/10/2007 | 31/12/2015 | 9 700 000.00 | 100 % |
| | 02/03/2007 | 21/03/2007 | 30/10/2007 | 02/04/2008 | 30/09/2014 | 5 980 000.00 | 100 % |
| | | | | | 31/12/2012 | | |

# Annex 4: Evaluation Criteria Rating Scale

| Evaluation criteria | Evaluation questions | Rating scale | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| | | **4. Highly satisfactory** | **3. Satisfactory** | **2. Partly unsatisfactory** | **1. Unsatisfactory** |
| **Relevance** | Was the design of the CSP **relevant** to the country's needs and strategic framework and aligned with Bank strategies? | More than 75% of the strategic objectives (pillars) of the CSPs concerned are explicitly aligned with the national priorities defined in the relevant national development policy document. | 50-75% of the strategic objectives (pillars) of the CSPs concerned are explicitly aligned with national priorities. | Less than 50% of the strategic objectives (pillars) of the relevant CSPs are explicitly aligned with national priorities. | None of the strategic objectives (pillars) of the CSPs concerned are explicitly aligned with one of the national priorities. |
| | | More than 75% of the objectives of projects approved during the period are explicitly aligned with the components defined in the relevant national development policy document. | 50-75% of the objectives of projects approved during the period are explicitly aligned with the components defined in the relevant national development policy document. | Less than 50% of the objectives of projects approved during the period are explicitly aligned with the components defined in the relevant national development policy document. | None of the objectives of projects approved during the period are explicitly aligned with one of the components defined in the relevant national development policy document. |
| | | More than 90% of the strategic objectives (pillars) of the CSPs concerned are explicitly aligned with the Bank's strategic priorities. | 50-90% of the strategic objectives (pillars) of the CSPs concerned are explicitly aligned with the Bank's strategic priorities. | Less than 50% of the strategic objectives (pillars) of the CSPs concerned are explicitly aligned with the Bank's strategic priorities. | None of the strategic objectives (pillars) of the CSPs concerned are explicitly aligned with one or other of the Bank's strategic priorities. |
| | | More than 90% of approved operations relate to one of the Bank's 30 strategic priorities. | 50-90% of approved operations relate to one of the Bank's 30 strategic priorities. | Less than 50% of approved operations relate to one of the Bank's 30 strategic priorities. | None of the approved operations relate to one of the Bank's 30 strategic priorities. |
| | | Selectivity ratio[26] => 90 | 90 < Selectivity ratio => 60 | 60 < Selectivity ratio | Selectivity ratio = 0 |
| | | Selectivity index[27] => 90 | 90 < Selectivity Index => 60 | 60 < Selectivity Index | Selectivity index = 0 |
| **Selectivity** | Were there any aspects or dimensions of the CSP that were not addressed by all operations? Were there operations not envisaged in the CSP? If yes, which ones and why? | More than 90% of the strategic objectives (pillars) of the CSPs concerned have at least one approved operation that explicitly contributes to them. | 50-90% of the strategic objectives (pillars) of the CSPs concerned have at least one approved operation that explicitly contributes to them. | Less than 50% of the strategic objectives (pillars) of the CSPs concerned have at least one approved operation that explicitly contributes to them. | None of the strategic objectives (pillars) of the CSPs concerned are explicitly supported by an approved operation. |
| **Effectiveness** | Was the CSP effective in achieving development results? What evidence demonstrates the CSP **results**? | More than 90% of the national objectives/ results of the CSPs concerned are achieved. | 50-90% of the national objectives/results of the CSPs concerned are achieved. | Less than 50% of the national objectives/ results of the CSPs concerned are achieved. | None of the national objectives/results of the CSPs concerned are achieved. |
| | | More than 90% of the strategic objectives/ results (pillars) of relevant CSPs are achieved. | 50-90% of the strategic objectives/results (pillars) of relevant CSPs are achieved. | Less than 50% of the strategic objectives/ results (pillars) of relevant CSPs are achieved. | None of the strategic objectives/results (pillars) of relevant CSPs are achieved. |

| Evaluation criteria | Evaluation questions | Rating scale | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| | | 4. Highly satisfactory | 3. Satisfactory | 2. Partly unsatisfactory | 1. Unsatisfactory |
| | | More than 90% of projects approved and completed or closed during the period provided immediate results that contribute to one strategic results (pillars) of one of the CSPs concerned. | 50-90% of projects approved and completed or closed during the period provided immediate results that contribute to one strategic results (pillars) of one of the CSPs concerned. | Less than 50% of projects approved and completed or closed during the period provided immediate results that contribute to one strategic results (pillars) of one of the CSPs concerned. | None of the projects approved and completed or closed during the period provided immediate results that contribute to one strategic results (pillars) of one of the CSPs concerned. |
| | | Over 90% of projects approved and completed or closed during the period delivered all expected outputs. | 50-90% of projects approved and completed or closed during the period delivered all expected outputs. | Less than 50% of projects approved and completed or closed during the period delivered all expected outputs. | None of the projects approved and completed or closed during the period delivered all expected outputs. |
| | | Over 90% of respondents consider that the projects met the expectations of the target population. | 50-90% of respondents consider that the projects met the expectations of the target population. | Less than 50% of respondents consider that the projects met the expectations of the target population. | None of the respondents consider that the projects met the expectations of the target population. |
| **Sustainability** | Have the CSP achievements continued and/or are they likely to continue after the end of the (significant) external assistance provided? | Target communities participated in more than 90% of projects approved and completed or closed during the period. | 50-90% of projects approved and completed or closed during the period involved target communities. | Less than 50% of projects approved and completed or closed during the period involved target communities. | None of the projects approved and completed or closed during the period involved target communities. |
| | | More than 90% of projects approved and completed or closed during the period implemented a system for sustaining the achievements. | 50-90% of projects approved and completed or closed during the period implemented a system for sustaining the achievements. | Less than 50% of projects approved and completed or closed during the period implemented a system for sustaining the achievements. | None of the projects approved and completed or closed during the period implemented a system for sustaining the achievements. |
| | | More than 90% of projects approved and completed or closed during the period implemented a revenue mobilization mechanism to finance recurrent costs. | 50-90% of projects approved and completed or closed during the period implemented a revenue mobilization mechanism to finance recurrent costs. | Less than 50% of projects approved and completed or closed during the period implemented a revenue mobilization mechanism to finance recurrent costs. | None of the projects approved and completed or closed during the period implemented a revenue mobilization mechanism to finance recurrent costs. |
| | | For more than 90% of projects approved and completed or closed during the period, the PIU is integrated into the services of the supervisory ministry. | The PIU of 50-90% of projects approved and completed or closed during the period is integrated into the services of the supervisory ministry. | Less than 50% of projects approved and completed or closed during the period have the PIU integrated into the services of the supervisory ministry. | None of the projects approved and completed or closed during the period have the PIU integrated into the services of the supervisory ministry. |
| | | More than 90% of projects approved and completed or closed during the period implemented one or more country technical or institutional capacity building activities. | 50-90% of projects approved and completed or closed during the period implemented one or more country technical or institutional capacity building activities. | Less than 50% of projects approved and completed or closed during the period implemented one or more country technical or institutional capacity building activities. | None of the projects approved and completed or closed during the period implemented a country technical or institutional capacity building activity. |

| Evaluation criteria | Evaluation questions | Rating scale | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| | | 4. Highly satisfactory | 3. Satisfactory | 2. Partly unsatisfactory | 1. Unsatisfactory |
| | | More than 90% of approved Cat. I & II projects documented the implementation of environmental and social impact mitigation measures, including those linked to related preconditions. | 50-90% of approved Cat. I & II projects documented the implementation of environmental and social mitigation measures, including those linked to related preconditions. | Less than 50% of approved Cat. I & II projects documented the implementation of environmental and social mitigation measures, including those linked to related preconditions. | None of the approved Cat. I & II projects documented the implementation of environmental and social mitigation measures, including those linked to related preconditions. |
| | | All approved Cat. I & II projects met the deadline for publication of ESIA & ESMP summaries (time between Project Appraisal Report approval and date of publication on the website). | More than 50% of approved Cat. I & II projects completed or closed during the period met the deadline for publication of ESIA & ESMP summaries. | Less than 50% of approved Cat. I & II projects completed or closed during the period met the deadline for publication of ESIA & ESMP summaries. | None of the approved Cat. I & II projects completed or closed during the period met the deadline for publication of ESIA & ESMP summaries. |
| | | More than 90% of approved Cat. I & II projects have appointed/effectively have an officer within the PIU in charge of ESMP implementation monitoring and reporting and/or the resettlement/ compensation of the affected population. | 50-90% of Cat. I & II projects approved and completed or closed during the period have appointed an officer within the PIU in charge of ESMP implementation monitoring and reporting and/or the resettlement/ compensation of the affected population. | Less than 50% of Cat. I & II projects approved 2018 and completed or closed during the period have appointed an officer within the PIU in charge of ESMP implementation monitoring and reporting and/or the resettlement/ compensation of the affected population. | None of the approved Cat. I & II projects completed or closed during the period have appointed an officer within the PIU in charge of ESMP implementation monitoring and reporting and/or the resettlement/ compensation of the affected population. |
| | | More than 90% of approved Cat. I & II projects have a budget for ESMP implementation monitoring and reporting, and the latter is effectively made available according to Bank or borrower supervision reports. | 50-90% of approved Cat. I & II projects have a budget for ESMP implementation monitoring and reporting, and the latter is effectively made available according to Bank or borrower supervision reports. | Less than 50% of approved Cat. I & II projects have a budget for ESMP implementation monitoring and reporting, and the latter is effectively made available according to Bank or borrower supervision reports. | None of the approved Cat. I & II projects have a budget for ESMP implementation monitoring and reporting, and the latter is effectively made available according to Bank or borrower supervision reports. |
| **Efficiency** | Did the CSP **efficiently** convert its inputs into benefits? | More than 90% of approved projects respected the initial budget (no overrun) | 50-90% of approved projects respected the initial budget. | Less than 50% of approved projects respected the initial budget. | None of the approved projects respected the initial budget. |
| | | More than 75% of approved projects respected the initial schedule (actual implementation duration over planned duration). | 50-75% of approved projects respected the initial schedule (no delays). | Less than 50% of approved projects respected the initial schedule (frequent delays). | None of the approved projects respected the initial schedule (systematic delays). |
| | | The average disbursement rate of approved projects is greater than or equal to 90%. | The average disbursement rate of approved projects is between 60 and 90%. | The average disbursement rate of approved projects is between 60 and 50%. | The average disbursement rate of approved projects is below 50%. |
| | | Administrative costs per UA 1 million spent decreased over the period. | Administrative costs per UA 1 million spent did not increase over the period. | Administrative costs per UA 1 million spent have increased over the course of one CSP. | Administrative costs per UA 1 million spent have increased over the period. |

| Evaluation criteria | Evaluation questions | Rating scale | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| | | 4. Highly satisfactory | 3. Satisfactory | 2. Partly unsatisfactory | 1. Unsatisfactory |
| **Effectiveness - the Bank's institutional performance** | How has the **Bank** as a development partner has performed in designing, implementing, and managing the CSP to achieve results? | All categories of stakeholders were involved at all stages of the CSP. | All categories of stakeholders were involved at one stage or another of the CSP. | Not all categories of stakeholders were involved at one stage or another of the CSP. | Only public administrations were involved in the CSP. |
| | | The proportion of professional level (PL) staff in the country office staff exceeds 50%. | The proportion of PL staff in the country office is between 15 and 50%. | The proportion of PL staff in the country office is between 10 and 15%. | The proportion of PL staff in the country office is below 11%. |
| | | More than 90% of projects are managed from the country office. | 50-90% of projects are managed from the country office. | Less than 50% of projects are managed from the country office. | None of the projects are managed from the country office. |
| | | More than 80% of approved projects have explicit objectives of promoting gender equality or empowering women. | 50-80% of approved projects have explicit objectives of promoting gender equality or empowering women. | Less than 50% of approved projects have explicit objectives of promoting gender equality or empowering women. | None of the approved projects have explicit objectives of promoting gender equality or empowering women. |
| | | Over 80% of approved projects have explicit youth employment promotion objectives. | 50-80% of approved projects have explicit youth employment promotion objectives. | Less than 50% of approved projects have explicit youth employment promotion objectives. | None of the approved projects have explicit youth employment promotion objectives. |
| | | More than 80% of the resources committed were devoted to climate change mitigation and/or adaptation.. | 50-80% of resources committed were devoted to climate change mitigation and/or adaptation. | 20-50% of resources committed were devoted to climate change mitigation and/or adaptation. | Less than 20% of the resources committed were devoted to climate change mitigation and/or adaptation. |
| | | Over 80% of approved projects have explicit climate change mitigation and/or adaptation objectives. | 50-80% of approved projects have explicit climate change mitigation and/or adaptation objectives. | Less than 50% of approved projects have explicit climate change mitigation and/or adaptation objectives. | None of the approved projects have explicit climate change mitigation and/or adaptation objectives. |
| | | More than 80% of approved projects have a climate change mitigation and/or adaptation component. | 50-80% of approved projects have a climate change mitigation and/or adaptation component. | Less than 50% of approved projects have a climate change mitigation and/or adaptation component. | None of the approved projects have a climate change mitigation and/or adaptation component. |
| | | Fragility factors were addressed in a structured manner and this analysis guided the Bank's strategic and instrument choices in all CSPs | Fragility factors were addressed in a structured manner and this analysis guided the Bank's strategic and instrument choices in all CSPs. | The analysis of fragility factors did not guide the Bank's strategic and instrument choices in one of the CSPs. | Fragility factors were not addressed and the Bank's strategic and instrument choices do not take them into account in all CSPs. |
| | | Over 80% of operations have an additional objective and (proxy) indicators that address the expected impact of operations on drivers of fragility, in addition to the usual sector objectives. | 50-80% of operations have an additional objective and (proxy) indicators that address the expected impact of operations on drivers of fragility, in addition to the usual sector objectives. | Less than 50% of operations have an additional objective and (proxy) indicators that address the expected impact of operations on drivers of fragility, in addition to the usual sector objectives. | None of the operations have an additional objective and (proxy) indicators that address the expected impact of operations on drivers of fragility, in addition to the usual sector objectives. |

| Evaluation criteria | Evaluation questions | Rating scale | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| | | 4. Highly satisfactory | 3. Satisfactory | 2. Partly unsatisfactory | 1. Unsatisfactory |
| | | More than 80% of operations have a completion and retrospective evaluation report, which includes an assessment of the project's impact and lessons to be learned in terms of fragility and resilience building. | 50-80% of operations have a completion and retrospective evaluation report, which includes an assessment of the project's impact and lessons to be learned in terms of fragility and resilience building. | Less than 50% of operations have a completion and retrospective evaluation report, which includes an assessment of the project's impact and lessons to be learned in terms of fragility and resilience building. | None of the operations have a completion and retrospective evaluation report, which includes an assessment of the project's impact and lessons to be learned in terms of fragility and resilience building. |
| | | More than 80% of objectives/results related to fragility and resilience in CSPs are achieved. | 50-80% of national objectives/results related to fragility and resilience in CSPs are achieved. | Less than 50% of objectives/results related to fragility and resilience in CSPs are achieved. | None of the objectives/ results related to fragility and resilience in CSPs are achieved. |
| | | More than 80% of approved projects completed or closed during the period delivered all expected outputs on fragility and resilience. | 50-80% of projects approved and completed or closed during the period delivered all expected outputs on fragility and resilience. | Less than 50% of approved projects completed or closed during the period delivered all expected outputs on fragility and resilience. | None of the projects approved and completed or closed during the period delivered all expected outputs on fragility and resilience. |
| | | Over 80% of approved projects have explicit private sector development objectives. | 50-80% of approved projects have explicit private sector development objectives. | Less than 50% of approved projects have explicit private sector development objectives. | None of the approved projects have explicit private sector development objectives. |
| | | More than 80% of completed operations are rated satisfactory. | 50-80% of completed operations are rated satisfactory. | Less than 50% of completed operations are rated satisfactory. | None of the completed operations are rated satisfactory. |
| **Lessons learned** | What **factors** that led to or hindered the achievement of CSP results can be drawn from the findings? | Not applicable | Not applicable | Not applicable | Not applicable |
| | What are the main **lessons** and **recommendations** that can be drawn? | Not applicable | Not applicable | Not applicable | Not applicable |
| **Coherence** | To what extent are the Bank's operations in the country complementary with each other or have synergy with the initiatives of development partners? | More than 80% of Bank portfolio operations are considered complementary. | 50-80% of Bank portfolio operations are considered complementary. | Less than 50% of Bank portfolio operations are considered complementary. | None of the Bank portfolio operations are considered complementary. |
| | | More than 80% of Bank portfolio operations have explicit complementarity links with the operations of other partners of the country. | 50-80% of Bank portfolio operations have explicit complementarity links with the operations of other partners of the country. | Less than 50% of Bank portfolio operations have explicit complementarity links with the operations of other partners of the country. | None of the Bank portfolio operations have an explicit complementarity link with the operations of other partners of the country. |

# List of Technical Annexes

**Technical annexes 5 to 12 (In French) can be found on the following page:**
https://idev.afdb.org/fr/document/mauritanie-evaluation-de-la-strategie-et-du-programme-pays-2011-2020

| | |
|---|---|
| **Technical Annex 5:** | **Theory of Change of Bank Interventions (2011-2020)** |
| **Technical Annex 6** | **Bank Portfolio Statistics in Mauritania (2011-2020)** |
| **Technical Annex 7:** | **Detailed Note on the Approach and Methods Adopted** |
| **Technical Annex 8:** | **Relevance - Alignment of Projects with National Development Strategies** |
| **Technical Annex 9a:** | **Management of IOP 2011-2015 IOP at RBCSP Approval** |
| **Technical Annex 9b:** | **Management of IOP 2016-2020 IOP at CSP Approval** |
| **Technical Annex 9c:** | **Management of the Revised IOP 2011-2015 at RBCSP Mid-Term** |
| **Technical Annex 9d:** | **Management of the Revised IOP 2016-2020 IOP at CSP Mid-Term** |
| **Technical Annex 9e:** | **Economic and Sector Work Conducted (2011-2020)** |
| **Technical Annex 10:** | **Sustainability: Environmental Category of Approved Projects (2011-2020)** |
| **Technical Annex 11:** | **Mainstreaming of Cross-cutting Aspects in Projects** |
| **Technical Annex 12:** | **Complete List of Documents Consulted** |

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# Endnotes

1 These were: 1) P-MR-AAZ-003: Emergency Humanitarian Assistance (2012); 2) P-MR-AAZ-006: Emergency Assistance to Victims of Flooding in Mauritania (2019); 3) P-MR-EB0-005: Emergency Humanitarian Assistance for Victims of Flooding in Nouakchott (2014); 4) P-MR-K00-018: COVID-19 Crisis Response Support Programme in G5 Sahel Countries - Burkina Faso, Mali, Mauritania, Niger, Chad - (PARC COVID-19 - G5 Sahel), Mauritania component (2020); and 5) P-Z1-IBE-021: Multinational Support Project for G5 Sahel Countries to Combat the Coronavirus Pandemic (2020).

2 This decision to not cover the entire period without independent evaluation was justified by IDEV's determination to: i) focus on the most recent operations which reflect the Bank's current practices; and ii) avoid recall bias of key informants. By "bias" we mean the systematic error which occurs when respondents no longer accurately remember previous events or experiences or omit details: the accuracy and quantity of memories may be influenced by subsequent events and experiences. Recall bias is a problem in studies which rely on self-reporting.

3 On the proposal of the Bank's management, the Board of Directors, on 20 April 2021, approved the 'update and extension of CSP 2016-2020' for Mauritania to December 2022 to account for the delay caused by the COVID-19 crisis in preparing the action plan for the second five-year period (2021-2025) of the implementation of the 'Accelerated Growth and Shared Prosperity Strategy' (SCAPP) 2016-2030.

4 Law No. 050/2001 of 25 July 2001 on poverty reduction makes it the reference framework for medium to long term economic and social development (by 2015).

5 United Nations Development Programme

6 The three main policy choices recommended at this on-line seminar in April 2020 comprised: short-term policies to prevent and eradicate COVID-19 pandemic; medium-term policies to re-open and rebuild economies; and long-term policies to build more resilient and inclusive economies in Africa and restore the momentum towards achieving the SDGs.

7 Combined Mid-Term Review and Portfolio Performance Review, 2016-2020, page 18

8 The priority areas (High 5s) are not indicated in appraisal reports of Bank's lines of credit operations to the *Banque Populaire de Mauritanie* (BPM) and the Bank for Trade and Industry (BCI). These operations financed loans to economic agents, mainly the country's SMEs. The High 5 of the line of credit was determined by considering the area with the highest cumulative loan envelope based on the indicative pipeline of projects presented in the annex to the project appraisal report or the Table showing the Distribution of Financing Allocated per Sector in the Expanded Supervision Report (XSR).

9 Economic Reforms and Diversification Support Programme - Phase I and II (P-MR-K00-016); COVID-19 Support Programme in G5 Sahel Countries - Burkina Faso, Mali, Mauritania, Niger, Chad - (PARC COVID-19 - G5 Sahel (P-MR-K00-018) with the World Bank and IMF; the Africa Disaster Risk Financing Programme (Mauritania component) with the African Risk Capacity Group (P-MR-A00-003).

10 The Multinational Support Project for G5 Sahel Member Countries to Combat the Coronavirus Pandemic (P-Z1-IBE-021) approved on 6 June 2020 is an ADF Grant of UA 15 million supplemented by a UA 1 million grant from TSF Pillar III resources. To complement this, on 22 July 2020, the Bank approved the Mauritanian component of the COVID-19 Crisis Response Programme in the G5 Sahel Countries (P-MR-K00-018). This budget support operation comprises a loan and grant from the COVID-19 Rapid Response Facility to these countries (Burkina Faso, Mali, Mauritania, Niger and Chad), of UA 118.9 million and UA 89.6 million respectively. Its completion report was published in December 2021 (https://www.afdb.org/en/documents/mauritania-covid-19-crisis-response-programme-project-completion-report-pcr).

11 SCAPP is broken down into strategic levers each with priority areas (see Part 2.2 of this report)

12 Information was obtained from project appraisal reports and the country's development documents (PRSP, SCAPP)

13 Including: improved knowledge, monitoring and protection of water resources; improved access to drinking water for all; improved access to water for agriculture and stockbreeding; improved access to liquid drainage services and sanitation.

14 These were aligned with the Rural Sector Development Strategy (SDSR) to 2025. This SDSR comprises five strategic thrusts (promotion of agriculture and stockbreeding, local development, participatory natural resource management, and adaptation of the legal and institutional framework for implementing the strategy).

15 Brainstorming among colleagues in operations at the Evaluation Reference Group (ERG) meeting on 22 February 2022 to validate version 10 of the summary report on the evaluation of the Bank's strategies and programmes in Mauritania from 2011 to 2020.

16 ERG meeting on 22 February 2022

17 Personal e-mail message on 23 February 2023 from Mr. Amine Mouaffak, the Bank's resident country programme officer in Mauritania

18 In the approved portfolio for the 2011-2020 period, there are 8 completed/closed projects including 2 emergency humanitarian aid operations.

19 Information is not available for the other 2 projects and emergency humanitarian aid operations are not concerned.

20 This is the project to deepen and widen the access channel to the 25 km long mineral port of Nouadhibou where all the ore extracted by SNIM from Zouérate transits (13.3 million tonnes of ore in 2016). These works will enable SNIM to increase its exports to become one of the world leaders in iron production.

21 Information is not available on the Project for Improving the Climate Resilience of Water Sector Investments with Appropriate Climate Adaptive Activities for Pastoral and Forestry Resources in Southern Mauritania (REVUWI), which is a Category II project.

22 These include: the African Development Bank (AfDB), the World Bank (WB), the French Development Agency (AFD), the European Union (EU), the Islamic Development Bank (IsDB), the Arab Fund for Economic and Social Development (AFESD), the International Fund for Agricultural Development (IFAD), the World Food Programme (WFP), the German Society for International Cooperation (GIZ), the International Monetary Fund (IMF), and the Spanish Agency for International Development Cooperation (AECID).

23 The main partners in agricultural sector development are AfDB, WB, EU, IFAD, IDB, FADES, Saudi Fund, AFD, and GIZ. Coordination between the various donors is done through thematic groups, including Agriculture, which is chaired by the Directorate of Strategy, Planning and Monitoring and Evaluation (DSPSE) of the Ministry of Rural Development.

24 Compliance with deadlines (approval/implementation/disbursement) was analyzed for each operation. Indeed, a project may have several operations and the transaction dates (approval, entry into force, disbursement) are not identical for each of the operations financing the same project.

25 The analysis unit is the operation instead of the project since the latter may be financed by several operations which do not have the same disbursement profile.

26 AfDB. (2020b). Strengthening the Bank's Selectivity and Development Focus - Guidelines for the 2020 Pilot Project. Document AfDB/BD/WP/2020/30, 18 February 2020, 28 pp. + Annexes, Implementation, Performance Management and Results Department (SNDR).

27 Idem

IDEV

Independent Development Evaluation

African Development Bank

An IDEV **Country Strategy Evaluation**

## About this evaluation

Independent Development Evaluation (IDEV) has carried out an evaluation of the Country Strategy and Program (CSP) of the African Development Bank Group ("the Bank") in Mauritania. It covers the 2011-2020 period, in particular the Results-Based Country Strategy Paper (RBCSP) 2011-2015 and the Country Strategy Paper (CSP) 2016-2020. During this period, the Bank financed 24 projects in Mauritania, worth USD 218 million, in 7 sectors of intervention: industry, mines, quarries; transport; agriculture; finance; water and sanitation; social sector; and the multisector. The purpose of this evaluation was to assess the relevance of the Bank's assistance to Mauritania, including its selectivity, the effectiveness of its strategies and programs and their contribution to the achievement of national development goals, their sustainability, internal and external coherence, efficiency, and mainstreaming of cross-cutting issues. This will enable the Bank's Management to: i) report to stakeholders the outcomes achieved with the resources provided; and ii) improve its development effectiveness by learning lessons, particularly to guide the preparation and implementation of the next Mauritania CSP for 2023-2027.

The evaluation found that all the pillars of the CSPs were aligned to the country's priorities and 87.2% of approved projects during the period had their objectives aligned with one of the components of national strategies. The relevance of the Bank's strategies and programs was therefore rated satisfactory. However, the involvement of civil society, beneficiaries, the private sector, and universities was unsatisfactory. Although these actors participated in the validation of strategic choices, they were not included at the operations level. Poverty was reduced as planned from a rate of 42% in 2008 to 31% in 2014 as well as extreme rural poverty from 40.8% to 25.1% over the same period. Furthermore, the country partly achieved the objective of a more inclusive and greener growth. This led to effectiveness being rated satisfactory. As for sustainability of the Bank's strategies and programs, it was assessed as satisfactory overall. However, there is room for improvement to ensure sustainability of achievements and mobilization of financial resources for recurrent costs in addition to the monitoring of implementation of environmental and social management measures.

Some of the recommendations for the Bank included improving the articulation between the targeted objectives at national and pillar levels and the expected results of the operations during programming and implementation. The recommendations also included ensuring that the rhythm of two supervisions per year is adhered to. Furthermore, the AfDB was recommended to foresee mechanisms that ensure the sustainability of benefits right from the design of Bank operations and monitor their effective implementation. At last, the Bank was advised to improve the mainstreaming of cross-cutting issues in the CSPs and the Bank's operations, in particular gender equality promotion and women's empowerment, youth employment, fragility and resilience, climate change adaptation and mitigation, and private sector development.

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